The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra "The White Lotus of Great Compassion"

Āryamahākaruṇāpuṇḍarīkanāmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 111 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་སྙིང་རྗེ་ཆེན་པོའི་པད་མ་དཀར་པོ་ཞེས་བྱ་བཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པོའོ།།

The White Lotus of Great Compassion, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Mahākaruṇāpuṇḍarīka Mahāyāna Sūtra and in Tibetan as Pakpa Nyingjé Chenpo'i Padma Karpo, is a Great Vehicle discourse set at the most solemn moment of the Buddha's life. It opens in the sāla grove of the Mallas near Kuśinagara, where the Blessed One tells the venerable Ānanda that he will pass into complete nirvāṇa in the last watch of that very night and asks him to prepare a resting place between the twin sāla trees. From this setting the sūtra presents the Buddha's final teachings and explains his passing as a perfect nirvāṇa in which all conditioned imagining comes to rest, framing that event through the boundless compassion of the buddhas. It is Toh 111 in the Kangyur, where it is placed among the general Mahāyāna sūtras.

In the language of India: ārya mahākaruṇāpuṇaḍarīka nāma mahāyānasūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra called The White Lotus of Great Compassion.

The first fascicle.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One (the Buddha) was staying in the city of Kuśinagara, in the sāla grove near where the Mallas dwell. Then, at the time of his complete nirvāṇa, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda:

"Ānanda, this very night, in the last watch, the Tathāgata will pass into complete nirvāṇa. Therefore prepare a bed between the twin sāla trees, on which the Tathāgata will lie on his right side like a lion.

"Ānanda, I pass into complete nirvāṇa through that perfect complete nirvāṇa in which all that is imagined as conditioned has been thoroughly destroyed.

"Ānanda, I have done the work of a buddha. I have taught the Dharma that is without abode: peaceful, utterly peaceful, supreme, excellent, profound, hard to see, hard to realize, beyond examination and unexamined, not the domain of logicians, known by the learned and the wise, the supreme and noble nectar of immortality.

"Ānanda, I have turned the unsurpassed wheel of Dharma, which no ascetic or brahmin, no māra, god, or Brahmā, nor anyone else in the world, has turned in accordance with the Dharma; I have turned it three times over, in twelve aspects. I have beaten the great drum of the Dharma. I have blown the great conch of the Dharma. I have raised the great banner of the Dharma. I have lit the great lamp of the Dharma. I have dispelled the great darkness. I have illuminated the great trichiliocosm. I have built a great ship. I have set up a great landing place. I have constructed a great bridge. I have brought many across to the far shore. I have correctly shown the path to liberation. I have sent down the great rain of the Dharma. I have satisfied gods and humans. I have tamed those to be tamed. I have struck fear into all opponents. I have cut off all the strongholds of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). I have crushed the power of Māra. I have made the abode of Māra tremble. I have roared the lion's roar. I have done the work of a buddha. I have brought to completion the deeds of a holy being. I have fulfilled my former vows. I have consecrated the way of the Dharma. I have set the great śrāvakas to their tasks. So that the way of the buddhas to come may continue unbroken, I have already given prophecies to the bodhisattvas, the great beings. Ānanda, apart from passing into nirvāṇa, nothing remains for me to do."

Then the venerable Ānanda, having heard such words from the Blessed One, became pained and unhappy, joyless, and pierced by the dart of great sorrow. Weeping bitterly, with tears streaming down, he said to the Blessed One:

"The Blessed One will pass into nirvāṇa all too soon; the Sugata will pass into nirvāṇa all too soon. The eye of the world will vanish all too soon. All too soon the world will be without a protector, without a refuge, without a guide."

Then again the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda:

"Ānanda, enough. Do not grieve. Do not lament. Whatever abides, has arisen, is conditioned and is compounded has the nature of perishing; how could it not perish? That is impossible. Ānanda, did I not teach you from the very beginning that we become separated, parted, divided, and scattered from all that is delightful, dear, and pleasing?

"Ānanda, you have attended on me with bodily acts of loving-kindness, beneficial, pleasant, undivided, measureless, and without discord. Ānanda, compared with someone who attends on gods, humans, and asuras together with their retinues, and on śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, for an eon or more than an eon, one who attends on the Tathāgata for even a single moment

gains a result far greater still. Ānanda, do not grieve. Do not lament. Ānanda, your attendance on the Tathāgata will be of great meaning, of great fruit, of great benefit, vast, like the nectar of immortality, flowing into the deathless, culminating in the deathless, and leading all the way to nirvāṇa."

Then the venerable Ānanda wiped away his tears and, still lamenting, prepared between the twin sāla trees the bed on which the Tathāgata would lie on his right side like a lion. Then the Blessed One went to where the twin sāla trees stood and lay down between them on his right side like a lion.

At the moment when the Tathāgata lay down on his right side like a lion between the twin sāla trees, throughout the great trichiliocosm all the trees, grasses, shrubs, medicinal plants, and forests, down to those only four finger-widths high, bent, bowed low, and bowed down deeply toward the place where the Tathāgata was passing into nirvāṇa.

Throughout the great trichiliocosm, all the rivers, streams, springs, lakes, ponds, wells, pools, and white-lotus waters that flow, blessed by the power of the Buddha, ceased to flow.

Throughout the great trichiliocosm, all the many birds and the many and various wild animals, by the power of the Buddha, remained without uttering a sound, and neither ate nor moved about.

Throughout the great trichiliocosm, all the light of the sun and the moon, the forms of the stars, and the light of jewels, of fire, and of fireflies, by the power of the Buddha, became invisible and did not appear; they did not glimmer, did not shine, and did not gleam.

Throughout the great trichiliocosm, all the fires of the great hells, by the power of the Buddha, were quelled; they ceased to blaze, ceased to be hot, ceased to burn, and ceased to torment. Throughout the great trichiliocosm, all those fires of the great hells were completely extinguished and became cool.

Then, at that instant, at that very moment, all the beings in the hells attained happiness by the power of the Buddha. All beings born among the animals also came to have minds of loving-kindness and minds intent on benefit. They had no malice toward one another, no violence, no contempt, and did no harm. All the beings of the world of Yama, lord of the dead, were also freed from hunger and thirst. At that instant, at that very moment, all beings, by the power of the Buddha, came to have happiness, satisfaction of body and mind, an end to the stream of suffering, and supreme happiness and mental ease.

As soon as the Tathāgata lay down on his right side like a lion, throughout the great trichiliocosm, Sumeru, the king of mountains, the Cakravāla and the Great Cakravāla, the Mucilinda and the Great Mucilinda, Gandhamādana, all the snow mountains there are, the other black mountains as well, the great earth with everything upon it, and the great oceans reaching to the edge of the encircling trench, shook in six ways: they moved and moved strongly, were stirred and stirred strongly, swayed and swayed strongly. At that time the entire disk of wind, too, did not rise up.

At that time, at that instant, at that very moment, all beings set aside their work. They were free of sleep, free of hindrance, free of obscuration, without exertion and untroubled. Their sounds grew soft, their clamor faint, and their minds undistracted.

As soon as the Blessed One lay down on his right side like a lion, all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and mahoragas, Śakra (Indra), Brahmā, and as many world protectors as dwell in this great trichiliocosm knew that their own abodes had become dim, without light and without splendor. As soon as the Tathāgata lay down on his right side like a lion, all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and mahoragas, Śakra, Brahmā, and as many world protectors as dwell in this great trichiliocosm took no delight in their own seats, pleasure groves, and celestial palaces. By the power of the Buddha, all of them, together with their retinues, became weary and disheartened.

In this great trichiliocosm there are Brahmās and Great Brahmās, conquerors who are never conquered, lords over a thousand worlds, who think, "We made these beings; we emanated these beings; we made the world; we emanated the world." Those Brahmās and Great Brahmās dwelling in the great trichiliocosm who thought this way also took no delight at all in their own seats. They knew that their own abodes, with everything in them, had become dim by the power of the Buddha. Likewise all the other Brahmās, too, knew that by the power of the Buddha their own abodes had become dim, and they took no delight in their own abodes. The world protectors, Maheśvara (Śiva), and the gods of the Pure Abodes also took no delight in their own abodes.

Then the Great Brahmā of the great trichiliocosm thought, "Of whom is it an omen that I take no delight in my own abode?" Then that Brahmā of the great trichiliocosm surveyed the entire great trichiliocosm. Having surveyed that great trichiliocosm, he thought, "The maker of this great trichiliocosm, its lord,

master, and sovereign, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, will surely pass into nirvāṇa today. That I take no delight in sitting on my own seat, and that such inconceivable and marvelous miracles as these have appeared, is the omen of his complete nirvāṇa. This is his power." He was unhappy and his heart sank; his hair stood on end. Then, surrounded and preceded by a great Brahmā retinue, he went quickly, swiftly, and in haste to where the Blessed One was.

At that time all the Brahmās of the great trichiliocosm who remained behind and had not gathered there, and however many others there were besides those Brahmās, became thoroughly tamed in the noble Dharma and came to abide in the noble Dharma.

Then the Brahmā of the great trichiliocosm went to where the Blessed One was, bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, and said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, please tell me how I should abide and how I should practice."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One said to the Great Brahmā, "Brahmā, you think, 'I am Brahmā, Great Brahmā, a conqueror who is never conquered, possessed of all knowledge, lord over a thousand worlds. I made beings; I emanated beings; I made the world; I emanated the world,' and you say so. Is that true?"

He replied, "It is so, Blessed One. It is so, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, who made you? Who emanated you?"

Then the Great Brahmā fell silent. When the Great Brahmā had fallen silent, the Blessed One said, "Brahmā, when the eon is consumed by fire, at that time this great trichiliocosm blazes, blazes fiercely, blazes everywhere, spreads everywhere and blazes, until it becomes a single flame. When that time and that occasion come about, Brahmā, did you yourself make it? Did you emanate it?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, what do you think of this great earth, which rests upon a mass of water, while the water in turn rests upon wind, and the wind in turn rests upon space, measuring sixty-eight thousand yojanas in height and not perishing? Did you make this, and did you emanate it?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so. No, Sugata, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, what do you think of the time and occasion when the young gods in the celestial palaces of the sun and moon are no longer vividly present and no longer manifest, and the palaces stand empty? Brahmā, did you make those, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "What do you think of the seasons: the hot season, the rainy season, autumn, winter, late winter, and spring? Brahmā, did you make those as well, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, consider the many kinds of reflections that appear in water, in the disk of a mirror, in a vessel of sesame oil or of butter, within jewels and crystals, or in other clear vessels. Trees, forests, parks, pleasure groves, and celestial palaces appear in them. Villages, cities, and market towns appear. Elephants, horses, camels, cattle, donkeys, sheep, wild animals, and birds appear. The moon, the sun, and the hosts of stars appear. The forms of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, bodhisattvas, and tathāgatas appear. Earth, mountains, and rivers appear. Śakra (Indra), Brahmā, the world guardians, and other beings, humans and nonhumans, appear. Brahmā, did you make those, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, in ravines, on mountains, in mountain streams, and in ponds there arise echoes of the sounds of conches, great drums, clay drums, song and dance, wild animals, birds, humans, and nonhumans, and whatever reverberations resemble them. Brahmā, did you make those as well, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, in their dreams beings see various forms, hear various sounds, smell various odors, experience various tastes, touch various tangible objects, and know various mental phenomena. They experience various joys and amusements, and they see, experience, or know shedding tears, weeping, fear, terror, and suffering. Brahmā, did you make those, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, what of the fear, unhappiness, grief, lamentation, cold, heat, hunger, and thirst of beings? Brahmā, did you make those, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, in the world of the four castes some are beautiful and some ugly, some have great wealth and some little wealth, some are destitute, some have great merit, some have good moral discipline and some corrupt discipline, some have good wisdom and some faulty wisdom. Brahmā, did you make those as well, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, beings are frightened, terrified, harmed, injured, and tormented by the dangers of weapons, fire, water, violent winds, poison, fierce beasts of prey, enemies, humans, and nonhumans, and by the many other dangers of those who do harm. Brahmā, did you make those as well, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, beings suffer many kinds of disease. Some arise from wind, bile, phlegm, or their combination, from the season, or from an imbalance of the elements. Some are inflicted by others, and some arise from the obscuration of former karma: illness of the eyes, the ears, the nose, the tongue, and the body, and the many sufferings that torment the minds of beings. Did you make those, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, what of famine, floods, wild regions, snakes, robbers, wildernesses, weapons, disease, and the intermediate eons? Brahmā, did you make those, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, beings suffer the many kinds of pain of separation, the pain of being parted from father and mother, brothers, sisters, friends, relatives, blood kin, sons, wives, and daughters. Did you make those, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Beings suffer in many ways as they toil at lowly work: selling hair, yeast, lac, and wheels, setting out upon the great ocean, entering wild and desolate lands, carrying loads in every direction, laboring at farming on a large scale, and engaging in many other activities. Brahmā, did you make those as well, did you emanate them, and did you empower them?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, consider the many kinds of virtuous and nonvirtuous karma that sentient beings take up; the hells, the animal realm and the world of Yama, lord of the dead; and the states of gods and humans that arise from their causes. Consider the misconduct and good conduct of sentient beings in body, speech and mind. Consider the paths of the ten nonvirtuous actions in the world, which do sentient beings no good, which are painful and harmful, and which make them fall into the lower realms, the bad destinies and perdition: killing, taking what is not given, sexual misconduct, lying, divisive speech, harsh speech, idle chatter, covetousness, malice and wrong view. Brahmā, were these too made by you, emanated by you and empowered by you?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, consider the sufferings that harm sentient beings: having the head cut off; having the hands, feet, ears or nose cut off, or all the major and minor limbs cut off; being burned in fire; being doused with oil; being deprived of life; being struck with swords, short spears and double-pointed weapons; being killed, bound and thrown into prison; and fighting, quarreling and disputing. Brahmā, were these too made by you, emanated by you and empowered by you?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, consider sentient beings who, because of desire and on the basis of desire, commit misconduct with their mothers, commit misconduct with their sisters, commit misconduct with those who keep moral discipline, and engage to excess in every kind of evil deed. Brahmā, were these too made by you, emanated by you and empowered by you?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, consider the various things that harm sentient beings: curses, vetālas, spells, mantras, potions, bhūtas and the sending down of grahas, and other things besides, such as administering poison; whatever

brings harm to sentient beings, deprives them of life, and cuts their life short. Brahmā, were these too made by you, emanated by you and empowered by you?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Consider the worldly conditions that cannot be avoided anywhere in the world of the four castes: birth, aging, sickness, death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, unhappiness and turmoil; the nature of impermanence, the nature of exhaustion, the nature of change; being separated from all that is dear and delightful, its ceasing to be, being parted from it and its falling apart. Brahmā, were these too made by you, emanated by you and empowered by you?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, consider the attachment, aversion and delusion of sentient beings, their obscurations, bonds, latent tendencies, entanglements and fetters, and the many other kinds of secondary afflictions that arise in them, through which sentient beings become attached, become hostile and become deluded, and through which they form the many kinds of karmic formations. Brahmā, were these too made by you, emanated by you and empowered by you?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, consider the three bad destinies, the hells, the animal realm and the world of Yama, where sentient beings experience many kinds of suffering through many kinds of torment. Brahmā, were these too made by you, emanated by you and empowered by you?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, consider the hosts of the elements, the multitudes of seeds, the grasses, the trees, the medicinal plants, the forests that grow in water and on dry land, and the many kinds of flowering trees, fruit trees and fragrant trees; and the many distinct flavors, sweet, bitter, salty, sour, pungent and astringent, the pleasant and unpleasant things that come into being and that benefit or harm sentient beings. What do you think of them? Brahmā, were they made by you, emanated by you and empowered by you?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Brahmā, consider the births, the deaths and transmigrations, the emergings, the arisings and the perishings of those who wander round in the five destinies. Brahmā, consider sentient beings veiled by the obscuration of ignorance and bound by the fetter of craving, who run on and wander, and whose beginning cannot be discerned. Brahmā, consider the unbroken stream of the path of saṃsāra yet to come, in which this world with its gods and its Brahmās, and this population with its śramaṇas and brahmins, like a tangled skein of thread, like a matted cord, come and go, running on and wandering from this world to the world beyond and from the world beyond to this world, not knowing the way out of saṃsāra. What do you think of them? Brahmā, were they made by you, emanated by you and empowered by you?"

Brahmā replied, "No, Blessed One. No, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Then, Brahmā, why do you think, 'I made these sentient beings, I emanated them, I empowered them; I made the world, I emanated it, I empowered it'?"

Brahmā replied, "Blessed One, I did not know. Because I had not abandoned the view of permanence, I fell into error. Blessed One, because I had never heard the Dharma and Vinaya taught by the Tathāgata, I came to hold this wicked view, saying, 'I made sentient beings, I emanated them; I made the world, I emanated the world.' Blessed One, I ask the Tathāgata about this very matter."

"Blessed One, who made this world? Who created this world? Who made sentient beings? Who created them? Blessed One, whose power is this? Who empowered it?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One spoke to Brahmā as follows: "Brahmā, the world is made by karma and created by karma. Sentient beings are made by karma, arise from the cause of karma, and are differentiated by karma. Why is that? Brahmā, conditioned by ignorance come formations; conditioned by formations, consciousness; conditioned by consciousness, name and form; conditioned by name and form, the six sense sources; conditioned by the six sense sources, contact; conditioned by contact, feeling; conditioned by feeling, craving; conditioned by craving, grasping; conditioned by grasping, existence; conditioned by existence, birth; and conditioned by birth arise aging and death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, unhappiness and agitation. In this way this entire great mass of suffering comes into being. And, Brahmā, with the cessation of ignorance, formations cease, and so on, up to

the cessation of this entire great mass of suffering.

"Brahmā, when the conjunctions of karma and phenomena are present, sentient beings appear to arise, and when they are free of the conjunctions of karma and phenomena, they appear not to arise. Apart from this, there is no maker here at all, no one who causes things to be made, and no one who establishes them. Brahmā, in this way, the exhaustion of karma, the exhaustion of afflictions, the exhaustion of suffering, peace through the pacification of suffering, deliverance, and complete peace are called complete nirvāṇa.

"Brahmā, apart from the exhaustion of whatever karma there is, freedom from whatever afflictions there are, and the complete pacification and setting of whatever suffering there is, what is there that is called complete nirvāṇa? Through the power of the buddhas and through the empowerment of the buddhas, such truths of the nature of reality come forth. Why is that? Brahmā, if buddhas, blessed ones, do not appear, such a Dharma is not taught. But, Brahmā, when buddhas, blessed ones, appear in the world, then, for the sake of bringing peace, they fully teach such kinds of dharmas, which are hard to realize, profound, and profound in appearance. By hearing them, sentient beings who are subject to birth are completely liberated from birth, and sentient beings who are subject to aging and death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, unhappiness and agitation are completely liberated from all of these, up to agitation.

"Therefore, Brahmā, it is like this: 'All formations are like a mirage, impermanent, unstable, not firm, not lasting, subject to exhaustion and change.' Brahmā, the buddhas taught this, explained it correctly, analyzed it and made it clear; this is the empowerment of the buddhas. Even when the true Dharma of the buddhas, the blessed ones, who have passed into complete nirvāṇa has declined, this very statement, 'All formations are like a mirage,' is their empowerment.

"If the tathāgatas had not seen all formations as like a mirage, the tathāgatas would not teach, even for an instant, a moment, a brief while, that all formations are like a dream, a mirage and an echo. Brahmā, because the tathāgatas know all formations to be like a dream, a mirage and an echo, impermanent, unstable and subject to change, the tathāgatas therefore teach that all formations are like a dream, a mirage and an echo.

"Among them there are the wise, who see its sign. Having seen its sign, through that cause, that condition and that sign as their object of focus, they realize that all formations are impermanent, and they discern: 'They are unstable and subject to change.' All formations perish and change. They perish also through times, junctures and seasons. Instants, moments, short spans and brief whiles, nights and days, months and half-months, years and hundreds of years, eons and hundreds of eons will also perish. Even a great mass of fire, having blazed, dies out. Even a great mass of water, having poured down, pours no more. Even a great mass of wind, having risen, rises no more. Even a great mass of earth, having come into being, ceases to exist. The great masses of mountains, the Cakravāla and the Great Cakravāla, Meru and Great Meru, and the other black mountains too, having come into being, become wholly nonexistent. These suns, moons and hosts of stars together with their retinues, having come into being, no longer blaze, no longer glow, no longer shine, and fall back down. Even the fine celestial palaces of the gods who dwell in the realms of the gods will perish. These villages, cities and market towns, these trees and forests, pleasure groves and delightful parks, having come into being, will also cease. These gods and humans too are born, age, die and transmigrate, and come into being again.

"These sensible and wise people, seeing that sign, think, 'Alas! All these formations are impermanent; they perish. All these formations go to nonexistence; they change. All these formations will be exhausted,' and they become disenchanted. Through that cause and that condition, these sensible and wise people go forth from home into homelessness. Having gone forth properly with faith from home into homelessness, they know all formations to be like a mirage, like a dream and like an echo, and through that sign, that object of focus and that condition, they attain awakening."

There are wise persons who see the disk of the moon appearing in water, the disk of the sun appearing there, and the forms of the stars appearing there. Then, through the instruction of the Tathāgata, or the instruction of some other spiritual friend, or the examination of their own intellect, they realize that all formations are like dreams, mirages, and echoes. Out of faith they go forth from home into homelessness. They attain the fruit of stream-entry, the fruit of once-returning, and the fruit of non-returning, and they actualize arhatship. Persons of the bodhisattva vehicle attain the first forbearance, attain the second and the third forbearance, and will attain unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

This very teaching of the Dharma of the buddhas, the blessed ones who have passed into nirvāṇa, appears in the world. By hearing it, beings will go forth through the three vehicles: the śrāvaka vehicle, the pratyekabuddha vehicle, and the unsurpassed Great Vehicle, endowed with what is supreme in every aspect.

Brahmā, in this way this too should be understood as the blessing of the buddhas. Brahmā, that wise persons see the sign, "These formations are suffering, wavering and unstable, subject to exhaustion and change; they are like dreams, mirages, and echoes," and on seeing it become truly disenchanted: this is the domain of the buddhas and the blessing of the buddhas.

Beings who practiced in the past, who have arisen from former causes, and who were to be ripened long ago, on hearing such a sound of the Dharma as this, "All these formations are impermanent, formations perish, all formations are like dreams and echoes," will have faith in the Tathāgata and will come to deep devotion.

Those beings who practiced pure conduct in the presence of the buddhas, the blessed ones, or who as householders took up the bases of training, will also, by that cause and that condition, understand formations in this way: "Formations are impermanent, formations are suffering, formations perish, formations are like dreams, mirages, and echoes." By that cause and that condition they go forth out of faith from home into homelessness, and even though buddhas, blessed ones, have not appeared in the world, through the very blessing of the buddhas and through the condition of having generated roots of virtue with the buddhas, they will attain awakening.

Brahmā, by that enumeration too it should be understood thus: this is the blessing of the buddhas, and this is the domain of the buddhas.

Brahmā, this great trichiliocosm world-system too is the buddha field of a buddha. Brahmā, this is so because formerly, when I was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, for countless hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of eons I generated immeasurable, countless roots of virtue in the presence of immeasurable, countless buddhas, blessed ones. Through hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of acts of moral discipline, austerity, pure conduct, and other hardships, so that all roots of virtue would increase and so that they would be completely purified, I took up the taming of beings in accordance with time, measure, and vessel, and so I took hold of a

buddha field and thoroughly purified it.

I gathered beings through the four means of attraction: generosity, pleasant speech, beneficial conduct, and consistency of aim. Through my very aspiration they have been born in this buddha field and understand the Dharma I teach. They will be tamed by my teaching of the Dharma, not by Śakras (Indra), not by Brahmās, not by world guardians.

Brahmā, by this enumeration too it should be understood thus: this buddha field belongs to the buddhas, the blessed ones. It does not belong to Śakras, it does not belong to Brahmās, it does not belong to world guardians, nor to others, the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), the carakas, and the wandering ascetics.

Then that Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, the Brahmā who is lord of a million worlds, and the other Brahmās as well, were stirred with weariness and renunciation, and they spoke these words: "How wonderful it is that the buddhas, the blessed ones, possess such vast qualities! How wonderful it is that the buddhas, the blessed ones, possess such marvelous qualities!"

Then that Brahmā of the great trichiliocosm came to regard the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, with wonder, and thought, "How wonderful it is that the domain of the buddhas, the blessed ones, is inconceivable and limitless!"

Then that Great Brahmā of the great trichiliocosm professed himself a disciple of the Blessed One and went for refuge to the Blessed One, saying, "Since the Blessed One is my teacher and the Sugata is my teacher, Blessed One, please tell me how I should abide and how I should practice." And he received the Blessed One's instruction.

When he had made this request, the Blessed One spoke to Great Brahmā as follows: "Brahmā, this great trichiliocosm world-system is my buddha field. This is my buddha field. Brahmā, I entrust this great trichiliocosm world-system to you. By all means follow after me, and keep this path of virtue, this way of virtue, the way of the unsurpassed Buddha, the way of the Dharma, and this way of the Saṅgha unbroken. I am the last person of this.

"Brahmā, my eldest son will come: the youth born from my heart, born from my mouth, arisen from the Dharma, emanated by the Dharma, the bodhisattva great being Maitreya, who is endowed with great compassion and desires the welfare of many people, desires their benefit, desires their happiness, and desires their success and happiness. He too will sustain this

great trichiliocosm world-system through the Dharma, just as I sustain it. So just as you act in accord with me, act in accord with him in the same way. By all means, you must keep this path of virtue, this way of virtue, the way of the Buddha, the way of the Dharma, and the way of the Saṅgha unbroken.

"Why is that? Brahmā, for as long as such a way of virtue remains unbroken, for so long the way of the Buddha, the way of the Dharma, and the way of the Saṅgha will not be broken. The way of Śakra (Indra), of Brahmā, and of the World Guardians, the way of gods and humans, and the way of liberation, up to the way of nirvāṇa, will not be broken. Therefore, Brahmā, I entrust to you this great trichiliocosm world-system, this buddhafield of the Buddha. Brahmā, this is my command to you, and this is my instruction, so you must act accordingly. I am the last person in this."

At that time, all the Brahmās and Great Brahmās dwelling in the great trichiliocosm world-system became fully tamed in the noble Dharma, all except that one Great Brahmā alone. Then that Great Brahmā, the Brahmā of a thousand worlds, was also thoroughly tamed by the Blessed One and established in the noble Dharma.

This completes the first chapter, the chapter on Brahmā.

The second fascicle.

At that time, Māra's son named Sārthavāha, who had gained faith and great devotion toward the Blessed One, heard the news that the Blessed One was about to pass into parinirvāṇa. He was pained and unhappy, joyless, and filled with great suffering and great distress of mind. Weary and dismayed, his hair standing on end, he went in great haste, as fast as he could, to where the Blessed One was. Having arrived, he bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet and sat down to one side. Seated to one side, Māra's son Sārthavāha said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, I make a request. For the sake of benefit, please do not pass into parinirvāṇa. Blessed One, holding the world with its gods in your loving care, please remain for the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, out of compassion for the world, and for the welfare, benefit, and happiness of gods and humans. Blessed One, please do not let the world all too soon become blind, without eyes, without a teacher, without a guide, without an ally, without a refuge, and without support."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One said to Māra's son Sārthavāha, "Sārthavāha, your father, wicked Māra, petitioned me, saying, 'Blessed One, pass into parinirvāṇa! Sugata, pass into parinirvāṇa! Blessed One, now the time has come for you to pass into parinirvāṇa.' Having been so petitioned, I told your father, wicked Māra, 'I shall pass into nirvāṇa.' Sārthavāha, I gave wicked Māra the occasion for my parinirvāṇa. Sārthavāha, the time has also come to do what I promised that wicked one."

When the Blessed One had said this, Māra's son Sārthavāha said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, that wicked Māra is indeed my father, but, Blessed One, he is my enemy. He is an executioner and an adversary. Blessed One, he is no friend of mine; he wishes me harm and wishes what does not benefit me. Blessed One, that wicked one wishes for me what is neither success nor happiness. Blessed One, that wicked one who wishes such a lamp of wisdom as this, such a great light of wisdom, such a great lamp illuminating primordial wisdom, to pass into parinirvāṇa is of evil intent and evil conduct. He is an enemy who brings ruin to the world with its gods, humans, and asuras.

"Blessed One, if one who speaks rightly were to say, 'A being of great evil has appeared in the world, in the world with its gods,' then, Blessed One, one who speaks rightly would be saying, 'It is Māra.' Blessed One, if one who speaks rightly were to speak of one who has set out to harm himself, set out to harm others, and set out to harm many people, then, Blessed One, one who speaks rightly would be saying, 'It is Māra.' That which is said to have set out to bring harm, injury, and suffering, what is neither success nor happiness, and a fall into wrongness to the world with its gods, its māras, and its Brahmās, and to beings with their śramaṇas and brahmins, Blessed One, one who speaks rightly would say, 'It is Māra.'

"I have heard directly from the Blessed One, and have directly grasped, what a promise in accord with the Dharma is and what a promise not in accord with the Dharma is. Blessed One, the promise that wicked Māra obtained is a promise not in accord with the Dharma. Blessed One, if you rely on this promise and regard it as essential, then, Blessed One, please remain for an eon, for the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, out of compassion for the world, and for the benefit and happiness of gods and humans. Blessed One, if you remain for a long time, that will bring benefit to many people, happiness to many people, and happiness to gods and humans. Therefore, Blessed One, holding the world with its gods in your loving care, please do not pass into parinirvāṇa so soon."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One said to Māra's son Sārthavāha, "Excellent, Sārthavāha, excellent! Sārthavāha, it is because you desire the welfare of many people, their benefit and happiness, their success and happiness, that you act in this way."

Caravan leader, there are those who serve and honor a head-anointed kṣatriya king and fill him with benefit and happiness. They devote themselves constantly and without interruption to serving and attending on the provinces, towns and regions of that head-anointed kṣatriya, and on his princes and ministers. Such people, caravan leader, obtain much wealth and great riches from the head-anointed kṣatriya. In return that kṣatriya king does them great good, and fills them with benefit, together with their sons and wives, their friends, their kinsfolk and their blood relations.

In the same way, caravan leader, if you offer such a root of virtue, born of faith, to the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, the unsurpassed King of Dharma, then, caravan leader, because you serve and attend on the Tathāgata with faith, I grant you solace. I grant you the great riches of vast roots of virtue. Caravan leader, if you generate a root of virtue with faith in the Tathāgata, I give you solace. Caravan leader, know this: through this root of virtue, this faith and this devotion, there will come such a time and such an age, after I have passed into nirvāṇa, when in the future you will become a pratyekabuddha called the Compassionate One.

Caravan leader, after I have passed away, when the true Dharma has completely vanished in every respect, there will come such a time and such an age when Māra the Evil One will be utterly gratified, delighted and pleased. Out of that great delight and gratification he will die and pass from the abode of Māra. The moment he has died and passed from the abode of Māra, he will take a body in the great hell of Avīci, and there he will experience the many kinds of Avīci's suffering. And why is that? Caravan leader, it is because he delights that so great a lamp of wisdom, so great a light of wisdom, has ceased to be.

Caravan leader, one whom a truthful speaker would describe as "bent on killing himself, harming himself, and failing to accomplish his own good" is the one that a truthful speaker should declare to be Māra. Caravan leader, why is that? It is because, as long as the true Dharma remains after I have passed into parinirvāṇa, Māra the Evil One stays in the abode of Māra. Caravan leader, the moment my true Dharma has vanished, great pleasure will arise in Māra

the Evil One, and great satisfaction, great delight, great rapture, great gratification and great happiness of mind will arise in him. In that very instant, that very moment, that very second, he will die and pass from the abode of Māra, and fall into the great hell of Avīci, the Incessant.

Caravan leader, it is like this. Suppose some man climbed a great sāla tree, laden with many flowers and fruits, and helped himself to the most delightful of its flowers and fruits, and then broke off the very branch on which he was sitting. Caravan leader, what do you think of that? Could that man stay on that broken branch? And is the man who cuts the very branch he has climbed and on which he sits at ease of a wise disposition?

He replied, "No, Blessed One. No, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Caravan leader, I consider that Māra the Evil One, who wishes the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, to pass into parinirvāṇa, and who delights in the vanishing of the Dharma and Vinaya taught by the Tathāgata, appears just like that. And why is that? Because as long as my true Dharma remains, he stays in the abode of Māra. When my Dharma has vanished, Māra the Evil One will feel joy, will be gratified and pleased, and will feel happiness of mind, and immediately he will die and pass from the abode of Māra and fall headlong into the great hell of Avīci.

"Caravan leader, it is like this. Just as that man harmed himself and others with that sāla tree, so I see that Māra the Evil One is like him. Caravan leader, Māra the Evil One is bent on harming himself. Caravan leader, Māra the Evil One is bent on harming others. Caravan leader, at that time and at that age, Māra the Evil One, having fallen into the great hell of Avīci and having experienced unbearable, burning, life-destroying feelings of suffering, will be dying, and as he experiences the feelings of the moment of death, he will remember me. He will think: 'The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, who speaks the truth, who does not speak otherwise, who does not speak falsely, said: "Restraint of body is good, restraint of speech is good, restraint of mind is good. The ripening of good conduct of body, good conduct of speech and good conduct of mind brings about what is lovely, desired, delightful and pleasing. The ripening of bad conduct of body, bad conduct of speech and bad conduct of mind brings about what is unlovely, undesired, undelightful and unpleasing." That was well spoken. In the past I was given to bad conduct of body, and I was given to bad conduct of speech and bad conduct of mind. Through the ripening of that in

me I have now been born in this great hell, and I am experiencing such unbearable, fierce, burning, unpleasing suffering, feelings that end in death and rob me of life.'

"At that time, having heard what I have well spoken, he will gain faith. Having gained faith, he will die and pass from the great hell and be born with a fortune equal to that of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. And why is that? Caravan leader, it is like this: those who conduct themselves toward the Tathāgata by obstructing him wrongfully will, because they have conducted themselves toward the Tathāgata by obstructing him wrongfully, be born in a great hell when the body breaks up."

"Sārthavāha, those who behave toward the Tathāgata with loving-kindness, and not with hostility, will be reborn among the gods, in the world of the higher realms and the happy destinies, when their bodies break apart. Through that root of virtue they will take up the practice of the Dharma of the buddhas, the blessed ones. Generating roots of virtue right there, they will gradually pass into complete nirvāṇa, with no grasping left.

"Therefore, Sārthavāha, because you have brought your mind to faith in the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, through that root of virtue, that cause and that condition, when Maitreya appears in the world, at that time and in that age you, Sārthavāha, will go forth in the teaching of the Tathāgata Maitreya. Once you have gone forth, you will urge beings who are asleep, intoxicated and utterly intoxicated, saying: 'O beings, rise up and apply yourselves! Make an effort! Exert yourselves! It is hard to come upon the appearance in the world of a tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha. Just as the flower of the udumbara tree blooms only once in a long while, so too tathāgatas appear in the world only once in a long while. Rare also is the teaching of the Dharma taught by a perfectly complete buddha, which leads to peace beyond all abiding, which leads to complete nirvāṇa. Rare too is it to see one who has gained a human body and dwells properly in the abode of the noble ones. Rare also is it to escape the eight unfree states and find such perfect leisure. So strive well and be heedful! Do not come to regret it later!'

"In this way, Sārthavāha, you will uphold and preserve the teaching of the Tathāgata Maitreya and the words he speaks in the buddha field of the Tathāgata Maitreya, the King of Dharma. You will pervade beings with a mind of pure loving-kindness that is boundless, unrivaled and blameless, and with

benefit and happiness.

"Sārthavāha, through that root of virtue, after the evil Māra has passed away, you will become Māra in the abode of Māra, a great sovereign lord (maheśvara).

"Sārthavāha, all beings who generate a root of virtue toward the Tathāgata, even a single arising of the thought, will through that root of virtue approach the deathless, incline toward the deathless, and end in the deathless.

"Sārthavāha, through that root of virtue you will enjoy the vast prosperity of gods and humans. Then, in your final existence at the end of eighty eons, when you obtain your last body, you will become the pratyekabuddha called the Compassionate One.

"Why is that? Because, Sārthavāha, when you heard the word that I would pass into complete nirvāṇa, you generated great faith in me. You also generated a mind of compassion for beings, and for the benefit and happiness of all beings you petitioned me, saying, 'Blessed One, please remain and do not pass into complete nirvāṇa.' And in the teaching of the Tathāgata Maitreya too, moved by compassion for those beings, you will rouse and exhort people who are asleep, intoxicated and utterly intoxicated, and urge them toward immeasurable virtuous qualities. Sārthavāha, this is the cause, and this is the condition, for your becoming a pratyekabuddha.

"Sārthavāha, I bestow on you such a great wealth of roots of virtue. Sārthavāha, be glad and delighted, pleased and joyful! Sārthavāha, because you petitioned the Tathāgata and had faith in the Tathāgata, the Tathāgata has given you this joy of the Dharma and this wealth of the Dharma."

When he had said this, Sārthavāha, the son of Māra, said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, even though I have made this request, if you do not consent to remain, then, Blessed One, from this day onward I make this vow and this aspiration: after the Blessed One has passed into complete nirvāṇa, for as long as the sacred Dharma remains, I, Blessed One, will not indulge in forms, sounds, smells, tastes or tangible objects. Nor will I cling to, play with or enjoy the five sense pleasures. I will not wish for other garments, nor will I use flowers, incense, garlands or ointments. Until the sacred Dharma of the Blessed One has declined, I will not partake of any other divine riches or enjoyments.

Why is that? Blessed One, it is because tomorrow morning I shall be separated from such a precious person. We shall no longer dwell together; we shall be parted and divided, and he will vanish from sight entirely. Blessed One, what would I do with joy and play? What would I do with happiness? What would I do with ease of mind? Once such a great lamp of wisdom, such a great light of wisdom, such a great illumination of primordial wisdom has passed into parinirvāṇa, Blessed One, how could I ever feel satisfaction, ease of mind, joy, delight, or great rejoicing? When such a sun of great primordial wisdom, ringed by many hundreds of thousands of rays, dispelling the darkness of ignorance, such a maker of light, has set, Blessed One, where would I find joy or happiness? If I am parted from such a precious being, where would joy and play come from?

He is the being of illumination, the being of realization, the being beyond reproach, the faultless being, the undeluded being, the supreme being, the unsurpassed being, the being with none above him, the matchless being, the unequaled being, the being equal to the unequaled, the being who liberates all beings, the excellent being, the venerated being, the being who steers others like a charioteer, the being who tames, the being who delights in helping others. He speaks truly, speaks at the proper time, speaks in due measure, speaks without error, and acts just as he speaks. He is endowed with great compassion and abides in great loving-kindness. He has no anger toward any being; his mind is equal toward all beings and free of elaboration. He is without pride, without grasping, without basis, without abode, untiring, and without stain. He is the protector, the guide, the leader, the one who leads all the way, the one who liberates completely, the one who protects completely, the one who awakens mindfulness, the one who brings realization, the one who urges on, the dispeller of sorrow, the remover of the thorn, the king of physicians who heals the mind, the giver of great medicine, the one who liberates completely from intense suffering. He is the teacher, the caravan leader who guides, the maker of the landing place, the holder of the raft, the holder of the lamp, the maker of illumination, the maker of light, the maker of clarity, the giver of sight, the one who shows the path, the one who brings beings to the land of happiness. He has abandoned all stains, all turbidity, and all knots. He is without craving and without latent tendencies, and he has utterly destroyed all knots and fetters. He is free from attachment, free from aversion, free from delusion, free from the afflictions, free from the fetters, free from pride, arrogance, and contention.

Such a great person, holy person, supreme person, heroic person, valiant person, lotus among persons, white lotus among persons, elephant among persons, lion among persons, foremost person, steadfast person, supreme person, wise person; the unsurpassed one, whose mind never wearies; who meditates in great meditation and meditates in every meditation; whose sphere of activity is all the concentrations and meditative absorptions; whose wisdom is unattached, whose wisdom is unobscured, the domain of whose wisdom is unequaled; who has lowered the banner, crossed the swamp, and stands on firm ground; who has gone beyond, who has reached the place of fearlessness, who gives fearlessness to all beings, who gives relief to the whole world: he will be parted and separated from us here tonight in the last watch. Since from then on I shall no longer see the Blessed One roaring the lion's roar, and shall no longer hear the lion's roar of the Tathāgata, Blessed One, where would I find joy or ease of mind?

Blessed One, the Tathāgata's passing into parinirvāṇa is like this. Suppose an anointed king of the kṣatriya caste dies. There are some beings who are grateful, who remember what was done for them and repay that kindness, and they, tormented by suffering, mourn there and weep for one day, or two, or three, or four, or five, or six, or seven, or for half a month or a month. In the same way, when the Blessed One has passed into parinirvāṇa, for as long as this sacred Dharma remains, I shall not indulge in forms, sounds, smells, tastes, or tangible objects. Nor shall I be attached to the five qualities of sensual pleasure, nor play with them, nor enjoy them. I shall not seek other clothing, and I shall not indulge in or enjoy flowers, garlands, incense, or ointments. Blessed One, until the sacred Dharma has disappeared, I shall not indulge in any other enjoyments either.

This concludes the second chapter, the chapter on the caravan leader.

Then Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, went to where the Blessed One was. When he arrived, he bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet and sat down to one side. Seated to one side, Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, please tell me how I should practice. Blessed One, there come such times and such occasions when the four asura lords put on their armor, draw up their battle lines, and attack the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. Whenever the gods and asuras drew up their battle lines and the four asura lords had gathered, the noble Maudgalyāyana would come, and having come, he would subdue those four asura lords in accordance with the

Dharma. Because he did so, there was no fighting between gods and asuras, no quarreling, no fault-finding, and no dispute, and all was well. But, Blessed One, Maudgalyāyana has passed into parinirvāṇa, and now the Blessed One too is about to pass into parinirvāṇa. Therefore we shall face fighting and great remorse. So, Blessed One, please tell me how I should practice when the gods, the asuras, and the four asura lords draw up their battle lines."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, it is like this. Because moral discipline is pure, the aspiration in the mind of one who has moral discipline and lives the holy life is fulfilled, not that of one who does not live the holy life. It is fulfilled for one who is free from attachment, not for one who is not free from attachment.

It is fulfilled for those who are free from aversion, not for those who are not free from aversion. It is fulfilled for those who are free from delusion, not for those who are not free from delusion. It is fulfilled for those endowed with wisdom; for those of corrupt wisdom it is not fulfilled.

Kauśika (Śakra, that is, Indra), as long as this sacred Dharma has not disappeared, Kauśika, whenever the gods and the asuras are drawn up for battle, the gods will be victorious and the asuras defeated by the mere mention of my name. From this day on I have blessed it to be so. Therefore, Kauśika, do not be unhappy, do not grieve, do not lament!"

Then the four lords of the asuras heard this declaration of the Blessed One's blessing and became dejected and unhappy. Their hair stood on end, and they went to where the Blessed One was. When they arrived, they bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet and sat down to one side. Seated to one side, the lords of the asuras said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, why have you made such a blessing?"

When they had said this, the Blessed One spoke to those four lords of the asuras: "Lords of the asuras, do not grieve, do not lament, do not fall into despondency! Why is that? Because there will come such a time, such an occasion, when you too will become lords of the gods. You will be far wealthier than the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, and without fighting, without dispute, without strife, and without opposition you will attain victory. Therefore devote yourselves to being without fighting, without fault-finding, without strife, without dispute, and without opposition, and abide perfectly in a mind of loving-kindness and a mind intent on benefit.

Friends, life does not last long, and power over wealth is impermanent. Friends, all prosperity ends in destruction. Friends, look how even the Tathāgata is brought to his end by impermanence, is exhausted, and is wholly spent. I abide in being without enmity, without fighting, without dispute, and without opposition toward all sentient beings, and I am engaged in reconciling and bringing harmony to all sentient beings; even so this befalls me. What need is there, then, to speak of you, who have small roots of virtue and delight in fighting and disputing with one another?

Friends, whoever engages in harming and injuring others will for a long time receive harm and injury. Friends, a person who takes life will be short-lived. Friends, a person who delights in fighting and dispute will always live in fear, and will neither be renowned as powerful nor have a large retinue of servants. Friends, virtuous and evil deeds are never wasted. Therefore, friends, practice toward one another a mind of loving-kindness, bodily acts of loving-kindness, verbal acts of loving-kindness, and mental acts of loving-kindness. Abide devoted to being without fighting, without fault-finding, and without dispute, and that will be for your long-lasting good, benefit, and happiness, and free of regret."

When he had said this, those lords of the asuras said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, it is so. Sugata, it is so. We shall do just as the Blessed One has said. We shall practice accordingly. We shall abide accordingly. Blessed One, from this day on we will no longer engage in battle. We will act toward one another with loving-kindness."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, grieving over the Blessed One's parinirvāṇa, weeping with tears streaming down his face, suffering, unhappy, and pierced by a great thorn of sorrow, said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, from this day on, for as long as the sacred Dharma of the Blessed One who has passed into parinirvāṇa endures, I shall not indulge in forms, and so on up to not touching tangible objects; I shall not enter my palace, and I shall not wear any other clothing. Blessed One, it is like this: when sentient beings who are grateful, who acknowledge what has been done for them, and who repay kindness lose their master, they suffer and shed tears for him. In just the same way, when the Blessed One has passed into parinirvāṇa, for as long as the Blessed One's sacred Dharma endures, I shall shed tears. I shall not indulge in the five sense pleasures, I shall not enter my palace, and I shall not wear any other clothing. Blessed One, see how tomorrow morning I am to be parted from such a Teacher, who has transcended the whole world, and will no longer

see him or be in his company!"

Having said this, Śakra, lord of the gods, sat with his head bowed as his tears flowed.

Thus concludes the third chapter, the chapter on Śakra.

Then the elder Rāhula thought: "I have no heart to witness with my own eyes the Blessed One's parinirvāṇa. If I were to see the Blessed One's parinirvāṇa with my own eyes, how could I be at peace? What satisfaction could there be, what gladness, what joy, what contentment? Therefore I shall surely go into the presence of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha called Durāsada, in the world called Radiant, which lies ten world systems beyond this one."

Then the venerable Rāhula vanished from the sal grove of the Mallas near Kuśinagara and went toward the northeast, to where the Tathāgata Durāsada was. On arriving, he bowed his head at the feet of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Durāsada, and sat down to one side. When he was seated to one side, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Durāsada spoke to the suffering and unhappy venerable Rāhula:

"Rāhula, do not grieve, and do not lament! And why? Rāhula, from all that is dear and pleasing we come to be divided. We are parted, separated, and torn away from it. Rāhula, that the buddhas, the blessed ones, pass into complete nirvāṇa once they have carried out the deeds of a buddha is the nature of reality. Rāhula, the Blessed One Śākyamuni, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, lies like a lion on his right side between a pair of śāla trees in the śāla grove where the Mallas dwell. In the last watch of this very night he will pass into complete nirvāṇa, into the realm of nirvāṇa in which no remainder of the aggregates is left. Therefore, Rāhula, go there. You must certainly be present there, so go, Rāhula! Otherwise you may come to regret it once the Blessed One has passed into complete nirvāṇa."

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Rāhula said this to the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Durāsada: "Blessed One, if I cannot even bear to hear the words 'the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha will pass into complete nirvāṇa in the last watch of this very night,' what need is there to speak of seeing with my own eyes the Blessed One's passing into complete nirvāṇa? Therefore, Blessed One, I have no wish to go there."

Then the venerable Rāhula did not heed the word of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Durāsada, and vanished from that buddha-field.

In the upper direction, in the tenth world-system counting outward in order, there dwells the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha called Sārthavāha, who remains, lives, and sustains himself there. Then the venerable Rāhula went to where the Tathāgata Sārthavāha was. When he arrived, he bowed at the feet of the Tathāgata Sārthavāha and wept, his face streaming with tears. Lamenting, he sat down to one side. When he had sat down to one side, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Sārthavāha said this to the venerable Rāhula:

"Enough, Rāhula! Do not be unhappy, do not grieve, and do not lament! Rāhula, how could it ever be that what is subject to birth would not be born, what is subject to aging would not age, what is subject to sickness would not fall ill, what is subject to death would not die, and what is subject to exhaustion would not be exhausted? Rāhula, such a state is not to be found. Rāhula, all the buddhas of the past and all the śrāvakas of those buddhas grew peaceful, departed, and passed into complete nirvāṇa. All the buddhas, the blessed ones, of the future, and all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, will also pass into complete nirvāṇa. All the tathāgatas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas who dwell at present will also pass into complete nirvāṇa. Rāhula, even one who remains for an eon, or for a hundred eons, must certainly pass into complete nirvāṇa.

"Rāhula, for the buddhas, the blessed ones, there is no other nature of reality and no other state apart from utter pacification. Rāhula, 'utter pacification' means utterly peaceful, utterly cooled, utterly final, utterly blissful, utterly accomplished and blissful: that is to say, the baseless realm of nirvāṇa.

"Rāhula, birth is suffering, aging is suffering, sickness is suffering, death is suffering, being parted again and again from those one loves is suffering, keeping company with those one does not love is suffering, and carrying the burden of the aggregates is suffering. Rāhula, those who have passed into complete nirvāṇa are at ease. Therefore, Rāhula, you too should pass into complete nirvāṇa.

"The Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, will also pass into complete nirvāṇa, where there is no birth, no aging, no sickness, no death, no parting from those one loves, no meeting with those one does not love, and no suffering or unhappiness. Both of you have come to aspire to that state.

Therefore, Rāhula, do not be unhappy, do not grieve, and do not lament! Rāhula, recollect the nature of reality! Apart from wrongly and invertedly grasping at what is unreal, what birth is there in this? What aging is there in this? What death is there in this? What transmigration is there? What arising is there?

"Rāhula, childish ordinary beings have not heard the teaching. They have not seen the noble dharmas, have not trained in the noble dharmas, are not skilled in the noble dharmas, do not abide in the noble dharmas, and have not been disciplined by the noble dharmas. Because they do not know the noble dharmas, they are inverted in perception and inverted in view. Being so inverted, they come to birth, aging, sickness, death, transmigration and arising. They run about and wander in saṃsāra, crave, decline, and fall into unhappiness, sorrow, lamentation and the beating of their breasts.

"Rāhula, in this noble Dharma and Vinaya, since all formations are pacified, there is nothing further left to be done. Rāhula, whatever a śrāvaka of the Teacher, a son of the Blessed One, has to do, you have already done. Rāhula, the Teacher, the Blessed One, has also already done whatever was to be done for the śrāvakas, and there is nothing further for him to do. Therefore, Rāhula, do not grieve now, do not be unhappy, and do not lament. Rāhula, go to the Blessed One Śākyamuni, that great king of the Śākyas, to see him for the last time, to pay him homage, and to serve him! Otherwise you may come to regret it later. Rāhula, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni is at this very moment lying like a lion on his right side in the śāla grove where the Mallas dwell, and he wishes to see you too. Therefore, Rāhula, you must certainly be present there."

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Rāhula said this to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Sārthavāha:

"If I have no wish even to hear such words as 'The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni is passing into complete nirvāṇa,' what need is there to speak of seeing that Blessed One pass into complete nirvāṇa? Blessed One, on hearing those words, 'The Blessed One Śākyamuni, king of the Śākyas, is passing into complete nirvāṇa,' my body has grown faint. Blessed One, he is the precious being who wishes to benefit the whole world. He benefits the whole world and holds it in his love. He is the lamp of the whole world, unequaled by anything in the world, the one who brings light to the whole world, the eye of the whole world, the one who

illumines with the great lamp of wisdom. Tomorrow morning I shall be parted and separated from such a one, and no longer in his company. How shall I bear it?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Sārthavāha, said to the venerable Rāhula, "Enough, Rāhula, do not lament. Rāhula, did that Blessed One not teach the Dharma from the very beginning: all formations are impermanent, all formations are suffering, all phenomena are without self, and nirvāṇa is peace? Rāhula, did that Blessed One not also say:

All formations are impermanent;
Their nature is to arise and perish.
Having arisen, they come to cease;
Their stilling is called bliss."

Rāhula replied, "Blessed One, it is so. Sugata, it is so."

The Blessed One said, "Did that Blessed One not teach from the very beginning that we become different from all that is dear and pleasing, depart from it, are parted and separated from it, and that however long it may last, it will surely decline?"

Rāhula replied, "Blessed One, it is so. Sugata, it is so."

He said, "Rāhula, whatever is born and has come into being, whatever is compounded, thought up, arisen from conceptualization, and dependently arisen, how could it not perish? There is no such possibility."

Then the venerable Rāhula, recollecting his father, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni, shed tears through the force of the Dharma. "Tomorrow morning I shall not see the Blessed One with the Saṅgha of monks arrayed before him, teaching the Dharma. Like Sumeru, king of mountains, rising up from the ocean and standing out in majesty; adorned with a hundred marks, like the full moon ringed by stars; like the sun with its thousand rays shining clear in the sky; deep and immeasurable like the ocean, holding a multitude of jewels; surrounded by many retinues like a universal monarch; like the king of snow mountains, all in bloom with the flowers of the faculties, the powers, and the limbs of awakening; unshaken by any opponent, like the great encircling mountain range; untainted by any worldly concern, like a lotus that, though it rests within a lake, is untouched by it; like Brahmā within Brahmā's assembly; seated on the lion throne like Śakra (Indra) of the thousand eyes; roaring the lion's roar without fear or dread, like a lion. From

now on I shall not see him." When the venerable Rāhula had said this, he wept, and with his heart sunk in grief he remained silent.

Then the Tathāgata Sārthavāha said to the venerable Rāhula, "Rāhula, go into the presence of that Blessed One. That Blessed One wishes to see you, so, Rāhula, go, and do not disregard my words. Do not leave that Blessed One's body wearied. Rāhula, you must certainly stay there. Why is that? Rāhula, it is the nature of things that the buddhas, the blessed ones, certainly do not pass into complete nirvāṇa while there is anyone whom the Tathāgata pervades with loving-kindness, whom he holds in mind and longs for; at such a time they will certainly remain. Rāhula, that Tathāgata wishes to see you, so go, and you must certainly stay there."

Then the venerable Rāhula bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Sārthavāha. And just as a strong man might stretch out his bent arm or bend his outstretched arm, in that same moment the venerable Rāhula vanished from the buddha field of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Sārthavāha, and went to where the Blessed One was, near Kuśinagara where the Mallas dwell, in the sāla grove, between the twin sāla trees. On arriving, he bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated him three times, and, weeping and lamenting, with tears flowing, joined his palms and sat to one side.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Rāhula, "Come here, Rāhula. Rāhula, do not be unhappy, do not weep, do not lament, do not lose heart. Rāhula, you have done a father's duty toward me, and I too have done a son's duty toward you, my son. Rāhula, thus I have done a father's duty, and you too have done a son's duty. We have both done what was to be done and completed the task, so, Rāhula, do not grieve, do not lament, do not lose heart. Rāhula, consider how we two set out to bring fearlessness to all beings, and set out free of enmity, free of rivalry, free of reproach, and free of harm. And now I remain only in order to pass into complete nirvāṇa, and from now on I shall be no one's father. Rāhula, you too, once you have passed into complete nirvāṇa, will from then on be no one's son. Rāhula, consider how we two dwell without harming or opposing any being."

Then the venerable Rāhula said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, please do not pass into parinirvāṇa! Sugata, please do not pass into parinirvāṇa! Blessed One, for the welfare and happiness of many people, out of compassion for the world, and for the good, benefit, and happiness of

gods and humans, please remain for an eon!"

When he had made this request, the Blessed One said to the venerable Rāhula: "Rāhula, there are qualities whose possession causes one to be counted in the world as a tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha. Those qualities, Rāhula, are not exhausted. They do not grow old, are not born, do not go, do not come, do not arise, do not cease, do not come into existence, do not perish, do not remain, do not sit, do not lie down, and are neither joined nor disjoined. Why is that? Rāhula, that dharma is abiding. It is utterly non-arising, utterly unborn, utterly unceasing, utterly empty, utterly without birth, and utterly without essential nature. It is fully at peace, beyond number, without basis, inexpressible, and beyond the reach of speech.

"Rāhula, this is the nature of reality of the buddhas, the blessed ones. It is utter abiding, full peace, utter solitude, utter freedom from attachment, utter cessation, utter unmixedness, utter unmadeness, and utter inexhaustibility. Rāhula, it was with this in mind that I said: 'Whether tathāgatas appear or tathāgatas do not appear, the abiding of the Dharma of phenomena, the nature of phenomena, the certainty of phenomena, the freedom from attachment of phenomena, and the essential nature of phenomena simply abide.'

"Rāhula, the Tathāgata does not pass into parinirvāṇa taking the aggregate of moral discipline with him. Nor does he take the aggregate of meditative absorption, nor the aggregate of wisdom, nor the aggregate of liberation. He does not pass into parinirvāṇa taking the aggregate of the knowledge and vision of liberation with him.

"Rāhula, do not be unhappy. Do not lament. Do not give rise to despair. Rāhula, all formations are impermanent, unstable, offering no comfort, not everlasting, and subject to exhaustion and change. Therefore, Rāhula, it is right to become weary of all formations, right to be unattached to them, and right to be liberated from them. Rāhula, this is my instruction to you."

When they had fully understood this chapter on seeing the truth, which the Blessed One spoke to Rāhula, about sixty elder monks were freed from the defilements without further grasping, and their minds were liberated. For countless gods and humans, the eye of Dharma regarding phenomena was purified, free of dust and stainless. Sixty-eight thousand bodhisattvas attained acceptance that phenomena are unborn. All of them uttered this inspired utterance: "Oh, the Buddha! Oh, the Buddha! Oh, the qualities of the Buddha

are inconceivable!" They scattered utpala, padma, kumuda, and white lotus flowers over the Blessed One. Having strewn them, they spoke these words: "May we too, in a future time, appear in the world as a teacher such as this! May we teach the Dharma like this! May we pass into parinirvāṇa with a great parinirvāṇa of a buddha such as this, one that is unsurpassed and unlike anything in all the world!" Having said this, those bodhisattvas fell silent.

This concludes the chapter on Rāhula, the fourth chapter.

The third fascicle.

At that time the venerable Ānanda was leaning against the couch at the Blessed One's side, weeping, his tears flowing as he lamented. Then the venerable Ānanda, weeping with tears streaming down, fell to the ground like a great tree that has been cut down and felled, and cried: "The Blessed One's parinirvāṇa comes far too soon! The Sugata's parinirvāṇa comes far too soon! Far too soon the Compassionate One will be with us no longer! Far too soon the Precious Being will be with us no longer! Far too soon the great lamp will vanish from the world! Far too soon the great torch will vanish from the world! Far too soon the Supreme One of the world will cease from the world! Far too soon the Precious Being, the white lotus among beings, will vanish from the world! Far too soon the wise being, the one who is tamed and who tames untamed beings, will be gone from the world! Far too soon the caravan leader, the Teacher who shows the path to happiness, will vanish from the world! Far too soon the great eye that reveals the light of wisdom will vanish from the world! Far too soon the father and mother of beings will vanish from the world! Far too soon the world will become blind! Blessed One, far too soon the world will be without a protector and without a guide! Behold, from tomorrow morning only a name will remain, and the Precious Being will be seen no more!"

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, enough! Do not grieve, do not lament. Ānanda, did I not explain from the very beginning that we are separated, parted, divided, and severed from all that is dear and pleasing? Ānanda, how could whatever is born, has come into being, is conditioned, is intended, is dependently originated, and is subject to destruction not be destroyed? That is impossible. It is impossible that such things should remain and not vanish. Ānanda, however long something may remain, it is certainly subject to final nirvāṇa. Therefore, Ānanda, do not grieve, do not lament."

Then the venerable Ānanda gazed unblinking at the Blessed One's face and fell to the ground like a tree that has been cut down and felled. A second time the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, enough! Do not grieve, do not lament. Ānanda, this aim is not easily won by grieving and lamenting."

I told you from the very beginning that one becomes separated and parted from all that is dear and pleasing. However long formations may last, they are by nature certain to change. Ānanda, you have served the Tathāgata with loving deeds of body that were beneficial, pleasant, nondual, measureless, boundless and unrivaled, and with loving deeds of speech and loving deeds of mind, likewise pleasant and so on up to unrivaled."

Then the venerable Ānanda rose, wiped away his tears, and said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, I am to be parted from so precious a being. He has great compassion, surpassing all the world. He wishes to benefit all the world. He is loving toward all the world. He holds all the world dear. He is the Teacher of all the world, the guide of all the world, the giver of benefit and happiness to all the world. If tomorrow morning I am to be separated and parted from so great a being, how could I not grieve? How could I not lament?"

Then the venerable Ānanda shed many tears, wiped them away, and spoke these words once more: "Alas, that so great a lamp, so great a torch, so great a light should vanish from the world! Here is the great sun of wisdom, encircled by many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of rays, all-radiant, all-illuminating, all-blazing, all rays and all-discerning, all-seeing and all-knowing, all wisdom and all mindfulness, whose domain is everything, a being made wholly of light, so great a light of wisdom. The formations through which such a one sets in the world are treacherous; they are deceitful.

"Alas, all too swiftly does the maker of light vanish from the world! All too swiftly does the protector of the world with its gods vanish! Alas, since the Blessed One with his miracles vanishes from the world all too swiftly, Blessed One, how could I not grieve? Blessed One, how could I not lament? Blessed One, it is a great wonder that my heart has not burst into a hundred pieces. It is a great wonder that I have not died here before the Blessed One. Blessed One, I think of this: 'It is by the Blessed One's blessing that I have not died.' And why? The eighty-four thousand collections of the Dharma that I received directly from the Blessed One, that I thoroughly mastered and fully retained, have not yet benefited many people and have not yet spread in many

directions. Therefore, Blessed One, I think, 'That I have not died is the Blessed One's power.' Blessed One, how could I not grieve? Blessed One, how could I not lament?

"Blessed One, when I go to the city of Kapilavastu, the place where the Blessed One was born, shall I say to the assembled Śākyas, 'Śākyamuni, king of the Śākyas, has passed where he will never appear again'? Or what shall I say? When I go to the city of Rājagṛha, shall I say to King Ajātaśatru, son of Vaidehī, 'The perfectly complete Buddha, the great sun of suns, has set; that great king of physicians, who draws out the thorn of the deeds of immediate retribution, has departed'? Or what shall I say? When I go to the great city of Śrāvastī, shall I say, 'He who had attained great compassion, who wished to benefit, who was loving toward the world, has vanished'? Or what shall I say? Shall I say to Anāthapiṇḍada, 'Will the Tathāgata ever again dwell in the Jeta Grove, the park of Anāthapiṇḍada?' Or what shall I say? When I go to the great city of Vaiśālī, shall I say before the assemblies of the Licchavis, 'The caravan leader who wished to benefit has set'? Or what shall I say? To the sons and daughters of good family who come from all the directions and intermediate directions to put their questions, shall I say, 'He who possessed great knowledge, who knew the dispositions of all the world, the wise one who dispelled every doubt that was put to him, has set'? Or what shall I say? To the monks who have kept the rainy season retreat in all the directions and intermediate directions, and who come to see the Blessed One, to bow to him, to serve him, to question him and to inquire, the Blessed One spoke talk in accord with the Dharma, he who had realized the superhuman qualities. If the Blessed One no longer remains, I shall not see him, I shall not hear him. If such a holy life, with its miracles, vanishes from the world, Blessed One, how could I not grieve? How could I not lament?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Enough, Ānanda, do not grieve, do not lament! Ānanda, my holy life, which has benefited many people, which is vast and extensive among gods and humans, and which has been received by the world with its gods, will endure for a long time. Ānanda, after I have passed into complete nirvāṇa, you two, the monk Kāśyapa and you, Ānanda, will for a little more than forty years carry on that holy life with its miracles, received by gods and humans each in their turn. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, do not lament! My holy Dharma, which has benefited many people and become vast and extensive among gods and humans, will endure for a long time. Ānanda, after I have passed away, you

two, the monk Kāśyapa and you, will devote yourselves to making this unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, which I accomplished over countless hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of eons, and this precious jewel, my virtuous Dharma, flourish and never decline. And why is that? Ānanda, the monk Kāśyapa has few desires, is content, lives in seclusion, has taken up diligence, has mindfulness closely established, delights in freedom from conceptual elaboration, is settled in meditative equipoise, and is sharp in wisdom. Ānanda, the monk Kāśyapa rightly teaches many people, rightly leads them to take up the teaching, rightly inspires them, and rightly delights them, and he never tires of teaching the Dharma to all his companions in the holy life.

"Ānanda, the monk Kāśyapa is like a father and mother to the fourfold assembly. Ānanda, the monk Kāśyapa has long watched over the world and is full of tender compassion. Ānanda, the monk Kāśyapa has set out for the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, out of compassion for the world, and for the welfare, benefit and happiness of gods and humans."

Ānanda asked, "Blessed One, to what extent has the monk Kāśyapa set out, delighting in the welfare of so many people and delighting in the benefit and happiness of gods and humans?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, when the monk Kāśyapa passes into complete nirvāṇa, he will make this resolve: 'After I have passed into complete nirvāṇa, until the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened Buddha Maitreya appears in the world, may my body not change. May my robes, my body hair, my head hair, my skin, my complexion and my faculties not change. May my body and all its limbs not change. When the Tathāgata Maitreya has appeared in the world, may that Tathāgata, together with his first assembly, likewise his second assembly, and likewise his great third assembly, see my body undecayed. Relying on my teaching of the Dharma, through my blessing, and by focusing on me, may many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, and many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of living beings be tamed. When the Tathāgata Maitreya and the three assemblies of śrāvakas, with undistracted faculties and their robes worn properly, have seen my body undecayed, may my body then rise up into the sky and be consumed by the body's own fire element. And may not even the cinders of that burning remain visible.' So he will think.

"Ānanda, the monk Kāśyapa, who will make such a resolve, has thus set out in order to bring sentient beings to maturity, for the benefit of many people in this way, and for the happiness of many people in this way.

"Ānanda, after the monk Kāśyapa has passed into complete nirvāṇa, four rocky mountains will come together, enclose Kāśyapa's body, and remain joined as one. Ānanda, within those four rocky mountains the body of the monk Kāśyapa will remain solid and undecayed. For as long as the Tathāgata Maitreya has not appeared in the world, the body of the monk Kāśyapa will remain undecayed, together with its robes.

"Why is that? Ānanda, it is like this. Because moral discipline is pure, the aspiration of the mind of one who possesses moral discipline and lives the holy life is fulfilled, and not that of one who does not live the holy life. It is fulfilled for one who possesses wisdom, not for one whose wisdom is corrupt. It is fulfilled for one who is free of attachment, not for one who is not free of attachment.

"Therefore, Ānanda, through his earlier resolve, after the monk Kāśyapa has passed into complete nirvāṇa, until the Tathāgata Maitreya appears in the world, his body will not change. His head hair, body hair, flesh, blood and skin, his other limbs and lesser limbs, his faculties and his robes will not change, and his body will have no foul odor.

"Then, Ānanda, after the Tathāgata Maitreya has appeared in the world, he will go, together with nine hundred and sixty million monks of his first assembly, to where Kāśyapa's body rests. Then, Ānanda, the Tathāgata Maitreya will show the body of the monk Kāśyapa to those nine hundred and sixty million monks and will say this:

"'Monks, this is the great śrāvaka of the Blessed One Śākyamuni, the monk called Kāśyapa. He is the foremost of those who abide in the ascetic qualities, of those of few desires, of the content, of those who dwell in solitude, of those who have undertaken diligence, of those with mindfulness established, of those in meditative equipoise, and of those possessed of wisdom. He is devoted to the absence of conceptual elaboration and delights in the absence of conceptual elaboration. He rightly teaches many people, rightly leads them to take it up, rightly inspires them, and rightly gladdens them; he is tireless in teaching the Dharma to his companions in the holy life. Monks, the monk Kāśyapa has been like a father and mother to the fourfold assembly, watching over them long, watching over them closely, watching over many people.

Monks, look at this monk Kāśyapa, who set out for the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, out of compassion for the world, and who set out for the welfare, benefit and happiness of gods and humans.'

"A second time also, the Tathāgata Maitreya will go to that place together with nine hundred and forty million śrāvakas. Ānanda, a third time also, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened Buddha Maitreya will go, together with nine hundred and twenty million śrāvakas, to the place where the body of the monk Kāśyapa rests. And, Ānanda, that Tathāgata Maitreya will show the body of the monk Kāśyapa to those nine hundred and twenty million monks: 'Monks, this one called the monk Kāśyapa is the great śrāvaka of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, the foremost of those who uphold the ascetic qualities,' and so on, from 'of few desires and content' up to 'look at him, who set out for the benefit and happiness of many people and of gods and humans.'

"Ānanda, then at that time the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened Buddha Maitreya will stretch out his golden right hand and stroke the head of Mahākāśyapa. Having stroked it, he will look upon the Saṅgha of monks. Having looked upon them, he will say this:

"Monks, the monk Kāśyapa upheld the true Dharma of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, who passed into parinirvāṇa. Now, in this great Saṅgha of my monks, there is not even one monk who will teach the true Dharma in that way once I have passed into parinirvāṇa." This is what he will declare.

Ānanda, then, in that same third great assembly, through his earlier blessing, the monk Kāśyapa will rise up into the sky above and display many kinds of miracles. His own fire element will burn his own body, and of that burning neither charcoal nor ash will be seen.

Ānanda, then the Tathāgata Maitreya will take the monk Kāśyapa as his occasion and teach the Dharma to those ninety-six koṭis of monks. He will teach it in just the way that will tame many hundreds of beings, many thousands of beings, many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of beings, and all people, gods and humans alike.

Ānanda, see how the monk Kāśyapa has set out to benefit many people. Ānanda, you too have set out for the benefit and happiness of many people, and you will continue to do so. Ānanda, in this way you and the monk Kāśyapa, the two of you, will uphold this true Dharma of mine for a little more than forty years. The holy life, together with its miracles, will be practiced and will

become vast and widespread among gods and humans.

The fifth chapter, the chapter on Kāśyapa, is complete.

Then again the Blessed One spoke to Ānanda: "Ānanda, do not grieve," and so on in full, up to: "Ānanda, your holy life will benefit many people. It will be practiced, vast and widespread among gods and humans, and rightly received."

"Ānanda, after I have passed away and passed into parinirvāṇa, in the city of Mathurā there will be a mountain called Lofty Peak of Great Slopes. There will be a park of the Saṅgha there called Naṭabhaṭika, and there a monk called Land Mender will appear. He will have great miraculous power and great might. He will be illustrious, disciplined and fearless, very learned, a holder of the sūtras, a holder of the Vinaya, and a holder of the Mātṛkā. He will rightly teach, rightly lead others to take up the Dharma, rightly inspire them, and rightly delight them, and he will be tireless in teaching the Dharma to his companions in the holy life. He too will make this holy life, with its miracles, vast and widespread among gods and humans. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, on that same Lofty Peak of Great Slopes, in that same park of the Saṅgha called Naṭabhaṭika, a monk called Joyous will appear. He will have great miraculous power and great might, and so on, up to: tireless in teaching the Dharma to his companions in the holy life. He too will make this teaching of mine broad and flourishing, and gods and humans will rightly receive it. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, on that same Lofty Peak of Great Slopes there will be a mountain called Uśīra. Forty-four thousand monks will gather there. Every one of them, without exception, will have great miraculous power, great might, and renown for great mastery. They will be illustrious, disciplined and fearless, very learned, holders of the sūtras, holders of the Vinaya, and holders of the Mātṛkā. They will rightly teach many people, rightly lead them to take up the Dharma, rightly inspire them, and rightly delight them. They too will make this holy life, with its miracles, flourish, and make it vast and widespread among gods and humans. Ānanda, my holy life will flourish, so, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, on that same Lofty Peak of Great Slopes a monk called Upagupta will appear. He will have great miraculous power and great might, and so on, up to: he too will make this holy life, with its miracles,

broad and flourishing, and gods and humans will rightly receive it. Many arhats of mine will gather there as well: eighty-eight thousand monks will appear there who share a single poṣadha ceremony, free of pride, possessed of perfect knowledge, and skilled in explaining. They too will practice my holy life with its miracles, and make it broad and vast among gods and humans. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament. Ānanda, the monk Upagupta will practice my holy life broadly and vastly, and will rightly teach it to gods and humans.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, in the city called Pāṭaliputra there will be a park of the Saṅgha called the Path. There a monk called Aśvagupta will appear. He will possess the three knowledges and the six superknowledges, will meditate on the eight liberations, and will be liberated in both ways. He will have great miraculous power and great might, and so on, up to: he too will make this holy life broad and flourishing. This is to be applied in full in every case. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, in that same place, at the Kukkuṭārāma, a monk called Uttara will appear. He will have great miraculous power and great might, and so on, up to: he too will make this teaching full of miracles, and will spread it broadly and abundantly among gods and humans, each in their own place. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament. And why is that? Ānanda, it is because my holy life will flourish and become broad and vast among gods and humans.

"Ānanda, after I have passed into parinirvāṇa and passed away, in the land called Aṅga a five-yearly festival will be held for the śrāvakas. Thirteen thousand arhats will gather there. Every one of them, without exception, will have great miraculous power, great might, and renown for great mastery, and so on at length, up to: every one of them tireless in teaching the Dharma to his companions in the holy life."

"There will be an elder of the Saṅgha there called Faithful the Sixth. He will have great miraculous power, great might, and renown for great mastery, and so on at length, up to: tireless in teaching the Dharma to his companions in the holy life. He too will make my holy life, together with its miracles, flourish among gods and humans. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, in the city called Golden Measure two monks will appear who have gone forth from brahmin families: one called Learned, and one called Sañjayin. They will have great miraculous power,

great might, and renown for great mastery, and so on, up to: the two of them too will make this holy life, together with its miracles, flourish. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, in the city called Abode a monk called Mahāvīrya will appear. He will have great miraculous power and great might, and he too will make this holy life, together with its miracles, flourish among gods and humans. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, in a future time a monk called Madhyāntika will appear. Ānanda, the monk Madhyāntika too will make this Dharma and Vinaya of mine flourish, and will make it, together with its miracles, broad and vast among gods and humans. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, in the northern region, in the land called Gandhāra, a monk called Kāśyapa will appear. He will have great miraculous power, great might, and renown for great mastery. He will be clear-minded and fearless, very learned, a holder of the Vinaya, a holder of the sūtras, a holder of the Mātṛkā. He will instruct, inspire others to take up the teaching, fire them with enthusiasm, and fill them with delight, and so on, up to: he too will make my teaching flourish. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, in the northern region there will be a city called Stone Setting, renowned in all the directions and intermediate directions. There a householder called Jaṭila will appear: rich, of great wealth and great possessions, endowed with merit, endowed with wisdom, handsome and beautiful, pleasing to behold, with a fine and radiant complexion of the highest kind, full of faith and devotion. He will delight in showing reverence, esteem, service, worship and offerings to my remains and to the śrāvakas. Having gradually perfected the accumulations for awakening, and so on, in a future time, when a thousand eons have been completed, he will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. In the eon called Excellent Making, in a world realm beautifully adorned with great arrays, he will become the Tathāgata called Samantāvabhāsa. Ānanda, the householder Jaṭila too will make this teaching of mine flourish among gods and humans. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament.

"Ānanda, after I have passed away, in the northern region there will be a royal city called Prosperous, wealthy, thriving, peaceful, with good harvests, and full of many people and inhabitants. There the brahmins and householders will

have faith in this teaching of mine and their minds will be filled with devotion. Ānanda, they too will delight in showing reverence, esteem, service, worship, offerings and honor to my body that has passed into nirvāṇa and to the śrāvakas. There too many hundreds of my śrāvakas will gather, with great miraculous power, great might, and renown for great mastery; this should be supplied at length.

"Ānanda, most of the householders who live there will be clear-minded, gentle and fearless, very learned, having amassed learning, skilled and of great wisdom. Ānanda, in the royal city of Prosperous, those householders who die will, immediately upon dying, for the most part be reborn among the gods of Tuṣita. Those who have gone forth who die will for the most part fall into bad rebirths. Why is that? Because they will not abide in having few possessions, and will not abide in their vows.

"Ānanda, in the royal city of Prosperous, even while the true Dharma still remains, the brahmins and householders will think, 'The true Dharma of the Blessed One Śākyamuni has vanished.' Why is that? Ānanda, because at that time most of the monks will be lax, have many possessions, fall away from renunciation, take the lead in backsliding, abandon their efforts at solitude, mingle with the fourfold assembly, decline in conduct, and become corrupt in moral discipline. Together with the brahmins and householders, they will decline in conduct and overstep the proper bounds. Without respect for one another, they will delight in giving and bestowing flowers, fruits, food and drink, and will be unrestrained. They too will enjoy children and wives. When the brahmins and householders see and hear this, they will think, 'Surely the true Dharma of the Blessed One is about to vanish, is it not?' and they will become terrified, frightened and unhappy.

"At that time, in the royal city of Prosperous, a layman called Dharmavardhana will appear, with great miraculous power, great might, and renown for great mastery, clear-minded, gentle and fearless, very learned, and skilled in establishing what he has learned. In order to gladden those brahmins and householders, he will rise into the sky by his miraculous power, and he will instruct the brahmins and householders, inspire them to take up the teaching, fire them with enthusiasm, and fill them with delight, and he will also speak these words: 'Brahmins and householders, do not be afraid! Do not give rise to doubt! Do not give rise to uncertainty! Do not waver! The true Dharma of the Blessed One Śākyamuni still remains and has not vanished. So, in order to attain what you have not attained, to realize what you have not realized, and

to directly experience what you have not directly experienced, apply yourselves! Strive! Make effort! It is still easy to hear the noble Dharma.'"

Then those brahmins and householders will be satisfied, pleased, delighted and overjoyed. Joy and happiness will arise in them, and they will give gifts and make merit. They will become eager to serve my relics, and so on up to honoring and worshipping them, and they will also strive in learning, moral discipline and renunciation. Because the householder Dharmavardhana will gladden the brahmins and householders in this way, most of them will go to the higher realms and to liberation. Ānanda, that householder Dharmavardhana will also spread this teaching of mine far and wide.

Ānanda, in this way, after I have passed away, many householders will also appear who have faith in my teaching and delight in it. They will have done service to the Victors of the past, generated roots of virtue, and be perfect in superior intention, and they will have attended on many buddhas. They too will be eager to serve, to esteem, to respect, to venerate, to honor and to worship my body and the śrāvakas. Ānanda, they too will spread this teaching of mine and cause gods and humans to take it to heart.

Ānanda, after I have passed away, in a future time, a monk called Jīvaka will appear in the northern region. He will have done service to the Victors of the past and attended on many hundreds of thousands of buddhas. He will have generated roots of virtue and generated superior intention. He will have truly entered the Great Vehicle, entered it for the benefit and happiness of many people. He will be greatly learned, a holder of the bodhisattva canon, one who speaks in praise of the Great Vehicle and who teaches the Great Vehicle correctly and thoroughly.

Seeing a stupa holding my relics dilapidated and crumbling, he will adorn it with gold and cover it with parasols, victory banners, pennants, silks, and nets of bells and little bells. He will adorn images of the Tathāgata, stupa shrines and stupas with lion banners, so that gods and humans will rejoice. To maintain the stupa, to maintain my teaching, to bring those without faith to faith, to make the faith of those who have it grow ever more, and so that many people may gather a store of roots of virtue, he will have a festival held every five years.

Ānanda, at that time there will be many monks who are lazy and slack, who have many possessions and have fallen away from renunciation. Their conduct will be corrupt and their moral discipline broken. They will engage in evil

practices and delight in bustle, paying no heed to solitude. They will have abandoned effort, settled in one place, and strive to acquire possessions. They will mingle with householders and with those gone forth, but not with the Three Jewels. They will be irreverent, merely posing as ascetics.

Few then will be the monks who have taken up diligence, who keep to solitude with mindfulness established, who are composed, endowed with wisdom, one-pointed in mind and of virtuous character, who have few desires and are content, who go for alms, who abide in the lineage of the noble ones, and who are greatly learned, having gathered much learning.

Among them, the monk Jīvaka, free of anger, with his faculties unimpaired and endowed with faith and the highest clarity, will regard all who wear the saffron robe, taking them to possess moral discipline, as worthy recipients of gifts. He will give them gifts and generate roots of virtue. Having gathered vast roots of virtue of many kinds, the kind that make a bodhisattva, immediately upon his death he will be born in the world realm Sukhāvatī, the buddha field of the Tathāgata Amitābha, which lies a hundred thousand koṭis of buddha fields away to the west. And in a world realm called Adorned with All Qualities he will become the Tathāgata called Vimalaprabha.

Ānanda, that monk Jīvaka too will make this teaching of mine broad and extensive. So, Ānanda, do not grieve. Do not lament. Ānanda, my holy life will spread, and gods and humans will take it to heart.

Ānanda, after I have passed away, in a future time, in a forested part of a border country, there will be a royal capital called Peace. There a king called Agnidatta will arise, full of faith and devotion. He will be eager to respect and to esteem my relics and the śrāvakas, and so on up to honoring them. Ānanda, that king Agnidatta will gather my śrāvakas at that royal capital Peace and give them cause for gladness. More than three thousand arhats will assemble there, all of them renowned for great miraculous power, great might and great mastery, and so on up to being tireless in teaching the Dharma to their companions in the holy life. Ānanda, they too will spread my teaching, making it broad and extensive among gods and humans. So, Ānanda, do not grieve. Do not lament.

Ānanda, after I have passed away, in the northern region there will be a city called Where All Trees Grow. There people will respect, esteem, serve and venerate my tooth with flowers, garlands, incense, unguents, cymbals, parasols, victory banners, pennants, banners of triumph and so on, and with

clothing, silver, gold and jewels. Ānanda, my stupa too will be adorned with gold. Ānanda, in that region many people will go forth. Many people endowed with moral discipline and virtuous qualities will appear, along with many hundreds of thousands of communities of monks. Ānanda, there will also be many householders there who keep moral discipline, who are greatly learned, wise and upright, and who have faith and devotion toward this teaching of mine. They will be eager to respect, to esteem, to serve, to venerate, to honor and to worship my relics and the śrāvakas.

They will take my Three Jewels fully to heart, and through that root of virtue they will enjoy the splendors of gods and humans. Then some will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, some will pass into parinirvāṇa by the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, and some will pass into parinirvāṇa by the vehicle of the śrāvakas. Ānanda, in this way their veneration will have great power.

Ānanda, they too will make this teaching of mine vast and extensive, will make it widespread and greatly extensive among gods and humans, and will explain it and teach it correctly. So, Ānanda, do not grieve. Do not lament. Ānanda, my holy life will flourish and will be rightly received by gods and humans. Ānanda, if the whole of Jambudvīpa will be filled everywhere with relic stūpas and with images of the Tathāgata, then, Ānanda, what need is there even to mention that the abodes of the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras and garuḍas will be filled with those that have passed out of sight? So, Ānanda, do not grieve. Do not lament. Ānanda, in this way my Dharma and Vinaya will flourish, and will become widespread and vast among gods and humans.

This concludes the sixth chapter, on upholding the sacred Dharma.

Then again the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, after I have passed into parinirvāṇa, whatever sons or daughters of noble family, whether gone forth or living as householders, venerate, honor, attend upon, or make offerings to even a relic the size of a mustard seed, Ānanda, the fruit of all those roots of virtue is parinirvāṇa, and I declare that in the end they will pass into parinirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, after I have passed into parinirvāṇa, whatever sons or daughters of noble family give rise to faith even on seeing a stūpa built for my sake, Ānanda, know with certainty that the fruit of all those roots of virtue that are faith in it is also nirvāṇa, and that in the end they will pass into parinirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, leave aside those who venerate me in person while I am present, who honor me and so on, up to making offerings. Leave aside also those who, after I have passed into parinirvāṇa, venerate even a relic the size of a mustard seed. Leave aside also those who venerate a stūpa built for my sake. Ānanda, whoever, with the Buddha as their focus, scatters even a single flower into the sky, Ānanda, the fruit of all those roots of virtue is nirvāṇa, and I declare that in the end they will pass into nirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, see how great is the miraculous power of offerings made to the buddhas, the blessed ones! If even casting a single flower into the sky with a mind focused on the Buddha brings one to nirvāṇa, then, Ānanda, what need is there to mention those who venerate the Tathāgata in person, or who, after he has passed into parinirvāṇa, make relic offerings to his relics? Ānanda, the tathāgata-domain of the tathāgatas is inconceivable. Ānanda, it should be known that when one venerates the inconceivable Tathāgata, the ripening too is inconceivable.

"Ānanda, if I were to explain by means of a buddha's wisdom the ripening of casting a single flower into the sky with a mind focused on the Buddha, Ānanda, even you yourself would hold it to be marvelous and wondrous, and would become joyful, delighted and overjoyed. What need then to mention those children of mine in the future who are deeply faithful, deeply respectful and deeply devoted, who reflect on the qualities of the Buddha and seek the wisdom of a buddha?"

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "The time has come for the Blessed One to explain the ripening of casting a single flower into the sky with the Buddha as one's focus. Blessed One, this is the time. Sugata, this is the occasion. What the monks hear from the Blessed One and hold to be true will be for the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, out of compassion for the world, and for the welfare, benefit and happiness of gods and humans. Beings of the present and of the future, having heard it from the Tathāgata, will again and again generate roots of virtue, will gain faith, and will also attain mental happiness. They will rejoice greatly, saying, 'The Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni, king of the Śākyas, endowed with great compassion, who benefits and loves the whole world, has given us comfort!' And they will bring the Buddha to mind and generate mindfulness focused on the Buddha."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Therefore, Ānanda, listen very well and bear it in mind, and I shall explain."

"So be it, Venerable One," replied the venerable Ānanda, and he listened as the Blessed One directed. The Blessed One then said to him:

"Ānanda, whoever, with the Buddha as their focus, casts even a single flower into the sky with a mind focused on the Buddha, as for its ripening, Ānanda: even if some being were to roam and circle through this saṃsāra for as long as an eon, just as the prior limit of saṃsāra is not known, so the limit of that root of virtue they have formed, which produces merit, is not easy to find, even for the Śakras themselves. Why is that? Ānanda, because a gift offered to the Buddha is not easily exhausted by all the happiness enjoyed in saṃsāra. Rather, since the fruit of that root of virtue is nirvāṇa itself, I declare that in the end one will pass into nirvāṇa."

"Ānanda, leave aside those who honor me in person. Leave aside those who perform relic worship to my bodily remains and relics, even ones the size of a mustard seed. Leave aside those who honor the stupas built for my sake. Leave aside those who, with the Buddha in mind, cast even a single flower into the sky. Ānanda, even if a sentient being who lacks the good fortune to attain nirvāṇa casts even a single flower into the sky with the Buddha in mind, Ānanda, the fruit of that root of virtue is also the fruit of nirvāṇa. I declare that it is completed by nirvāṇa and reaches its end in nirvāṇa. The end of those roots of virtue is nirvāṇa. Nirvāṇa is the chief, nirvāṇa is the distinguished, nirvāṇa is the supreme, nirvāṇa is the excellent. I declare that a gift offered to the one who has reached the ultimate end is nirvāṇa in its complete purity.

"Ānanda, for that reason the Tathāgata is the foremost of those worthy of gifts and the king of those worthy of gifts. Why is that? Because the result of any gift offered to the Tathāgata is the attainment of nirvāṇa. Therefore the Tathāgata is called the foremost of those worthy of gifts. Ānanda, that path is in accord. Ānanda, in this way, by this line of reasoning, it is shown that the Tathāgata is the foremost of those who receive without restriction. The end of every offering made to the Tathāgata is the fruit of nirvāṇa: it will be completed by nirvāṇa and reach its end in nirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, leave aside even giving of that kind. Why is that? Ānanda, whoever, with the Buddha in mind, gives rise to even a single thought and brings forth faith, Ānanda, the fruit of all that is also nirvāṇa. I declare that such a one will

finally attain nirvāṇa. Ānanda, leave aside such giving done by human beings. Ānanda, even the beings who have gone to birth as animals, if they find mindfulness directed to the Buddha, the fruit of all of them is also nirvāṇa. I declare that they will finally attain nirvāṇa. Ānanda, thus even beings who have gone to birth as animals will come to finally attain nirvāṇa. See, then, how great is the power of offerings made to the buddhas, the blessed ones, and how great is the power of a mind of faith in the buddhas.

"Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament! Ānanda, you will become one of great power, great fruit, great benefit, great vastness and great light, like nectar, completed by the deathless and reaching its end in the deathless. Ānanda, you have served the Tathāgata with loving deeds of body, loving deeds of speech and loving deeds of mind, beneficial, pleasant, free of duality, immeasurable, without limit and without malice.

"Ānanda, suppose this entire great trichiliocosm were completely filled with stream-enterers, and completely filled with once-returners, non-returners and arhats, as densely as a thicket of sugarcane, a thick field of rice, a dense stand of arrow reeds, a dense grove of bamboo, a dense bed of reeds, a thick field of sesame, or a dense growth of kuśa grass. And suppose some son or daughter of good family were to honor them all, revere them, serve them and worship them for an eon or more than an eon, and attend upon them with every pleasing requisite of comfort and every means of ease. Ānanda, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?"

He replied, "Much, Blessed One. Much, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, consider the heap of merit of one who joins his palms even once toward the Tathāgata and says even once the words, 'Homage to the Tathāgata.' Ānanda, compared with that honoring with a single joining of the palms, the former root of virtue does not come to even a hundredth part, nor a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part; it does not come to any number, fraction, reckoning or portion of it. Ānanda, why is that? Because the Tathāgata is thus the unsurpassed among those worthy of gifts, and so great is the power of offerings made to the Tathāgata.

"Ānanda, leave aside serving a great trichiliocosm completely filled with arhats. Ānanda, suppose this great trichiliocosm were completely filled with pratyekabuddhas, as densely as a thicket of sugarcane, and so on, from a dense bed of reeds up to a dense growth of kuśa grass. And suppose someone

were to honor them, revere them, serve them and worship them for as long as he lived, with every requisite of comfort and with everything that lets them dwell in ease. And suppose he built stupas of the seven precious substances for those pratyekabuddhas who had passed into parinirvāṇa, and for as long as he lived honored those too, revering them and so on up to worshiping them, with every kind of flower, incense, perfume, garland, ointment, powder, cloth, parasol, victory banner and pennant. Ānanda, what do you think? Would he generate much merit on that basis?"

He replied, "Much, Blessed One. Much, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, there is the heap of merit of one who, with even a single arising of thought and with a mind full of faith, recollects the Tathāgata, has faith in, reflects upon and is devoted to the qualities of the Buddha, and says the words, 'The wisdom of the tathāgatas is inconceivable.' Ānanda, compared with this root of virtue that comes from a mind of faith, the former heap of merit generated toward the pratyekabuddhas does not come near it, not even by the smallest fraction, not even by the least particle of a cause."

Why is that? Ānanda, the loving-kindness of the buddhas, the blessed ones, is immeasurable. Their great compassion is immeasurable. Their moral discipline is immeasurable. Their meditative absorption is immeasurable. Their wisdom is immeasurable. Their liberation is immeasurable. Their seeing of the wisdom of liberation is immeasurable. Their accomplishment is immeasurable. Their realization is immeasurable. Ānanda, the wisdom of the buddhas, the blessed ones, is inconceivable. Know that, since the domain of the buddhas is inconceivable, its karmic ripening too is inconceivable. Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament! Ānanda, you will come to have great miraculous power and great vastness.

Why is that? Ānanda, for more than twenty years you have attended upon the Tathāgata with loving deeds of body, loving deeds of speech, and loving deeds of mind, and you have retained the eighty-four thousand heaps of the Dharma. You are foremost among the learned and foremost among those of varied eloquence. You are clear, disciplined and fearless, learned, an upholder of the Sūtra, an upholder of the Vinaya, an upholder of the Mātṛkā, and tireless in teaching the Dharma to the fourfold assembly. Ānanda, after I have passed away, you and the elder Mahākāśyapa will carry out the deeds of the Teacher. So, Ānanda, do not grieve, and do not lament! Ānanda, you will come to have

great miraculous power, great benefit and great splendor; Ānanda, you will come to have great vastness.

This concludes the seventh chapter, on the relics not ceasing to exist.

Fascicle four.

Then once again the Blessed One said to Ānanda, "Ānanda, I declare that for any sentient beings who hear the speech of the buddhas, the blessed ones, or hear the sound of their names, Ānanda, that will not be in vain for them, all the way until they attain parinirvāṇa. Ānanda, what, then, is the meaning of the words 'Homage to the buddhas'?"

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, the Blessed One is the root of all dharmas. The Blessed One is the guide. Since the Blessed One is the Teacher, may the Blessed One please explain this meaning well to the monks. Having heard it directly from the Blessed One, they will retain the meaning just so."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Therefore, Ānanda, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain."

Saying, "Blessed One, so be it," the venerable Ānanda listened as the Blessed One instructed, and the Blessed One said to him, "Ānanda, the meaning of the words 'Homage to the Buddha' is this: the sound of the names of the buddhas, the blessed ones, is never in vain. Ānanda, thus it is taught that this 'Homage to the Buddha' is never in vain. Ānanda, therefore, so that this meaning may be known extensively and brought to completion, and so that faithful sons and daughters of good family who hear the names of the buddhas, the blessed ones, may come to have vast faith in this teaching, I shall set forth an illustration for you.

"Ānanda, long ago, in times past, a large company of merchants set out upon the great ocean. When they reached the middle of the ocean, their great ship was seized by a sea monster (makara). Ānanda, then that great company of merchants was afraid, terrified and alarmed. Their hair stood on end, and stricken with the fear of death, without protector, without refuge, without ally, each of them wept, wailed and lamented, crying out in many kinds of lamentation:

'Alas, how delightful that Jambudvīpa is! Alas, how fine that world of the living is! Alas, how hard it is to gain this human birth! Alas, we shall be parted from

our fathers and mothers! Alas, our children and wives, alas, our friends and the company of our wives, we shall never see again!'

"So they wept and lamented, and suffering pain and misery, in their wish to live they paid homage to all sorts of gods.

"Ānanda, now in that company of merchants there was a captain, wise, clear-minded and steadfast, with deep faith in the Buddha, the Dharma and the Saṅgha, who held no other to be his god, and who had faith in the buddhas, the blessed ones. He said to all those merchants, 'O merchants, do you wish to cross beyond and be freed from this great fear and terror? Or, failing that, do you at least wish to be born in the happy realms, in the higher states? Then come here! All of you gather together in harmony, and just as I say it, each of you say it too.'

"They replied, 'Captain, speak, and we too will repeat just as you say.'

"Ānanda, then the captain draped his robe over one shoulder, set his right kneecap upon the great ship, and with his mind fixed on the Buddha cried out in a great voice, 'Homage to the buddhas! Homage to the buddhas, givers of fearlessness, endowed with great compassion, loving toward all sentient beings!' Thus he paid homage to the Buddha.

"Right there, the company of merchants too joined their palms and spoke these words with one voice: 'Homage to the buddhas! Homage to the buddhas, the blessed ones, endowed with great compassion, loving toward all sentient beings!'

"Ānanda, then that sea monster heard that sound of 'Buddha.' Having heard 'Homage to the Buddha,' it attained great joy and a mind free of harm, and it closed its mouth again.

"Ānanda, then the captain, together with that ship, escaped safely, and the great ships, safe and with their aims accomplished, returned to Jambudvīpa.

"That sea monster too, having heard that sound of 'Buddha,' experienced happiness and from then on ate no other living creatures. Starving, it died right there. As soon as it died, it passed away from the animal state of birth and was reborn with a lot equal to that of humans."

He came to have faith in the Dharma and Vinaya taught by the Tathāgata, and went forth from home into homelessness. Having gone forth, he attended upon, relied on, and honored a spiritual friend, and in this way he attained arhatship. Having directly realized the six higher knowledges, he passed into

nirvāṇa in the element of nirvāṇa in which no remainder of the aggregates is left.

Ānanda, see how that hearing of the word "Buddha" by the sea creature born in the animal realm became the cause for becoming human, the cause for going forth, the cause for attaining arhatship, and the cause for complete nirvāṇa. Ānanda, see how great the power is of hearing the word of the buddhas, the blessed ones; how great the power is of uttering their name; and how great the power is of a mind of faith. If even a sea creature born in the animal realm, a realm belonging to the unwholesome, did not hear the word "Buddha" in vain, what need is there to speak of one who has become human? Ānanda, by this line of teaching too you should understand the following: if even hearing the word "Buddha" spoken of the buddhas, the blessed ones, is not in vain, what need is there to speak of other roots of virtue generated toward the Buddha?

Ānanda, one who does the partial accomplishes the partial; one who does the complete accomplishes the complete. On what basis did I say this? "Doing the partial" means a root of virtue arising from faith, of limited scope in time, which generates the seed of a śrāvaka, so that one becomes a śrāvaka. By that root of virtue one completes the stage of a śrāvaka. Doing it for one's own sake means generating one's own root of virtue and thereby completing the stage of a pratyekabuddha. Ānanda, it was on this basis that I said, "This is doing the partial."

Ānanda, "doing the complete" means, Ānanda, a root of virtue without beginning or end in time, generated toward the Buddha, which generates the seed of buddhahood. After a long time has passed, perhaps, by that cause, that condition, and that root of virtue, one pleases the buddhas, the blessed ones. Having pleased them, one generates roots of virtue toward them in order to bring it to completion. Having generated them, one accumulates the collections for awakening, and by completing all its branches one becomes a buddha whose name is renowned in the world as "the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha." Ānanda, this is called doing the complete. Thus whatever I said, I said on this basis. Ānanda, by this line of teaching too you should understand that one who does the partial accomplishes the partial, and one who does the complete accomplishes the complete.

Ānanda, I have also taught other practices, even down to a mere quarter of a root. On what basis did I say this? Ānanda, I taught it with regard to beings

who are emaciated and weak. Ānanda, I am the refuge of ruined beings. I am the protector of the utterly ruined. I am their ally. I am the support and protector of those without support and without protector. Ānanda, for beings who have no lamp, who are blind and without eyes, I am the lamp and the eye, the one who makes illumination and light. Ānanda, all opponents are without refuge, blind, without eyes, and without a guide. Ānanda, I am the Teacher of the world with its gods. I am the healer. I am compassionate toward all sentient beings.

Why is that? Ānanda, in the latter time, the time of decline, when the true Dharma is perishing, those who will go forth in this teaching of mine, having gone forth, will lead a child by the hand and wander together with the child from tavern to tavern for a ladleful of beer. Yet all those who follow this true Dharma of mine, Ānanda, will attain complete nirvāṇa in this Fortunate Eon.

Ānanda, why is this eon called the Fortunate Eon? Ānanda, when this great trichiliocosm world system has been destroyed, and the great earth has become a single ocean, the sons of the gods of the Pure Abodes gaze with their divine eyes upon the whole destruction by water. As they gaze, they see in Jambudvīpa a full thousand great lotuses, golden in color, radiating golden light, each with a thousand petals, sweetly fragrant and delightful. Seeing them, they think: "As many lotuses as have appeared, so many buddhas, blessed ones, will appear in this eon." Then they are satisfied, delighted, elated, and overjoyed; joy and gladness arise in them, and they utter this solemn exclamation: "Where a thousand buddhas appear, oh, this eon will be fortunate! Oh, this eon will be supremely fortunate!" Ānanda, that is why this eon is called the Fortunate. Ānanda, this is the cause and this is the condition for the Fortunate Eon being given the name "Fortunate Eon."

Ānanda, in this Fortunate Eon, after I have passed, nine hundred and ninety-six buddhas will appear. In this eon, from Krakucchanda down to me at present, there are four. Ānanda, after me Maitreya will appear, and the Tathāgata called Roca will appear as the last of the thousand. Ānanda, by this line of teaching too you should understand the following: when, after I have passed, nine hundred and ninety-six buddhas appear in this Fortunate Eon, Ānanda, all those who appear in this teaching of mine as being of the lineage of śramaṇas, śramaṇas only in name, those who claim to be śramaṇas, those who imitate śramaṇas, those who wear the saffron robe, will all gradually pass into nirvāṇa in this Fortunate Eon under those buddhas, blessed ones, who come later, from Maitreya up to Roca.

All of them will pass into complete nirvāṇa in the element of nirvāṇa in which no aggregates remain, and not a single monk will be left behind. Why is that? Ānanda, it is because, with regard to the Tathāgata, who has realized and fully realized the realm of phenomena, even the arousing of a single thought of faith of this kind does not go to waste, and neither do white and black deeds.

Ānanda, if some, with faith, utter the words "Homage to the buddhas," then, Ānanda, I declare that even that root of virtue leads toward nirvāṇa. I declare that it will end in nirvāṇa and will reach the culmination of nirvāṇa. If that is so, what need is there to speak of those who show reverence to the Tathāgata while he is living, who honor him, serve him and worship him, and who make relic offerings to the relics of him who has passed into complete nirvāṇa? Ānanda, if those of the monastic lineage who wear the saffron robe will, even only a few times, surely utter the words "Homage to the buddhas," what need is there to speak of their arousing faith and producing other roots of virtue? Ānanda, it was with this in mind that I said that.

Then the Blessed One put these words into verse and said:

"Thus the buddhas are inconceivable,
And the Dharma of the buddhas too is inconceivable.
If one has faith in the inconceivable,
Its ripened result is inconceivable.

Having made offerings to the buddhas of the past,
Possessed of great might, makers of light,
Unequaled in compassion throughout the world,
Thinking, 'I shall awaken to this incalculable awakening,'
I then devoted myself wholly to giving.

Cultivating the faculty of faith, endowed with diligence,
With the power of diligence, having fully brought forth harmony,
I gave gifts and cherished beings with tender love.

Just as one feels love for father and mother, for sister,
For brother and for friend,
So I gave up anger toward friend and foe alike,
And attained the unequaled, incalculable awakening.

To seek awakening, peaceful and free of sorrow,
For ten million eons I gave gifts.
Wishing to benefit, fully arousing compassion,

I gave away head and eyes, flesh and blood,
And many thousands of kingdoms of many kinds.

Beloved sons and wives and daughters,
Likewise horses and many vehicles,
I gave away in the past for the sake of this awakening.

For thousands of eons and many ten millions,
Out of longing for this sublime awakening,
As I roamed about, again and again,
With abundant faith I gave gifts.

While I searched for this supreme awakening,
Having endured many unbearable sufferings
Of heat and cold, of hunger and of thirst,
I took up diligence until the time of my death.

While seeking awakening, peaceful and free of sorrow,
For the benefit of all these worlds,
The features of all that I practiced
Would take a hundred years, or even an eon, to tell.

Now, while circling in saṃsāra, I pleased hundreds of buddhas,
Thousands of buddhas and many ten millions.
All those buddhas of great might
I constantly honored with golden flowers.
With food and drink, and likewise with garments,
With incense and garlands and with ointments,
With banners, victory standards and parasols by the ten million,
I made offerings to many ten millions of buddhas.

Many living beings, many ten millions of beings,
Circling in this saṃsāra that has no far shore,
I constantly brought relief as I went on,
And I also gave vast and excellent gifts.

Moral discipline, patience, and likewise diligence,
Samādhi, wisdom, and likewise skillful means,
The right abandonments and the applications of mindfulness,
And likewise the four bases of miraculous power I thoroughly cultivated.
Out of longing for this sublime awakening,

I cultivated well the five faculties and the five powers.
The seven limbs of awakening and the noble path,
All the factors of awakening, I cultivated.

Consider with noble wisdom
That which, once done, will never perish.
If one always practices it fully with faith,
It will not be lost by so much as the tip of a hair."

This concludes the eighth chapter, the chapter on homage.

Then again the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, if even the arousing of a single virtuous thought toward the buddhas, the blessed ones, does not go to waste, what need is there to speak of other roots of virtue? Ānanda, therefore, so that this meaning may be understood extensively, I shall give you an example, for some wise persons here will come to understand through an example how even the arousing of a single thought of faith toward the Tathāgata does not go to waste.

Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose some man took up a single drop of water with the tip of a hair split a hundredfold, came before me, and said, 'O Gautama, I place this drop of water in your hand. When an eon has passed, give it back to me, the same, neither more nor less. Do not let this drop of water be dried up by the wind and the sun. Do not give it to herds of wild animals or flocks of birds to drink. Do not mix it with other water either. You must keep this water poured into a vessel; do not set it on the ground.' And suppose the Tathāgata took it and placed it in the great river Ganges, in a spot where it would not be stirred up by the waves, and that drop of water, within the great river Ganges, unstirred by the waves and not drunk by herds of wild animals or flocks of birds, flowed along with the great river and gradually reached the great ocean. Then that drop of water would not be used up, even by masses of scattering winds, until the end of the eon, and it would be kept under watch. That man too would remain for an eon, keeping watch, and I too would remain for an eon. Then, when an eon had passed, that man would come back to me and say, 'O Gautama, I have need of that drop of water. Give that drop of water back to me.' Ānanda, even though an eon had elapsed, the Tathāgata possesses the wisdom by which the Tathāgata knows, 'That drop of water is in such and such a part of the great ocean.'

Ānanda, the Tathāgata possesses such wisdom that, with that very tip of a hair split a hundredfold, the Tathāgata himself takes that drop of water back out of the great ocean. It is unmixed with other water, it has not taken on any other moisture, it is untainted and unmixed, exactly the same, with nothing added and nothing lost, and he gives it back to that man. Such is the wisdom he possesses. Ānanda, the Tathāgata's wisdom is that completely pure. The Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha is renowned for having such great miraculous power, such great might and such great mastery. He possesses such immeasurable wisdom, and he possesses such unobscured vision of wisdom.

Ānanda, those tathāgatas with whom even so small a drop of water, once deposited, is not lost for however long a time, such tathāgatas are holy ones. They are supreme ones. They are holders of what is entrusted to them.

Ānanda, this example has been taught so that its meaning may be understood. What, then, is the meaning to be expressed here? Ānanda, "the fine tip of a hair" is a term for the mind. Ānanda, "the great river Ganges" is a term for the stream of saṃsāra. Ānanda, "a single drop" is a term for the root of virtue of generating a single thought. Ānanda, "the great ocean" is a term for the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha. Ānanda, "the man" is a term for faithful brahmins and householders. "Remaining for an eon" is a term for the fact that a root of virtue generated toward the Tathāgata is not lost.

Ānanda, just as a certain man's single drop of water is not lost for however long a time, in the same way, Ānanda, if even a single thought generated toward the Tathāgata is not lost, what need is there to speak of other roots of virtue that are far more excellent? Ānanda, the result of all of them is nirvāṇa. I declare that they continue until, in the end, final nirvāṇa is attained.

Furthermore, Ānanda, there are beings who have generated a single thought of faith toward the Tathāgata, and who, apart from that, have done wrong, or behaved badly, or generated thoughts that become nonvirtuous obscurations. Through other misdeeds of the past, which they themselves accumulated and they themselves committed, they may go to the hells, to birth as animals, or to the world of Yama. Yet when buddhas, blessed ones endowed with great compassion, appear in the world, their buddha wisdom, unhindered and unobscured, knows that these beings once made roots of virtue and then fell into the lower realms through some karma of wrong conduct. Knowing that they possess roots of virtue made in the past, the buddhas, the blessed ones,

draw them out of those lower realms by means of that virtuous thought, by the blessing of that root of virtue, and by that former cause. Having drawn them out, they release them from sorrow. They set them on the far shore, the cool plain of peace and happiness, where there is no fear.

Having set them there, those buddhas, blessed ones, remind them and urge them, saying, "Sons of good family, remember that at such and such a time, in such and such a life, you generated and deposited such and such a root of virtue with those buddhas, blessed ones!" Through the power of the Buddha they remember, and they say, "So it is, Blessed One! So it is, Sugata!"

Then those buddhas, blessed ones, say to them: "Sons of good family, these roots of virtue are the very ones you generated toward the buddhas of the past. They have not been exhausted, nor have they gone to waste. Indeed, it is on their basis that you have found this nirvāṇa, the pacification of all suffering. Sons of good family, you have arrived at the domain of your forefathers, the domain of the noble ones. For a long time you roamed in what was not your domain. You were circling in saṃsāra, which has neither beginning nor end. Sons of good family, a root of virtue deposited with those such as me is a deposit that is never lost."

Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose a prince or a merchant's son were put in prison for some offense, and, after his former offense had been brought up and he had been reproached, he were quickly released again. In the same way, Ānanda, those who generated roots of virtue toward the buddhas of the past may go to the hells, to birth as animals, or to the world of Yama because of some wrongdoing or some other fault. Yet when buddhas, blessed ones endowed with great compassion, appear in the world, then for those beings who generated even a single virtuous thought, by that root of virtue, by that thought, by the blessing of that root of virtue, and by that cause, those buddhas, blessed ones, knowing that those beings possess roots of virtue from the past, draw them out of the lower realms and set them on the cool plain of nirvāṇa, where there is no fear. Having set them there, they urge them, saying, "Sons of good family, remember that root of virtue!" And they reply, "So it is, Blessed One! So it is, Sugata! Through the power of the Buddha and the blessing of the Buddha, we remember."

This concludes the ninth chapter, on the Root of Virtue.

Then again the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, through this enumeration too you should understand the following. However small the

root of virtue done toward those such as me, it is not lost, and the result of all those roots of virtue of generating a single thought is nirvāṇa. I declare that in the end they attain final nirvāṇa. Ānanda, therefore I have taught you an example, in order to proclaim that very point at length, and so that some faithful and wise sons or daughters of good family may gain vast conviction in it, examine it, generate diligence, and, having gained conviction, give rise to vast joy and great, supreme delight."

"Ānanda, consider this example. Suppose a fisherman holding a hook casts the hook, together with its bait, into a great lake in order to lure the fish. If a fish swallows what he has cast there, then the fish that has swallowed the hook, though it still swims in the waters of the lake, should be known as already lying on dry land. Why is that? Because that fish has been caught by the fisherman with the strong line of the hook. If the fish goes down into the water with the hook, and the line stays fastened to the hook, it is both in the water and on dry land. For when the rod rests on dry land and is held firmly, the fisherman comes and knows that the fish has been caught by the line. He draws it in with that line and pulls it out onto dry land as he wishes, and then comes the time when he does with it whatever pleases him.

"Ānanda, in the same way, there are beings who have faith in the buddhas, the blessed ones, who generate roots of virtue, who make offerings, or who generate even a single moment of faith. Obscured by other evil deeds that turn into obscurations, those beings may fall into the hells, into birth as animals, into the world of Yama, or into some other unfavorable state of downfall. Yet when a buddha, a blessed one, appears in the world, the buddhas know them with their buddha wisdom: 'These beings belong to the bodhisattva vehicle. These beings belong to the pratyekabuddha vehicle. These beings belong to the śrāvaka vehicle. These beings have made roots of virtue. These beings have cut off their roots of virtue. These beings are on the side of decline. These beings are on the side of progress. These have planted seeds through realizing the pure Dharma. This one, for instance, has planted a seed through the pure virtuous act of making an offering to a buddha, or even of generating a single thought endowed with faith.' Thus they know.

"Whoever, through the ripening of any offering, comes to generate even a single thought of faith in the buddhas, the blessed ones, the buddhas, the blessed ones, with their buddha wisdom, draw out of that downfall by virtue of the distinction of that thought. Having drawn them out, they establish them on the blissful plain of nirvāṇa. And having established them there, they exhort

them: 'Son of noble family, remember these roots of virtue that you generated toward the Tathāgata called such and such.'"

Ānanda said, "So it is, Blessed One. So it is, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Therefore, sons of noble family, these roots of virtue of making offerings to the Tathāgata bring great fruit and great gain. Sons of noble family, what is placed in those like me, sown in the great field of merit, is not wasted even over a span as long as a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of eons. The fruit of all those roots of virtue is nirvāṇa, and in the end they will pass into nirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, what should be seen as the meaning of this example that I have given so that the meaning may be understood? Ānanda, the word 'fish' is a designation for ordinary beings. Ānanda, 'the lake waters' is a designation for the ocean of saṃsāra. Ānanda, 'the hook' is a designation for generating roots of virtue toward the Tathāgata. Ānanda, 'the line' is a designation for the four means of attraction. Ānanda, 'the fisherman' is a designation for the Tathāgata. Ānanda, 'the living fish' is a designation for establishing beings in the fruit of nirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, by this explanation too you should understand that whatever offering is made to the Buddha, however long it may take, does not perish, is not exhausted, and does not come to an end short of one's passing into nirvāṇa. Ānanda, for this reason I shall show you still other examples of how an offering made to the Buddha is fulfilled by nirvāṇa and reaches its culmination in nirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, there are beings who indulge in craving, who, wishing to experience attachment to feeling, praise saṃsāra, delight in saṃsāra, and, desiring saṃsāra, make offerings to the buddhas, the blessed ones, and dedicate their roots of virtue out of a wish for the higher realms and a wish to be reborn as humans. There are even beings who, having made offerings to the buddhas, the blessed ones, dedicate them thus: 'By this root of virtue, may we never pass into parinirvāṇa!' Yet, Ānanda, it is impossible, it cannot happen, that by that root of virtue those beings will not pass into parinirvāṇa. Why is that? Ānanda, because the buddhas, the blessed ones, are the unsurpassed field of merit, free of stones and thorns, free of the stains of attachment and aversion, completely pure. Whether the seed of virtue sown there is small, or the seed of virtue is vast, or however subtle it may be, and whether it becomes a seed of awakening, a seed of the śrāvakas, or a seed of the pratyekabuddhas, none of

those roots of virtue will deceive. If it is not given up, it brings perfect abundance of increasing wealth; through faith it becomes the pure path to the higher realms; and it culminates in nirvāṇa."

Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose a householder farmer had a field that was flawless, free of stumps and thorns, free of gravel and pebbles, with rich, dark soil. It had been well plowed and finished with the proper tools. His seed was fresh, sound, and very well prepared, not damaged by wind or sun, not broken, not cracked, not rotten, and unspoiled. He sowed those seeds in the field at the right time and season, watered them at the proper times, let them dry at the proper times, and guarded them well against every harm. Then, Ānanda, at a later time the farmer went to the field, sat down at its edge, and said, "Hey, seeds! Do not become seeds! Hey, seeds! Do not sprout! Do not grow! I do not want any fruit. I do not want any gain."

If he spoke like that, Ānanda, what do you think? Would those seeds cease to be seeds because of that farmer's words?

Ānanda replied, "No, Blessed One. No, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Would the fruit cease to be fruit? Would the gain fail to come about?"

Ānanda replied, "No, Blessed One. No, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, in the same way, even if people who praise existence and delight in existence make an offering to the Buddha and say, 'By this root of virtue may we never attain complete nirvāṇa,' there is no possibility, no occasion, that they will not attain complete nirvāṇa. Ānanda, even if they do not want those roots of virtue generated toward the Buddha, their fruit is nirvāṇa. I declare that it will lead them all the way to final nirvāṇa. Thus, whatever roots of virtue are produced by generating even a single thought toward the buddhas, the blessed ones, the fruit of all of them too is nirvāṇa. I declare that it will lead all the way to final nirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, in times to come there will arise robber kings and barbarians. Ānanda, those robber kings and barbarians who see a stupa of the Tathāgata or an image of the Tathāgata and become inspired with faith, Ānanda, even though they do not know any of the Buddha's teachings and do not know any of the Buddha's qualities, Ānanda, when I was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, I gathered them to me, in all those destinies and in all those births, by means of the four ways of attracting beings. What are the four?

Generosity, pleasant speech, beneficial conduct, and consistency of purpose. Ānanda, when they see my stupa they will certainly become inspired with faith. Ānanda, the fruit of their roots of virtue too is nirvāṇa. I declare that it will lead them all the way to final nirvāṇa.

"Those border kings who rob and kill, and the henchmen of those barbarians, their ministers, princes, accountants, those who belong to the great chiefs, their retinues, friends, relatives, companions, and blood kin, if they see the stupa of me who have passed into nirvāṇa and with little effort become inspired with faith, Ānanda, all of them too will generate roots of virtue through the teachings of the Buddha or the qualities of the Buddha. Ānanda, them too I fully gathered to me by the four ways of attracting beings when formerly I practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva. Ānanda, the fruit of all their roots of virtue too is nirvāṇa. I declare that they will finally attain nirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, see how for a long time I have gathered these beings to me by the four ways of attracting beings, and how for a long time I have brought them into connection with the teaching of the buddhas, the blessed ones.

"Ānanda, when the Tathāgata sets out on the road and travels, low ground becomes high, high ground becomes low, uneven places become even, and very low places become very high; and after the Tathāgata has passed by, they remain as they were before. All the trees bow down, and all the tree deities also pay homage, and after the Tathāgata has passed by, they return to how they were before. Ravines, precipices, hollows, grass, stumps, thorns, gravel, pebbles, thickets, and treacherous cliffs, all of these too bow down, become level, clean, thoroughly cleansed, and free of filth, and are strewn with fragrant and lovely flowers. Ānanda, because in the past the Tathāgata performed virtuous deeds well, when he travels on the road he travels on a clean way.

"Ānanda, see how, when the Tathāgata sets out on the road, there is no sentient being at all that does not bow down; and see how there are no insentient things on the earth, no mountains, ravines, precipices, trees, grasses, shrubs, medicinal plants, or forests, that do not bow aside wherever the Tathāgata travels on the road. Why is that? Ānanda, it is because formerly, while I was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, I bowed to my teachers, bowed deeply, and remained in homage to them. I bowed with deep respect to my father and mother and remained so. I bowed to elders, to those of middle age, and to the young, to friends, relatives, and blood kin, to buddhas and

bodhisattvas, to spiritual friends, to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, to those possessing the five superknowledges, and likewise to other śramaṇas and brahmins. Toward buddhas, bodhisattvas, spiritual friends, śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, non-Buddhist sages, śramaṇas, brahmins, father and mother, and all those friends, relatives, and blood kin, as well as others, elders, those of middle age, the young, and companions, I made my mind greatly joyful; I paid homage to them with my body, and with my speech I treated them as superiors, and in that way I bowed to them.

"Ānanda, through the ripening of that virtuous karma of mine, ever since the Tathāgata attained awakening, whenever the Tathāgata travels on the road, there is nothing whatsoever, whether sentient or insentient, that is disrespectful, that does not bow, or that does not bow deeply."

Ānanda, I gave many gifts that were pure, excellent and pleasing, with my own hand, to those such as my teachers, to the Tathāgatas and to sentient beings. Ānanda, through the ripening of that karma, when the Tathāgata travels along a road, it becomes fine, clean and thoroughly cleared, with sticks, clods and mud all swept away.

Ānanda, while I was striving for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I acted out of benefit for all sentient beings, for the happiness of all sentient beings, out of compassion for the world, and for the welfare, benefit and happiness of gods and humans. Whenever buddhas, bodhisattvas, spiritual friends, śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and many non-Buddhist sages set out on a road, I always swept the road. I swept their dwellings, their walking places and their seats. I swept the stupas of the Tathāgatas with a mind of loving-kindness, a mind of equanimity, a mind free of all unevenness, a mind without crookedness, and a mind intent on benefit. I made them clean.

Ānanda, through that root of virtue, in whatever direction the Tathāgata stands, sits, walks or lies down, or sets out on a road, those places become clean and pure with little effort, level like the palm of the hand. Ānanda, the limits of the distinctive features of the Tathāgata's bodily activity are not easy to fathom.

Therefore, Ānanda, in order to complete this meaning extensively and in full, and so that some faithful sons or daughters of good family here may somehow develop great joy, faith, respect and deep reverence toward the Tathāgata, I shall give you an analogy.

Ānanda, Sumeru, king of mountains, rises eighty-four thousand yojanas out of the great ocean, and eighty-four thousand yojanas are sunk beneath the water. Even if that great king of mountains were as hard as a vajra, Ānanda, it would not be easy for it even to harm the hair of the Tathāgata who has passed into complete nirvāṇa, so what need is there to speak of twisting even a single hair and altering it? That is impossible.

Ānanda, leave aside Sumeru, king of mountains. Ānanda, the kings of mountains, the Cakravāla and the Great Cakravāla, sixty-eight thousand yojanas in height, the kings of mountains, the Cakravāla and the Great Cakravāla, which are like vajra: even for them, Ānanda, it would not be easy to bend, or bend down completely, or pluck out the hair of the Tathāgata who has passed into complete nirvāṇa, so what need is there to speak of destroying it? That is impossible.

Why is this? Ānanda, it is because formerly, when I practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, it was not easy to find a single being whom I had set at odds. Ānanda, I brought beings who were quarreling and divided into reconciliation and harmony, and made them steadfast and undivided, endowed with minds of loving-kindness and minds of benefit toward one another. Ānanda, by that means and through that root of virtue, the body of the Tathāgata became indivisible, and, Ānanda, the attending retinue of the Tathāgata became indivisible.

Ānanda, what then is the attending retinue of the Tathāgata? Ānanda, the attending retinue of the Tathāgata is the Dharma, namely: the four applications of mindfulness, the four right exertions, the four bases of miraculous power, the five faculties, the five powers, the seven branches of awakening, and the noble eightfold path. Ānanda, these thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening are the great attending retinue of the Tathāgata. And those śrāvakas whom the Tathāgata has established in them cannot be divided by the world with its gods.

Why is this? Ānanda, it is because this is the nature of reality of a Dharma such as this: the world with its gods and Brahmā, the generation with its ascetics and brahmins, with its assemblies, with its gods, humans and asuras, and the great earth with Sumeru, the Cakravāla and the Great Cakravāla, would not find it easy even to bow the head of the Tathāgata who has passed into complete nirvāṇa, so what need is there to speak of dividing it? That is impossible. Why is this? Ānanda, it is because the body of the Tathāgata is

indivisible and his relics are indivisible.

Ānanda, out of compassion for sentient beings and in order to spread the teaching, by his former aspiration the Tathāgata blessed his relics to become the size of mustard seeds. Ānanda, formerly, when the Tathāgata practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, he resolutely gave rise to this thought: "When I have become fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and have passed into complete nirvāṇa, may my relics spread far and wide!" Ānanda, this spreading of the relics of the buddhas, the blessed ones, who have passed into complete nirvāṇa also comes about through the power of former aspiration.

At the time of passing into complete nirvāṇa, too, those beings to be trained will see the Blessed One. For their sake and out of compassion for beings, he blessed the relics to be broken up and blessed them to become the size of mustard seeds. Ānanda, at the time when the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, passes into complete nirvāṇa, out of compassion for the world he enters into the meditative absorption by which he blesses his relics to become the size of mustard seeds.

Ānanda, when all the joints of my body are broken apart and blessed into relics the size of mustard seeds, painful feeling does arise. Yet, Ānanda, in order to care for those beings and out of compassion, the Tathāgata is able to bear the painful feeling, so that the people of the land in later times will be cared for through happiness and the path of virtue.

Ānanda, there are those who, to relics even the size of a mustard seed, offer flowers, incense, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, victory banners, flags, dance, the playing of music, the beating of drums, and praises, and so honor them, revere them, serve them, worship them, esteem them, and venerate them. Ānanda, the fruit of all those roots of virtue is nirvāṇa. I declare that it will continue until they finally pass into nirvāṇa.

Ānanda, when a hundred years have passed after my parinirvāṇa, in the city called Pāṭaliputra there will appear a king called Aśoka, born into the Maurya clan, a righteous Dharma king. He will have faith in my teaching. Having gained faith, he will spread my relics far and wide. At one time, in a single day, he will build eighty-four thousand stūpas for my relics. Ānanda, do not grieve! Do not lament! Ānanda, my relics will spread, and for gods and humans they will become vast and extensive.

Ānanda, leave aside those who honor the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, while he is still living. Leave aside also those who make relic offerings to the relics of one who has passed into parinirvāṇa. Ānanda, if any people see a stūpa of the Tathāgata even in a dream and their minds become clear with faith, Ānanda, the fruit of that root of virtue too is nirvāṇa. I declare that it will be bounded by nirvāṇa and will reach its end in nirvāṇa.

Ānanda, among the buddhas, the blessed ones, who will appear in the future, there is not a single tathāgata appearing in the world who will not proclaim my qualities. Just as I now proclaim the qualities of the buddhas, the blessed ones of the past, so too the buddhas, the blessed ones yet to come, will fully proclaim my qualities.

Ānanda, all those sentient beings who, on the basis of my teaching of the Dharma, have the Dharma eye with regard to phenomena, free of dust, stainless and pure, Ānanda, were all brought to maturity by me in the past, when I was a bodhisattva practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Ānanda, gifts offered to the Saṅgha are exhausted along the way and come to an end. Gifts offered to the Saṅgha of the four directions are also exhausted along the way and come to an end. Ānanda, gifts offered to pratyekabuddhas are also exhausted along the way and come to an end. But, Ānanda, gifts offered to the Tathāgata are not exhausted along the way and do not come to an end. Ānanda, the fruit of all those gifts is nirvāṇa. I declare that they finally pass into nirvāṇa.

Ānanda, leave aside honoring the living Tathāgata in person. Leave aside also making relic offerings to the relics of one who has passed into parinirvāṇa. Ānanda, if someone, with a mind focused on the Buddha, tosses a single flower into the sky, I could not easily measure or describe that root of virtue, even with the buddha wisdom of a tathāgata. Ānanda, suppose one were to take up and examine the root of virtue that person created by tossing a single flower into the sky with a mind focused on the Buddha. Even if that person were to wander and circle in saṃsāra for as many eons as saṃsāra has no discernible beginning, the ripening of offering that single flower to the Tathāgata could not easily be used up by becoming Brahmā, or Śakra (Indra), or by the kingship of a universal monarch. Beyond that, Ānanda, the fruit of that root of virtue is nirvāṇa. I declare that it inclines toward nirvāṇa and finally passes into nirvāṇa.

Why is that? Ānanda, the ripening of offering a single flower to the Buddha, the Blessed One, cannot easily be fathomed to its limit, except that it culminates in nirvāṇa. So great is its miraculous power, so great its benefit, so great its splendor, so vast is it. Ānanda, gifts offered to the Tathāgata that ripen in such a way are thus immeasurable. I declare that even generating a single moment of faith toward the Tathāgata is utterly conclusive, utterly accomplished, blissful, utterly final, and utterly the pure life.

Therefore, Ānanda, a son or daughter of good family who wishes for the kingship of a universal monarch should in this way honor, revere, serve, and worship the Buddha, the Blessed One. A son or daughter of good family who wishes to attain the state of Śakra, or of Brahmā; who wishes to become lord of the gods of the realm of the Four Great Kings; or of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, of Yāma, of Tuṣita, of Nirmāṇarati, and of Paranirmitavaśavartin; or of the nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and mahoragas, of humans or non-humans; or who wishes to attain lordship over the world of all worlds, should honor, revere, serve, and worship the Buddha, the Blessed One. A son or daughter of good family who wishes to attain the level of a śrāvaka, or wishes to attain the level of a pratyekabuddha, or wishes to attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, should honor, revere, serve, and worship the Buddha, the Blessed One.

Ānanda, when I was seeking unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, I honored, revered, served, and worshiped many buddhas, many hundreds of buddhas, many thousands of buddhas, many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of buddhas, with robes, food, bedding, medicine for the sick, and provisions, with seats, walkways, and monasteries, and with flowers, incense, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, victory banners, and flags.

"Even after those buddhas, those blessed ones, had passed into complete nirvāṇa, I built stūpas for them. I revered them, honored them, and served them, worshiping them with hundreds of thousands of flowers, incense, fragrances, garlands, and ointments, and with hundreds of thousands of songs, dances, cymbals, and clapping of hands. All of that worship and veneration I also performed for the sake of this very unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening: out of tender love for all sentient beings, for the welfare, benefit, and happiness of gods and humans, in order to carry across those who have not crossed over, to free those who are not free, to bring relief to those who have found no relief, and to lead to complete nirvāṇa those who have not

attained complete nirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, I scattered five utpala flowers over the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Dīpaṃkara, and at that time I attained acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. Ānanda, from the root of virtue I gained then, I have experienced only a small portion of the ripening of virtue. Do you wish to hear just a small portion of the ripening of that root of virtue, of scattering those five utpala flowers over the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Dīpaṃkara?"

Ānanda replied, "Blessed One, I do wish it. Sugata, I do wish it. This is the time for the Blessed One to explain and teach just a small portion of the root of virtue he created toward Dīpaṃkara. Blessed One, the time has come. Sugata, the time has come."

Then the Blessed One stretched out his golden right hand, and from the little finger of his hand there came forth the fragrance of divine utpala flowers. Then all the buddha fields of the great trichiliocosm world system, in which a billion moons and suns move, were pervaded by the fragrance of divine utpala flowers. Then the Blessed One, having displayed such a wondrous and marvelous phenomenon to the world with its gods, humans, and asuras, showed a small portion of the ripening of the meritorious deed that arises from generosity, and showed too that producing roots of virtue toward the buddhas is never wasted. Then he spoke these verses:

"Thus the buddhas are inconceivable,
And the Dharma of the buddhas is inconceivable too;
If one has faith in the inconceivable,
Its ripening is inconceivable.

All sentient beings, as many as there are,
Whether endowed with perception or without,
For many hundreds of millions of eons
Might all make offerings
To whatever pratyekabuddhas there are
And to arhats free of defilement,
For inconceivable millions of eons;
But beyond offering to all of these,
When someone joins palms just once
To a perfect buddha, whether living
Or passed into complete nirvāṇa,

That merit is far superior.

The buddhas' moral discipline is unbroken,
They have gained mastery over samādhi,
They have no doubt concerning any phenomena,
And they know with the eye of a buddha.

If someone, toward that Sugata, for a single moment,
Or else by day and night, cultivates loving-kindness,
An offering that could equal that merit
Exists nowhere in the three realms.

In times gone by, countless eons ago,
To the buddha Prabhākara, a god surpassing the gods,
Who had become the teacher of the world,
I performed no small number of virtuous deeds.
As I wandered on through countless eons,
That merit never came to be exhausted;
That very merit became my cause,
And through it I attained supreme awakening.

Out of tender love for all the world,
The hundreds of buddhas and thousands of millions of buddhas
To whom I made offerings in former lives,
Those supreme among humans, knew me well,
And those buddhas never came to disparage me;
Yet because I had not yet attained acceptance,
Although I practiced virtue, they did not prophesy,
'In future times it will be thus.'

When I beheld Dīpaṃkara, the Guide,
I scattered five utpalas then,
And spread out my locks before the Guide;
And when I had attained acceptance of nonarising,
Dīpaṃkara, abiding in the sky,
Declared, 'Countless eons from now, as lord of the Śākyas,
Of the Śākya clan, self-arisen, you will become a Victor.'
Thus the Guide then prophesied concerning me.

Since I first longed for supreme awakening,
And from then on, as I wandered for a long time,

I performed many virtuous deeds
And endured suffering for the sake of beings;
Of that merit, even a small measure
The guides of the world have not set forth.

Having seen beings without protector, sunk in suffering,
Whatever I gave in former times,
And, while I practiced the conduct, the Sugata Prabhākara
And whatever heroic buddhas I worshiped,
Who beheld my conduct in former times,
Their names I recite by day and night.
Two, three, five, or ten, or twenty,
Or thirty, or selecting from among them, I recite their names:
The foremost buddhas whom I worshiped in the past
While practicing the conduct for the sake of the world.

Just as I took upon myself many great sufferings,
Again and again in saṃsāra, and did not give up,
Of buddhas who practiced such hardships as these,
No other buddha like that has ever appeared.

While seeking many teachings that were well spoken,
Hundreds of heads and thousands of millions of heads
I gave away in former times, while in saṃsāra,
And renouncing realm and kingdom, I went forth.
While searching for this supreme Dharma,
I excelled in giving, moral discipline, and restraint,
And through diligence I realized supreme awakening;
Thus was I for immeasurable eons.

The buddhas, of great power and inconceivable,
Endowed with every quality and eminently exalted,
Well proclaim the inconceivable supreme Dharma,
And they teach the inconceivable path as well."

This completes the tenth chapter, on the merit of offerings.

Fascicle Five.

Then again the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, before the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Dīpaṃkara, I pleased

a tathāgata called Padmottara, and because I longed for this very unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, I scattered golden flowers over that blessed one. Before that, I pleased a tathāgata called Sarvābhibhū, and because I longed for this very omniscience, I scattered silver flowers over that blessed one as well.

After him, I pleased the Tathāgata called Atyuccagāmin, and for the sake of this very incalculable goal I scattered a handful of gold upon that Blessed One as well. After Atyuccagāmin, I pleased the Tathāgata called Yaśottara, and for the sake of this very wisdom of certain realization I scattered a handful of jewels upon that Tathāgata. After the Tathāgata Yaśottara there appeared a tathāgata called Śākyamuni, who bore the same name as I, and for the sake of this very noble path I scattered loose flowers upon him as well. After the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, I pleased the Tathāgata called Tiṣya, and for the sake of this very wisdom of certain realization I scattered red sandalwood powder upon that Blessed One as well. After the Tathāgata Tiṣya, I pleased the Tathāgata called Puṣya, and with unblinking eyes and a mind filled with faith I praised that Blessed One as well with a single verse for seven days and nights. After the Tathāgata Puṣya, I pleased the Tathāgata called Vipaśyin, and I scattered a handful of beans upon that Blessed One as well. After Vipaśyin, I pleased the Tathāgata called Śikhin, and I offered that Blessed One as well a precious robe. After Śikhin, I pleased the Tathāgata called Viśvabhū, and I offered that Blessed One as well excellent food.

Ānanda, in this Fortunate Eon the Tathāgata Krakucchanda appeared, and for the sake of this very self-arisen wisdom I practiced the holy life as his attendant. After Krakucchanda there appeared the Tathāgata called Kanakamuni, and I practiced the holy life as his attendant as well. After Kanakamuni there appeared the Tathāgata called Kāśyapa, and I practiced the holy life as Kāśyapa's attendant as well. With all of them, I did this out of desire for this very unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Thus, having crossed over, I carry across those who have not crossed; having been liberated, I liberate those who are not liberated; and having passed fully beyond sorrow, I bring those who have not passed fully beyond sorrow to pass fully beyond sorrow.

Ānanda, it is like this: out of desire for this very unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I thus showed reverence to these buddhas, these blessed ones, and to other immeasurable and countless ones as well; I honored them as gurus, served them and made offerings to them. Look at how

many buddhas I have attended upon, and how many qualities the Tathāgata possesses! Ānanda, by this explanation too you should understand that even the smallest root of virtue produced toward the Tathāgata becomes thus of great miraculous power, thus of great benefit, thus of great splendor, and thus vast. Ānanda, I produced roots of virtue toward inconceivable tathāgatas, and you should know that their ripening too is inconceivable. Ānanda, know that since I thus offered to the tathāgatas gifts that were unequaled, incomparable and infinite, their ripening too is infinite.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

When formerly I practiced the conduct of awakening,
I pleased Dīpaṃkara, supreme among two-legged beings.
I scattered five blue lotuses upon him,
And then the Guide prophesied my awakening.
After him the Victor Padmottara
Appeared, and him too I pleased.
Since I desired this sublime awakening,
I worshiped that Victor with golden flowers.
The guides who appeared after him were
Sarvābhibhū, endowed with every quality,
Atyuccagāmin and Yaśottara,
The bull of the Śākyas, Tiṣya, and likewise Puṣya,
The buddhas Vipaśyin, Śikhin, and Viśvabhū,
Krakucchanda and the guide Kanakamuni,
And, while I sought the sublime awakening,
Likewise the buddha Kāśyapa: these I worshiped.
While seeking this supreme awakening,
Having given rise to compassion for the sake of beings,
Those whom I worshiped as I practiced the supreme conduct
Were these and other guides of the past.
I worshiped those thousands of millions of buddhas,
And having perfected all the accumulations,
I attained awakening, sorrowless and peaceful.
Having subdued Māra together with his army and his mounts,
I turned the wheel of Dharma.
For the benefit of living beings I taught the Dharma.
Gods, nāgas, humans and kinnaras
I established in the supreme awakening of a buddha,

And I showed them the paths of bliss and peace.
Whatever buddhas are yet to come, and likewise śrāvakas,
Whoever wishes to be freed from all suffering,
Let those wise ones learn my qualities.

This concludes the eleventh chapter, on producing roots of virtue.

Then again the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, leave aside the benefits of the qualities of my having attained awakening. Ānanda, the qualities that arose in me while I practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva are not found even in pratyekabuddhas, so what need is there to mention śrāvakas or other beings? Ānanda, whatever hardships I underwent while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, I underwent them all for your sake. I gave up kingdoms and loved ones; I gave up sons, daughters, wives, servants, my own life, flesh, blood, bones, marrow, ears, nose, hands, feet and heads; and the many kinds of unbearable, harsh and violent feelings of suffering that I experienced were all for your sake as well.

Ānanda, when I was striving for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I performed difficult deeds and made great sacrifices, and for the sake of sentient beings I underwent many sufferings. Ānanda, if I were to recount them all, they would not be believed to be true. What need, then, to speak of putting them into words?

Ānanda, suppose it is told: "The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Śākyamuni, formerly, while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, underwent such unbearable, harsh and fierce feelings of suffering for your sake." And suppose that childish ordinary beings, thinking, "That Tathāgata performed exceedingly difficult deeds for our sake," generate compassion for even as long as a single four-line verse. Ānanda, the fruit of that resolve is nirvāṇa; I declare that it carries them all the way to final nirvāṇa. Ānanda, what need, then, to speak of generating roots of virtue toward me?

Ānanda, some foolish people here, without faith, of degenerate character, covered by boundless darkness, do not generate even as much compassion as a single four-line verse, nor any wish to benefit, nor any clear faith, when my bodhisattva conduct is recounted.

There are qualities by which one becomes superior, in order to accomplish unsurpassed nirvāṇa, qualities that are attained by finding great compassion

while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva. If these are not found even in pratyekabuddhas, how could they be found in śrāvakas? How could they be found in ordinary beings?

Ānanda, if the qualities I attained by finding great compassion while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva were present in pratyekabuddhas, Ānanda, then all of them would fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Because those qualities are embraced by great loving-kindness and great compassion, they are not present in pratyekabuddhas. Therefore they do not become tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, possessing the ten powers, having attained the four fearlessnesses, endowed with great loving-kindness and great compassion.

Ānanda, I recall that formerly, while I was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, seeking whatever virtue there was to do, my mind ever fearful of saṃsāra and steeped in great compassion for sentient beings, I had a dream such as this. I was seated on a great and broad summit of Sumeru, the king of mountains. There, the sentient beings dwelling in the spaces between the worlds, and the beings born in the great hells, cut down by the guardians of hell, their bodies blazing, ablaze all over, turned to flame, undergoing extremely unbearable, harsh and fierce feelings that rob one of life, came to where I was. When they had come, they joined their palms, bowed to me, and said: "Friend, you experience pleasant feelings, while we dwell amid the miserable, unbearable feelings of hell. We undergo extremely unbearable, harsh and fierce feelings that rob us of life, and we have no protector, no refuge and no ally. Holy being, if you wish it, you can free us from this suffering."

Ānanda, in that very dream I wept, and from my two eyes flowed tears like the great river Ganges. Such great compassion arose in me for those hell beings that I comforted them, saying, "Friends, do not be so afraid. I shall free you from this great suffering."

Ānanda, in that same dream I gathered those hell beings together and stroked their heads with my right hand. Ānanda, the instant I placed my right hand on the crowns of those hell beings, and the instant I said, "Beings, I have freed you; do not be afraid," the fire of the hells died down. And in that very instant, in that very moment, those hell beings came to experience pleasant feelings. Ānanda, the moment I woke from that sleep, I wrung those tears from my robe and collected them.

Ānanda, if even while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva I was endowed with such a quality of great compassion, what need to speak of now, when I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening? Ānanda, by this account you should understand that the qualities that arose in me while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva are not found even in pratyekabuddhas, so how could they be found in śrāvakas and childish ordinary beings? Ānanda, consider how, formerly, while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, the Tathāgata was endowed with a great compassion for sentient beings so vast that even describing it in words could not easily reach its end, and with such a mind intent on benefiting sentient beings.

Ānanda, long ago, in times past, many merchants set out on the great ocean in search of jewels, and their great ship, laden with wealth, broke apart in that very ocean. Then, because their ship was wrecked, those merchants became terrified and distraught. To save their lives, some crossed by clinging to planks, some swam with their arms, and some died.

At that time, the one among those many merchants who was their leader, Sārthavāha, swam across the great ocean. At that time five merchants who were being carried off by the great ocean called out to Sārthavāha, "O Sārthavāha, grant us safety!"

Ānanda, when they had said this, Sārthavāha said to those merchants: "O men, do not be afraid. I shall bring you safely out of this great ocean."

Ānanda, at that time the caravan leader Sārthavāha also carried a sharp blade on his person. He thought, "This great ocean does not abide together with a corpse. So I will surely part my body from its life, and in that way bring these merchants out of this great ocean." Having thought this, he had the merchants hold fast to his body: some climbed onto his back, some climbed onto his shoulders, and some clung to his thighs. He summoned great effort and roused the power of examining body and mind one by one. He gave the merchants fearlessness, and then, with a mind wholly suffused with great compassion, he cut off his own life with the sharp blade, and very swiftly he died. Then at once the corpse was carried out of the great ocean onto dry land. Then those five merchants, safe and with their aims accomplished, crossed the great ocean and came safely back to Jambudvīpa.

Ānanda, if you have any doubt or uncertainty, thinking that Sārthavāha at that time was someone else, Ānanda, you should not see it that way. Why is that? Ānanda, I myself was Sārthavāha at that time. Ānanda, the group of five

monks were at that time the five merchants. Ānanda, at that time too I rescued the five monks from the great ocean, and now as well I have rescued them from the great ocean of saṃsāra and set them in nirvāṇa, which is fearless and peaceful.

Ānanda, look at how many hardships the bodhisattva great beings undertake, and how many immeasurable qualities they possess. Ānanda, by this account too you should understand this: qualities such as these that bodhisattvas have are not found in pratyekabuddhas. Ānanda, if pratyekabuddhas had my qualities, they too would become tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas. But because they do not have these qualities, they do not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete enlightenment.

Ānanda, thus the bodhisattva great beings do what is difficult; they have great compassion and are tender toward all sentient beings. Yet some foolish people do not give rise to even a single moment of faith in me for the sake of actualizing the seed of unsurpassed, perfect and complete enlightenment and of unsurpassed final nirvāṇa. Ānanda, one who does a little accomplishes a little, and one who does it completely accomplishes it completely.

Ānanda, I have also shown my other deeds. Ānanda, if even the producing of a root of virtue that consists in giving rise to a single moment of faith does not go to waste, what need is there to speak of the higher ones? Ānanda, whatever root of virtue is placed in the Tathāgata, even the giving rise to a single thought focused on the Buddha, Ānanda, I declare that all of these are like the deathless nectar, and in the end they become the deathless nectar.

Ānanda, the Tathāgata should be recollected in every way. Ānanda, the Tathāgata should be recollected through mindfulness as well. Ānanda, the Tathāgata should be recollected through roots of virtue as well. Ānanda, the Tathāgata should be recollected through his family as well. Because of a likeness, I am of the solar lineage; that is, I was born into the lineage of Ikṣvāku, rich in abundant wealth. The solar lineage is free of darkness and gloom, it illuminates, and it gives light. Ānanda, I am a Śākya, and that is a name for a great family.

Ānanda, the Tathāgata is exalted by his clan, his lineage, his family, his wealth, his form, his land, his excellent major and minor marks, his powers, his fearlessnesses, and the unshared qualities of a buddha. Ānanda, the Tathāgata is exalted by all qualities and is perfect in family. Ānanda, the Tathāgata should be recollected through the experience of taste as well.

Ānanda, if the Tathāgata is to be recollected even through his being meaningful, his perfect prior training, his perfect aspiration, his moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the seeing of the wisdom of liberation, his loving-kindness, compassion, joy and equanimity, his deportment, his conduct and his practice, what need is there to speak of all the qualities of a buddha? Ānanda, through whatever aspects the Tathāgata comes to be recollected, through those very aspects the recollection has great miraculous power, great benefit, great splendor and great vastness. It is like the deathless nectar; it becomes filled with the deathless nectar and culminates in the deathless nectar.

Ānanda, if even I, with the wisdom of a buddha, cannot fathom to the end the qualities of that ground of the perfection of generosity that was present in my continuum when formerly I was a bodhisattva, what need is there to speak of what became my perfection of moral discipline, perfection of patience, perfection of diligence, perfection of meditative concentration, and perfection of wisdom? What need is there to speak of the other qualities of a bodhisattva? If, of the time when I had not yet been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect and complete enlightenment, it is not easy even for me, with the wisdom of a buddha, to fathom the limit of the bodhisattva qualities I then had, what need is there to speak of after I was prophesied? What need is there to speak of all the qualities of a buddha? Their limit would not be easy to fathom even in a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of eons. Why is that? Because the qualities of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, are immeasurable.

Ānanda, having seen this compelling reason, I say: whoever recollects the qualities of my conduct as a bodhisattva and gives rise to faith, Ānanda, the fruit of all those roots of virtue is nirvāṇa; I declare that in the end they will reach nirvāṇa.

"Ānanda, therefore do not grieve, do not lament. Ānanda, I have already accomplished the great welfare of you and of the world with its gods, and I have brought great benefit. I have taught the path by which to attain unsurpassed accomplishment and happiness, that is, nirvāṇa. Since I have already explained the practice, you must now strive at heedfulness."

Then the Blessed One addressed the entire Saṅgha of monks: "Monks, tonight at midnight the Tathāgata will pass into complete nirvāṇa. Monks, come here. Today will be the last time I see you, and the last of my instructions. Today will

be the last time you and I see each other, the last time we meet. Monks, afterward you will not see me, and I will not see you either. Therefore, monks, do not grieve, do not lament.

"Monks, from all that is dear and pleasing we become separated; we part from it, are divided from it, and are severed from it. Monks, whatever has been born, has come into being, is imputed, is conditioned, is intended, has arisen dependently, and is by nature subject to destruction, how could there be any situation in which it would not be destroyed? That is impossible. Monks, however long one may remain, one must certainly go on to the next life. Monks, for what has been born there is no escape from death. Whatever has become a formation is not permanent, not stable, not everlasting, and not of an unchanging nature. Monks, birth and death are suffering. Monks, those who have passed into complete nirvāṇa are at bliss. In order to attain what you have not attained, to realize what you have not realized, and to actualize what you have not actualized, strive, exert yourselves, make effort! Monks, the unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening of the buddhas, the blessed ones, and whatever other virtuous factors conducive to awakening there are, are attained through heedfulness. So strive at heedfulness. Monks, this is my instruction to you."

At that time, all who had gathered in that assembly, the monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen, the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras and mahoragas, Śakra (Indra), Brahmā and the world guardians, on hearing such advice and instruction from the Blessed One, were filled with suffering and sorrow, possessed of the utmost suffering and sorrow. Pierced by the great thorn of grief, they wept and shed tears, and raised a great cry: "The Blessed One passes into complete nirvāṇa far too soon! The Sugata passes into complete nirvāṇa far too soon! The eye of the world vanishes far too soon! The world becomes eyeless and blind far too soon! We are parted, divided and separated from such a precious being far too soon!"

Then the venerable Ānanda gazed at the Blessed One without blinking, looking and examining him, and when he heard those words from the Blessed One, weeping and lamenting, he fell to the ground from where he stood, like a tree that has been cut and toppled.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, enough! Do not grieve, do not lament. Ānanda, from all that is dear and pleasing we become separated; we part from it, are divided and severed from it. Did I not teach

from the very beginning that whatever has come into being, is conditioned, is intended, and has arisen dependently, how could it not perish? That is impossible."

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "When I am parted, divided and separated from such a Teacher, a precious being, the guide of beings, the leader of beings, the one cherished by all beings, the one on whom all beings rely, why, Blessed One, should I not grieve? Sugata, why should I not lament? Blessed One, when I am to be separated from the protector of the world, the one of great compassion, who benefits and loves the whole world, the precious eye that brings light, why should I not grieve and lament? Blessed One, it is a wonder that my heart has not burst into a hundred pieces. Blessed One, it is a wonder that I have not died right here where I am. Blessed One, it is a wonder that I have not crumbled right here where I am into many pieces, like a handful of chaff. Blessed One, I think that it is through the Blessed One's blessing that I have not died. Blessed One, if from tomorrow onward I shall not see such a precious being, the guide of the world, who benefits and loves the world, remaining here, why should I not grieve and lament?"

Then the Buddha, the Blessed One, said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, am I dear to you?"

He replied: "Blessed One, you are dear to me. Sugata, you are dear to me."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, how dear am I to you?"

He replied: "Blessed One, you are so dear to me that it is not easy to express in words, and, Blessed One, not easy to convey by any example either; that is how dear the Blessed One is to me, how dear the Sugata is to me. Blessed One, even if I were to give up my body and life for the Blessed One's sake, I would not be unhappy; that is how dear the Blessed One is to me, how dear the Sugata is to me. That the Blessed One is so dear to me, and that the Sugata is so dear to me, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata himself, knows."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, if I am dear to you, give me your right hand." Then the venerable Ānanda held out his right hand.

Then the Blessed One took the venerable Ānanda's hand in his own right hand, which was golden in color, soft and very tender, as if tinted with the finest lac dye, and said to the venerable Ānanda:

"Ānanda, if I am dear to you, then do what one does for someone who is dear. And what is the deed of one who holds me dear? Ānanda, I entrust and hand over to you this unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, accomplished over countless ten millions of eons, and this treasury of the jewel of the unsurpassed Dharma. So by all means act in accord with me. And having acted in accord with me, make it broad and extensive. Keep it unbroken. Do not become an inferior person.

"Ānanda, so that this Dharma and Vinaya spoken by the Tathāgata may flourish, not decline, be guarded and kept safe, and not go to waste, I shall give you an example. Through it some wise people will come to understand the meaning conveyed by the example.

"Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose that to a merchant or a householder who is rich, of great wealth, of great means, with many treasuries, many things under his authority, and many goods and possessions, of excellent family and excellent lineage, from a noble family, an only son is born. As soon as he is born, in order to develop his faculties, he learns writing, numbers, calculation, reckoning by hand, and other difficult crafts and difficult arts. When he has trained in these, at last that merchant or householder says to him: 'Son, all that I had to do for you I have done. You have also mastered writing, numbers, calculation, reckoning by hand, the difficult crafts and the difficult arts. This is my final time, so I hand over to you everything under my authority. Train in three things and dwell in this merchant's house. What are the three? Aspiration, diligence, and heedfulness.'

"Having thus instructed his only son very well, that merchant or householder dies. But that only son conducts himself heedlessly, and so he gains no wealth that he has not already gained, while the wealth he received from his father and forefathers is exhausted and gone. Ānanda, what do you think of that? Did that son of the merchant, or son of the householder, act according to his father's instruction?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One. No, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, did that father do for that son something of what a father does for a son?"

He replied, "He did, Blessed One. He did, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, in the same way the Tathāgata too is the father of the whole world, and he comforts you as one comforts an only son.

Ānanda, this is my final time, and this is my final instruction. So by all means preserve, through three things, this treasury of the jewel of my Dharma, this vessel of the jewel of the Dharma, this unsurpassed wealth of the Dharma, accomplished over countless hundreds of thousands of ten millions of trillions of eons, and abide in it. What are the three? Aspiration, diligence, and heedfulness.

"If, by these three things, you abide in this treasury of the jewel of the unsurpassed Dharma, accomplished over countless hundreds of thousands of ten millions of trillions of eons, then the roots of virtue not yet attained will be attained, and the virtuous qualities already attained will not decline. If you do not abide by the three things in this unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, accomplished over countless hundreds of thousands of ten millions of trillions of eons, then you will not attain the virtuous qualities not yet attained, and the virtuous qualities already attained will decline.

"And why is that? Ānanda, it is because I, the father of the world, the protector of the world, who wishes its welfare, wishes its benefit, wishes its happiness, wishes its success and ease, wishes it good, loving and compassionate, have done what was to be done. Now you must do it.

"Ānanda, this unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, accomplished over countless hundreds of thousands of ten millions of trillions of eons, will vanish through three things. What are the three? Lack of faith, not practicing, and not teaching. Therefore, Ānanda, in order to protect this treasury of the jewel of the sacred Dharma, strive with aspiration, diligence, and heedfulness toward faith, practice, and teaching. If you do so, then you, my sons, will have done the task of me, the lord of the Dharma and father of the world.

"Therefore, Ānanda, in order to entrust this treasury of the jewel of the unsurpassed Dharma extensively, I shall give you an example. Through it some wise people will come to understand the meaning conveyed by the example, and they will think: 'When the Blessed One Śākyamuni, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, was passing into parinirvāṇa, he, for our sake, took the venerable Ānanda by the hand with his right hand and entrusted to him this unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, accomplished over countless hundreds of thousands of ten millions of trillions of eons.' Thinking this, they will be greatly overjoyed and delighted.

"Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose a caravan leader has gone abroad, and whatever tasks he himself had, and whatever tasks all his fellow travelers had, have been completed. Ānanda, what do you think of that? Will that caravan leader come back to his own home, or will he stay right there abroad?"

He replied, "Blessed One, he will go back home. There is no question of his not going."

"Ānanda, in the same way the Tathāgata, the father of the world, the protector of the world, the guide of the world, the great caravan leader, having fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, has completed all that was to be done by the wisdom of a buddha, and nothing whatsoever of a buddha's work remains for him to do later. Now there is not a single sentient being to be tamed by the Buddha who is untamed or unpacified.

"Ānanda, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, do not pass into parinirvāṇa without having fully completed and fully attained three things. Only when they have carried out those three things, fully completed them, and fully attained them, does a Tathāgata then pass into parinirvāṇa.

What are the three? There may be a bodhisattva who, after the Tathāgata's teaching has disappeared, is to awaken fully into perfect and complete awakening only after an eon, or a hundred eons, or a thousand eons, or a hundred thousand eons, or a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of eons, and who has not yet come to abide in the irreversible state. If the Buddha, the Blessed One, sees that this bodhisattva's faculties are not yet fully matured for irreversibility, then, in order to bring that person to full maturity, he sustains an emanated body until that bodhisattva has attained the state of irreversibility. Then, having later prophesied that person's unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, only then do the tathāgatas pass into parinirvāṇa in the nirvāṇa element without any remainder of the aggregates. Therefore I have now prophesied and established in the state of irreversibility many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of bodhisattvas, Maitreya and the others, and out of compassion for beings I have completed these tasks of mine.

Furthermore, Ānanda, as long as the Buddha has not tamed all who are to be tamed in his presence, the Tathāgata does not pass into parinirvāṇa. Suppose that, at a time when other buddhas, blessed ones, are to appear many

thousands of eons hence, there is a person born in any of the five destinies, in that world system or in others, whom the Buddha knows is to be tamed by a buddha. And suppose he knows that after one year, or a hundred years, or a thousand years, or a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of years, or more than an eon, "That person will be tamed by me, and not by a śrāvaka or a pratyekabuddha." Then, knowing this through buddha wisdom, out of compassion for that person, he sustains an emanated body until that person has become fully mature, and only after that does he tame him. Ānanda, this is the second deed of the tathāgatas, having done which the buddhas, the blessed ones, later pass into parinirvāṇa.

Furthermore, Ānanda, there may be some matter in the Tathāgata's sūtras, Vinaya, or Mātṛkā, the scriptures of the Buddha's teaching, that needs to be asked about in his presence or acted upon, and that the śrāvakas, whether still in training or beyond training, are unable to understand, to compile, or to teach. And it may happen that, from the Saṅgha of monks of the buddhas, not even a single monk is able to ask the Tathāgata about it respectfully, thinking, "It might trouble the Tathāgata." In that case the Blessed One, the perfectly complete Buddha, by means of buddha wisdom, emanates an emanated monk, and that emanation asks the Tathāgata in full, "Blessed One, if such a matter arises in this way, how should it be handled?" The Tathāgata then says to that emanation, "Monk, handle that matter in this way. Having done this, do it in this way."

Those three points without whose completion the Tathāgata does not pass into parinirvāṇa, which the Tathāgata must certainly accomplish, I have done them all and brought them to completion. In this, I have laid down for the śrāvakas the discipline of training and the Prātimokṣa. I have taught the path. I have proclaimed the path of deliverance by which those who practice it truly bring suffering to an end. There remains nothing at all still to be done later. Therefore, Ānanda, you should not lay down what has not been laid down, and you should not abolish what has been laid down. Ānanda, train in the precepts just as they have been laid down. Ānanda, this is what you must do: be heedful, and delight in heedfulness. This is my final instruction, so do not grieve, and do not lament.

Ānanda, in the last watch of this night I shall pass into parinirvāṇa. Ānanda, I go to my own domain, my own sphere of activity. I will not come back to this world, nor will I go to a world beyond. From now on you will not see me, and I will not see you. Ānanda, the nirvāṇa element without any remainder of the

aggregates is peaceful, cool, stainless, free of dust, the utter stilling of all suffering, delightful nirvāṇa. There, there is no birth, no aging, no death, no sorrow, no lamentation, no suffering, unhappiness, or agitation, no harm, no meeting with what is unloved, and no parting from what is loved. Into it buddhas and assemblies of the buddhas' śrāvakas as numerous as the sands of the Ganges river have gone, are going, and will go. In that I delight.

Ānanda, look how beings do not delight in the nirvāṇa element without any remainder of the aggregates, and do not give rise to even a single thought endowed with what accords with liberation, which would become a seed for their attaining nirvāṇa. Ānanda, how could childish ordinary beings have any strength? Ānanda, all childish ordinary beings are without strength, and their strength is feeble. Ānanda, all these childish ordinary beings appear like grass, chaff, and straw. Ānanda, childish ordinary beings do not give rise to even a single thought endowed with what accords with liberation, which would become a seed of nirvāṇa. How could they have any strength? How could they even find a breath of relief? Ānanda, childish ordinary beings have no power of moral discipline, no power of samādhi, and no power of wisdom.

Ānanda, I am endowed with buddha powers that are immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, unfathomable, and limitless. I am endowed with the powers of moral discipline, samādhi, wisdom, liberation, and the knowledge and vision of liberation. I am endowed with the power of conscience, the power of shame before others, the power of accomplishment, the power of primordial wisdom, the power of abandonment, the power of merit, the power of discernment, the power of the faculties, the power of blessing, and the ten powers. Ānanda, even so, I delight in that nirvāṇa element.

Among them, those childish beings who have become doors of darkness, who are possessed of the qualities of ignorance, who wander in saṃsāra, and who delight in being bound by bonds, do not generate even a single thought in accord with what becomes a seed of nirvāṇa.

Ānanda, in the later time, in the final age, there will be those who praise, establish, and expound sūtras such as this one on the Tathāgata's parinirvāṇa. After the Tathāgata has passed away, they will listen to sūtras such as this one, spoken by the Tathāgata. Having heard them, even if they do not attain this element of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates, there will be those who enter this vessel of my precious Dharma. Ānanda, so that this very point may be understood extensively, I shall give you an analogy.

Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose many travelers cross a great wilderness, pass beyond a road made perilous by bandits, and reach a city where there is no fear. One man among them becomes separated from the many travelers and wanders astray. He follows after those many travelers, following the very path by which they went, and goes on with suffering, affliction, and great hardship, until he meets up with the many travelers again. In the same way, Ānanda, the Tathāgata, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, now expounds sūtras such as this. In the future there will be sons or daughters of noble family who, having heard such sūtras, will come to understand through their words this element of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates. Therefore I have established this city of the sacred Dharma. They will arrive and dwell in this city of my sacred Dharma, they will guard this treasury of my sacred Dharma, and they will also teach it correctly.

Ānanda, even if this unsurpassed, perfect awakening were entrusted for the sake of a single person, you would have to hold it well. How much more so when it is entrusted for the sake of countless hundreds of thousands of sentient beings! Therefore, Ānanda, I entrust to you this unsurpassed, perfect awakening, accomplished over ten million countless eons, and this treasury of the jewel of the sacred Dharma. By every means, make it accessible to the four faithful assemblies, introduce them to it, explain it, set it forth, unravel it, analyze it, and clarify it! Do not become a lowly person! Ānanda, there are sentient beings who degenerate because they have not heard sūtras such as this. Ānanda, some wise persons come to understand a meaning spoken through analogy, and therefore I shall give you an analogy.

Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose there were a merchant or householder who was rich, of great wealth and great possessions, of wide dominion, with many goods and implements, much wealth and grain, many dependents, and many treasuries and storehouses. His only son went abroad. That merchant or householder then fell ill, unwell and in great suffering, and when the time of his death arrived, he deposited with another householder jewels, pearls, beryl, conch, crystal, coral, gold, much silver, and many precious things. Having deposited those precious things, he said to that merchant or householder: "Please understand this. My only son has gone abroad. I am now ill and unwell, and before long I shall die. So for the sake of my only son I place these many jewels and treasuries in your hands. When my only son returns from abroad and is conscientious and abides in the conduct of conscientiousness, then give him these jewels. And having given them, instruct him thus: 'Young man, at

the point of death your father deposited these many jewels with me for your sake. This store of your father's wealth is your own property. Take it, guard it with care, and by every means do not squander it.'"

Then suppose that merchant or householder, having taken the many treasuries of jewels deposited by the other merchant, did not give the deposited treasury of jewels to the merchant's son when he returned from abroad. Ānanda, what do you think of that? Who would be at fault?

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, since he took the many jewels deposited by that merchant and did not give them to the merchant's son, the householder holding the deposit would be at fault."

He declared: "Ānanda, in the analogy I gave so that that point might be understood, what is the meaning to be seen? Ānanda, 'householder' is a term for the Tathāgata. Ānanda, 'at the time of death' is a term for the element of the Tathāgata's parinirvāṇa. Ānanda, 'only son' is a term for the faithful sons or daughters of noble family of the future. Ānanda, 'gone abroad' is a term for being born in the saṃsāra of the five destinies. Ānanda, 'great treasury of jewels' is a term for this jewel of the Dharma, accomplished over ten million countless eons. Ānanda, 'holder of the deposit' is a term for those like you who protect this city of the sacred Dharma, the great śrāvakas and the bodhisattva great beings."

"Ānanda, in this way I entrust this great treasury of the jewel of the Dharma, accomplished over ten million countless eons, to you, to Mahākāśyapa, to the bodhisattva Maitreya and the others, for the sake of the sons or daughters of noble family of the future. In the future, by every means, give this treasury of the jewel of the sacred Dharma to my children who have faith and clear devotion, in a way that suits them and through instruction. Why is that? Ānanda, there are beings whom I brought to maturity long ago, when I was a bodhisattva. Through wrongdoing and misconduct they have now sunk into the hells, into animal births, or into the world of Yama. After the Tathāgata has passed away, they will die and pass from there and be born as humans. Because their faculties have developed and they have been brought to maturity, they will come to faith in this teaching of mine with little difficulty. Some of them will go forth from home into homelessness. Some will remain in the household. Having heard a sūtra such as this of mine, they will reach distinction, and they will attain parinirvāṇa through the vehicle of the

śrāvakas, the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, or the Great Vehicle.

"Ānanda, this treasury of the jewel of the sacred Dharma, accomplished over countless hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of eons, I place in your hands for their sake, so that sons of noble family may hear it in this way. I place it in your hands. Why is that? Ānanda, these beings will fall away entirely through not hearing such paths of virtue as these. Therefore, Ānanda, so that they by no means fall away from hearing such teachings, I entrust those of the future to you.

"Ānanda, some learned persons here come to understand a meaning through an example. Therefore, so that this meaning may be understood extensively, I shall give you an example. Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose a universal monarch entrusted all his treasuries and storehouses to his treasurers and stewards, saying, 'O men, give gifts to ascetics, brahmins, the poor, wayfarers, the destitute and beggars: food to those who want food, drink to those who want drink, and vehicles, clothing, flowers, incense, garlands, ointments, bedding, dwellings, supports, and whatever requisites of life there may be.' Suppose that, after he had commanded and instructed them in this way, the treasurers and stewards opened those treasuries and storehouses but did not give the gifts. Ānanda, what do you think of that? Who would be at fault?"

He replied, "Venerable Blessed One, those treasurers and stewards would be at fault. The universal monarch would not be at fault."

The Blessed One said, "Likewise, Ānanda, I, the king of Dharma, have gathered this great storehouse of the Dharma. Having attained perfect and complete awakening, I made this treasury of the jewel of the Dharma, accomplished over ten million countless eons, vast and extensive, and I have analyzed it and taught it to gods and humans. The Dharma that I have taught I give to you as well, analyzed in full. Let ordinary childish beings, ascetics, brahmins, and householders whose faith is not in vain, all who desire the Dharma, listen to it.

"Ānanda, suppose that this treasury of my jewel of the Dharma, which I have analyzed and correctly taught and placed in your hands, you did not teach to faithful brahmins and householders, and did not show to ordinary childish beings who lack learning yet seek it, who have aspiration and faith and are devoted. In that case, Ānanda, you would have committed a wrong against the Tathāgata. Why is that? Ānanda, I am a king: the unsurpassed king of Dharma, the one who turns the wheel of Dharma, possessed of many vast treasuries of the jewel of the Dharma, possessed of many storehouses of qualities, lord of

the many factors of awakening, possessed of the seven precious limbs of awakening, one who has gained mastery of the ten powers and the four fearlessnesses, sovereign over all dharmas. So, for as long as the storehouse of the eighty-four thousand heaps of Dharma endures, give it without discrimination to faithful brahmins and householders, and to ordinary childish beings who seek it with faith, who have aspiration, who desire the Dharma, and who have become vessels for the Dharma. Do not become a base person!

"Ānanda, if you correctly teach to the four assemblies this unsurpassed perfect and complete awakening, accomplished over ten million countless eons, and this treasury of the unsurpassed jewel of the Dharma, then, Ānanda, you will not be committing a wrong against the Tathāgata. But if you do not teach them correctly, you will be committing a wrong.

"Ānanda, a monk, an arhat whose defilements are exhausted, who has attained the unconditioned dharma yet does not explain it to others and does not correctly teach it, does not honor the Teacher. He does not uphold my sacred Dharma. Why is that? Ānanda, some learned persons here come to understand a meaning through an example, so I shall give you an example. Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose there is a merchant or a householder who is rich, of great wealth, of great possessions, with many storehouses, with abundant wealth, grain, goods and supplies, possessing much in the way of jewels, pearls, beryl, conch, crystal, coral and silver. Some adversary or enemy of his sets fire to that storehouse. Those others who are unfriendly to him, adversaries who have become his enemies, who wish him no benefit, who wish him no happiness, who do not wish him success and happiness, see the fire burning the storehouse and do not put it out, but stand idly by. Those who are his friends, who wish him benefit, who wish him happiness, who wish him success and happiness, also see that great mass of fire burning all that wealth and grain, and they too stand idly by. And the friends, relatives and blood kin of that merchant or householder, who wish for his welfare, his success and his happiness, see that fire and do not put it out, but stand idly by. Would they be acting rightly?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One. No, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, suppose there were merchants or householders who desired benefit, desired welfare, desired happiness, and desired success and happiness. If they saw a fire burning their storehouses and remained negligent about putting out the fire in those storehouses, would

that mass of fire not spread and burn up all the storehouses?"

He replied, "So it is, Blessed One. So it is, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, in the same way, when this unsurpassed storehouse of the jewel of the Dharma, which I accomplished through roots of virtue over countless ten millions of eons, is being destroyed and is disappearing, there will appear monks who are without faith, of corrupt moral discipline, given over to evil practices, led by haughtiness, who have abandoned striving for solitude, who are indolent, lazy and of little learning. They will not even have any wish to listen, so how could they ever cause others to listen in order to uphold this jewel of the Dharma? Such monks will appear. If childish ordinary people who lack learning see such a storehouse of the jewel of the Dharma burning with fire and remain negligent about putting out that fire, Ānanda, what do you think? Will they not fall away entirely from such a jewel of the Dharma? There will also appear monks who are arhats, whose defilements are exhausted, who, having directly realized the unconditioned, remain neglecting the explanation and teaching of the Dharma. They too will not have honored the Teacher, nor will they uphold my sacred Dharma. Because the unsurpassed treasury of the jewel of the Dharma is thus not explained and not caused to be read, it will decline."

He replied, "So it is, Blessed One. So it is, Sugata."

"Ānanda, so that some learned persons here may understand the meaning that is spoken through an example, and in order to make this meaning extensively complete, I shall give you an example. Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose a certain man, in the pitch-black darkness of night, carrying a grass torch, goes to his own house, and there many people who wish to escape that pitch darkness have gathered. Having escaped the pitch darkness by means of that grass torch, the man enters his own house, puts out the torch, and gives it to no one. Ānanda, what do you think? If, while he has the torch, he does not give the grass torch to any of the many people sitting there who wish to escape that darkness, Ānanda, if that person acts in this way, is he doing what is good?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One. No, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, in the same way, if a monk who is an arhat, whose defilements are exhausted, having directly realized the unconditioned dharma, does not explain this treasury of the jewel of the Dharma accomplished over countless ten millions of eons, does not teach it, and does

not spread it to others, then, Ānanda, he has not honored the Teacher, and he has not upheld my sacred Dharma. Therefore, Ānanda, I entrust to you this treasury of the jewel of the Dharma accomplished over countless ten millions of eons. By every means, teach it extensively to others so that its stream is not cut off and this path of virtue continues without interruption. Do not become an inferior person!"

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"Ānanda, whatever monk, nun, layman or laywoman practices these teachings oneself and also explains and teaches them to others, Ānanda, to that person I give a share of this treasury of the jewel of the Dharma that I accomplished over countless ten millions of eons, and I set aside a portion for them. Therefore, Ānanda, for the sake of those future beings, I entrust to you a second time this awakening accomplished over countless ten millions of eons, lest those beings fall away entirely through not hearing such a treasury of the jewel of the Dharma. Ānanda, many beings will fall away entirely through not hearing such a treasury of the jewel of the Dharma. Ānanda, on the strength of this matter I entrust to you this awakening of a buddha accomplished over countless ten millions of eons. See to it that those beings do not fall away from such a treasury of the jewel of the Dharma!

"Ānanda, in this some learned persons will understand the meaning that is spoken through an example; therefore I shall give you an example. Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose an anointed kṣatriya king had an only son, who went abroad. After he had gone abroad, the kṣatriya king fell ill. Having fallen ill, he placed many treasuries of jewels in the hands of trusted custodians skilled in jewels, and said, 'Householders, when my son who has gone abroad returns from abroad and has been installed as king, then say to him, "These many treasuries of jewels were left by your father when he was dying," and give these many treasuries of jewels to him.' Having spoken thus and given these instructions very carefully, the king died. After he had died, the prince returned from abroad and was installed as king. If then the treasurers and those householders to whom the treasuries had each been entrusted did not give the treasuries of jewels to the prince who had gained sovereign power and was established in the kingship, Ānanda, what do you think? Would the treasurers or those householders be wronging that king?"

He replied, "So it is, Blessed One. So it is, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, what should be seen as the meaning of the example I gave you so that the meaning might be understood? Ānanda, 'anointed kṣatriya king' is a designation for the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, the great king of the Dharma. Ānanda, 'only son' is a designation for future sons and daughters of good family who have faith. Ānanda, 'went abroad' is a designation for the five destinies. Ānanda, 'the one who fell ill' is a designation for the parinirvāṇa of the Tathāgata.

Ānanda, "many treasuries of jewels" is a figurative expression for the thirty-seven factors of awakening. Ānanda, "householder" is a figurative expression for the arhats. Ānanda, a king, when the time of his death comes, leaves his wealth in trust. In the same way, Ānanda, I entrust to you the treasury of my precious Dharma, which I accomplished over ten million countless eons, for the sake of the sons and daughters of good family who will come in the future.

Why is that? Ānanda, there are beings whom I have brought to maturity who, because of certain unwholesome courses of action, have been born among the hell beings, among the animals, and in the world of Yama. After my passing they will die and transmigrate from there and obtain a human existence. Because their faculties have developed and because they have matured, they will come to have faith in this teaching of mine. Some of them, out of faith, will go forth from home into homelessness. Some will remain living in the household. Some of them will attain the fruit of stream-entry. Some will attain the fruit of once-returner, some the fruit of non-returner, and some will realize arhatship. Some will die while still at the stage of training. Some, with superior intention, will give rise to the mind set on the stage of buddhahood. Some will cultivate roots of virtue in order to be born among gods and humans, and so they will come to possess each of those attainments. Some will attain a single moment of serene faith. Thinking, "The Father of the World has entrusted it well to us," they will become vastly faithful and will give rise to serene trust.

Ānanda, it is so that they may hear this precious Dharma that I entrust this treasury of the precious Dharma to you. Ānanda, if you do not lead those faithful sons and daughters of good family to hear this treasury of my precious Dharma, then, Ānanda, you will be committing an offense against the Tathāgata. Why is that? Ānanda, because when those sons and daughters of good family hear such a precious Dharma, some of them will attain distinction, some will become overjoyed and delighted, and some, through the force of the Dharma, will shed tears and their hair will stand on end. Ānanda, as for those

who, hearing such a discourse on the Dharma, recollect my qualities and, through the force of the Dharma, shed tears and feel their hair stand on end, Ānanda, the fruit of all those roots of virtue is nirvāṇa. I declare that in the end they will pass into nirvāṇa.

Ānanda, those monks who hold such a discourse on the Dharma, yet do not explain the Dharma or teach it to the faithful sons and daughters of good family who long for the Dharma and come to them, are committing an offense against the Tathāgata. Ānanda, if they cause those sons and daughters of good family who seek the Dharma and wish to listen, the listeners, to be deprived of hearing the Dharma, then, by not teaching those who are thus suitable vessels, they are engaged in ruining the roots of virtue in their own mindstream and utterly ruining the roots of virtue in the mindstreams of others. Why is that? Because they do not know to whom the Dharma should be taught and to whom it should not be taught. Therefore, Ānanda, so that this point may be understood at length, I shall give you an example.

Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose a certain merchant of childish nature, returning from abroad with many jewels, came into a great wilderness where there were bandits, spread out his wares there, called out to the gangs of thieves, and said, "Hey, men! Look how fine and how beautiful these wares are! You men, buy these wares of mine!" Ānanda, if in that wilderness those bandits beat that childish merchant painfully with clubs and robbed him of all his jewels, Ānanda, what do you think? Was that merchant, who spread out his wares in the wilderness and called to the bandits, acting in accordance with the Dharma?

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, if even spreading out wares in a wilderness where there are bandits is not in accordance with the Dharma, what need is there to mention spreading out wares and calling to the bandits? Blessed One, to act in this way would be in accordance with the Dharma: if that merchant were to hide his wares well, carry a bow and arrows, put on good armor, and come safely out of that wilderness, that would be in accordance with the Dharma."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, suppose that merchant of childish nature, carrying many heaps of wealth and many jewels, returned from abroad and came to villages, towns, market towns, provinces, and royal capitals, and spread out his wares. And suppose skillful and wise people who wanted goods came to buy those

precious, highly valuable jewels displayed there, and then that merchant took up a bow and arrows and attacked those people who had come wanting goods. Ānanda, what do you think? If that man acted in this way, would it be in accordance with the Dharma?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One. No, Sugata. Blessed One, that merchant should act in this way: he should say to those people who seek goods, 'Come here, gentlemen! Look how fine and how beautiful these many excellent kinds of goods are, and buy them! I will give them at a low price.' Blessed One, it is fitting for that merchant to act in this way. If he acts in this way, that is in accordance with the Dharma. But to spread out his wares at the time for trade and then come wearing armor is not fitting."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, in the same way, some monks here fully master the many treasuries of the jewel of the Dharma, namely the division of discourses, the division of sung verses, the division of prophetic expositions, the division of verses, the division of inspired utterances, the division of introductory accounts, the division of legends, the division of accounts beginning 'thus it happened,' the division of birth stories, the division of extensive teachings, the division of marvelous phenomena, and the division of definitive instructions. Yet they do not teach where there are people who are vessels for this treasury of the jewel of the Dharma and receive it. Such people, on hearing it, would attain distinction, would find joy and great supreme joy, and by that root of virtue would pass into nirvāṇa. Instead they teach where there are people who are not vessels for this jewel of the Dharma. Such people, on hearing it, do not become clear in mind, do not gain faith, and do not take it to heart, but reject it, and that root of non-virtue leads them into the three lower realms.

"Ānanda, it is like this. That merchant of childish nature does not lay out his goods where it is proper to lay them out, but lays them out where they should not be laid out. He does not give to those to whom it is proper to give, but gives to those to whom it is not proper to give. In the same way, Ānanda, I see that there are also some who do not teach the Dharma to the sons and daughters of good family who have come to them, who have devoted faith, who are endowed with the Dharma, who long for the Dharma, who wish to listen, who wish to practice, and who have become vessels. Instead they teach those to whom it is not proper to teach, and do not teach those to whom it is proper to teach.

"Therefore, Ānanda, the Dharma should be taught to those who are vessels, who are clear in mind, who wish to listen, and who seek nirvāṇa. You should train yourselves in this way: 'We will not teach those who are not vessels, who lack faith, who look for an opening to attack, who are immoral, who are of evil character, whose intention is to find fault, who reject the Dharma, who live in opposition to the true Dharma, and who make it mere talk and do not teach the Dharma in accordance with it.' Why is that? Ānanda, you should train yourselves thinking, 'Lest those foolish people, on hearing it, be utterly ruined.'

"Ānanda, do not grow weary. Ānanda, if one teaches the Dharma respectfully to monks who seek its meaning, and they in turn listen respectfully, then, Ānanda, both of them generate vast merit, and generate merit that is immeasurable and incalculable.

"Ānanda, what do you think? Which is greater, the earth element or the realm of sentient beings?"

Ānanda replied, "Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has taught, Blessed One, the realm of sentient beings is far greater."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, it is just as you say. Ānanda, the realm of sentient beings is far greater, not the earth element. Ānanda, the realm of sentient beings is far greater, not the water element, not the fire element.

"Ānanda, take this as a supposition. Suppose that all who exist as sentient beings in the great trichiliocosm, whether they have become clearly visible or have not become visible, were all to obtain human bodies in a single instant, a single moment, a single second, and that, having obtained human bodies, they were to attain the awakening of a pratyekabuddha in a single instant, a single moment, a single second.

"And Ānanda, take this as a supposition. Suppose that in endless, immeasurable world systems, however much earth element there is, a mass of earth whose end cannot be seen, and however many particles of atoms there are in that mass of earth, as many as all those particles of earth were to become humans. And Ānanda, suppose that those who had become humans were also to attain the awakening of a pratyekabuddha in a single instant, moment, and second, with none earlier or later.

"And Ānanda, take this as a supposition. In endless, immeasurable world systems there are the Sumerus, the kings of mountains, the Cakravāla, king of

mountains, and the Great Cakravālas, the snow mountains, Gandhamādana, and the other black mountains; and in the great trichiliocosm there are grasses, trees, leaves, saplings, forests, thickets, medicinal plants, and groves. Suppose that as many particles of atoms as there are in all of these, whatever exists as an entity or appears as something that can be examined and seen, were all to become humans. And Ānanda, suppose that those who had become humans were also to attain the awakening of a pratyekabuddha in a single instant, moment, and second, with none earlier or later. Ānanda, suppose those pratyekabuddhas were to remain for a long time, for as long as the beginning of saṃsāra cannot be seen. Then suppose a single householder were to appear among them, not counted within that realm of sentient beings, and he too were to live for as long as the beginning of saṃsāra cannot be seen. Then, with such a lifespan, that householder honors those pratyekabuddhas with robes, food, bedding, medicine for the sick, and every comfort; he reveres them, serves them, and makes offerings to them. And for those who have passed into parinirvāṇa he builds stūpas made of the seven precious substances, and with the parasols, victory banners, and flags of gods and humans, with flowers, garlands, incense, ointments, powders, cloth, song and dance, and music, he makes offerings as gods and humans do; he honors, reveres, serves, respects, and venerates them. Ānanda, what do you think? On that basis, would that householder generate much merit?"

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "As I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has taught, even honoring a single noble one generates much merit, incalculable, inconceivable, and unequaled. What need even to mention honoring such an assembly of pratyekabuddhas as this?"

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, I instruct you. You should understand this.

...pratyekabuddhas endowed with moral discipline, and endowed with the aggregates of meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the seeing of the wisdom of liberation, all of them purifying that householder's offering. Compare this, Ānanda: a single Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete Buddha, appears in the world. Having appeared, he makes use of the robes, food, bedding, medicine for the sick, and other requisites offered by that householder. Having made use of them, he does not even teach the Dharma to that householder, who does no more than see that Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete Buddha. Even so, Ānanda, that Tathāgata purifies that vast offering

merely by displaying his natural deportment. Yet in the way that the Tathāgata, by displaying his natural deportment, purifies the offering, all the pratyekabuddhas endowed with the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the seeing of the wisdom of liberation would not purify the offering even in a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of eons.

Why is that? Ānanda, if even the deportment of the Tathāgata possesses so many qualities, immeasurable, countless, and inconceivable, whose limit is not easy to reach, what need is there to speak of the other qualities of a buddha?

Ānanda, there are offerings made to pratyekabuddhas, and there are cases where such an offering becomes immeasurable and incalculable. Yet, Ānanda, even among the immeasurable, incalculable, and boundless there are distinctions, and there are differences to be drawn. Ānanda, such offerings exist; it is not that they do not exist. But Ānanda, when an offering is made resting upon one such as me, relying on one such as me, it is not easy even to find an example for that offering. Why is that? Because, Ānanda, that offering is immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, unequaled, incalculable, and inexhaustible.

Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose some person sets out in search of profit, then gains a profit and comes back. In the same way, Ānanda, I regard an offering made to pratyekabuddhas as being like that. Concerning offerings made to one such as me, resting upon one such as me, Ānanda, I shall give you an example so that you may understand this very point in detail, for in this way some wise persons come to understand the meaning of what is said through an example.

Ānanda, it is like this. Suppose some person is drawing a picture, and he draws it badly, and having drawn it badly he wipes away just a little here and a little there. Ānanda, that picture has some beauty, yet there are others far more beautiful than it. In the same way, Ānanda, an offering directed to those such as me becomes more extensive than one directed to all the pratyekabuddhas. Why is that? Ānanda, the wisdom of the pratyekabuddhas, the wisdom by which they come to be counted as what are called pratyekabuddhas, arises from this. The Tathāgata is especially skilled in knowing all phenomena.

Ānanda, what do you think? If someone honors the Tathāgata for as long as he lives with robes, food, bedding, medicine for the sick, and every requisite,

holds him in high esteem, serves him, and venerates him, does that person generate much merit?

Ānanda replied, "Blessed One, it is so. Sugata, it is so. Whoever honors the Tathāgata for as long as he lives generates much merit. Blessed One, if even generating a single thought of faith in the Tathāgata produces, on that basis, much merit, immeasurable, inconceivable, and countless, what need is there to mention someone who honors the Tathāgata for as long as he lives, holds him in high esteem, serves him, and venerates him?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Ānanda:

"Ānanda, leave aside someone who, for as long as he lives, honors a single Tathāgata with every requisite of comfort. Suppose instead there were two, or three, or four, or five, or ten, or twenty, or thirty, or forty, or fifty, or a hundred, or a thousand, or ten million, or a billion, or ten billion, or a trillion, or a hundred thousand koṭis of nayutas.

Ānanda, suppose that Jambudvīpa became entirely filled with tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas. Suppose the same of a great world system of four continents, of a world system of a second-order thousand, and of a great trichiliocosm. In such a world system there are a billion moons, a billion suns, a billion Sumerus, a billion Cakravāla mountain ranges, a billion great oceans, a billion Jambudvīpas, a billion Videhas in the east, a billion Kurus in the north, and a billion Godānīyas in the west, all of them encircled by eighty thousand continents. There are a billion great worlds of four continents, a billion heavens of the Four Great Kings, and a billion each of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, Yāma, Tuṣita, Nirmāṇarati and Paranirmitavaśavartin. From a billion Brahmakāyika heavens up to a billion Akaniṣṭha heavens, all this is called a great trichiliocosm.

Suppose all of it became completely filled with tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, as densely as a thick stand of sugarcane, a dense field of rice, a dense field of sesame, a dense growth of arrow reeds, a dense thicket of bamboo, a dense bed of reeds, a dense grove of acacia, or a dense growth of kuśa grass. And, taking it merely as a supposition, suppose those buddhas, those blessed ones, remained for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges. Suppose a single householder appeared there, and that householder also lived for that long. For as long as they lived, he honored those buddhas, those blessed ones, with robes, food, bedding, medicine for

the sick, and other requisites, revering them, serving them, and making offerings to them. And for the relics of the buddhas, the blessed ones who had passed into complete nirvāṇa, he built stūpas of the seven precious substances in worship of the relics. He honored them, revered them, served them, and made offerings to them with divine parasols, victory banners, flags and the like; with every kind of incense and ointment; with flowers and garlands, and with every kind of utpala, lotus, kumuda and white lotus; with every kind of song and every kind of music; and with all the fine offerings of gods and humans, from flowers to cymbals and the clapping of hands. Ānanda, what do you think of that? Would that householder generate much merit on that basis?"

Ānanda replied, "Blessed One, even if that householder offered food to a single Tathāgata, he would generate much merit. How much more need be said of honoring, revering, serving, and making offerings to such an immeasurable, countless host of tathāgatas remaining for so many eons, and of honoring the stūpas of those who had passed into complete nirvāṇa in such a way! Blessed One, the heap of merit of that householder who so honored such a host of tathāgatas cannot be shown by any example, as though one could say, 'On that basis he generates this much merit.'"

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, I instruct you. Ānanda, you should understand this. Compare it with the merit generated by the householder who honored, revered, served, and made offerings to so many tathāgatas remaining for so many eons, and who honored the stūpas of those who had passed into complete nirvāṇa in such a way. Ānanda, suppose a son or daughter of good family, abounding in faith and engaged with superior intention, has faith and trust in the awakening of the buddhas, the blessed ones, without doubting. Suppose that, with conviction, they properly enter into the well-spoken Dharma that teaches that all phenomena are impermanent, suffering, empty, or selfless, and speak of it in words. Ānanda, this one generates far more merit than that.

Ānanda, see how vast, how measureless, how countless, how inconceivable, how unequaled and how immeasurable is the merit generated by one who honors such an unsurpassed Jewel of the Dharma and explains it or teaches it to others. And why is that? Because, Ānanda, other gifts are accompanied by defilements and accompanied by afflictions, and they keep one wandering in saṃsāra; but, Ānanda, this unsurpassed treasury of the Jewel of the Dharma, free of material things and accomplished over countless koṭis of eons, cuts the

stream of saṃsāra.

Ānanda, when they hear this unsurpassed Jewel of the Dharma, beings who are subject to birth become completely free from birth. Beings subject to sickness, subject to death, to sorrow, to lamentation, to suffering, to unhappiness, and to agitation become completely free of all of these, up to agitation. Ānanda, seeing this point, I declare that the one who respectfully explains the Dharma and the one who respectfully listens to the Dharma both generate much merit."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, suppose one who is engaged with superior intention and wishes to practice properly has faith in the teaching of the buddhas, the blessed ones, without doubting, and with conviction trusts that the Dharma is well spoken, that the Saṅgha has entered well, and that all formations are impermanent, or suffering, or peaceful, or empty, or selfless. Ānanda, this one generates far more merit than that, and these are not mere words."

"Ānanda, suppose someone makes the Dharma a matter of vital concern, takes it to mind, reflects on it with all their heart, and listens to the Dharma with attentive ears. Having heard it, suppose they fully understand, even for just the time of a finger-snap, as it truly is, that things are impermanent, or suffering, or empty, or selfless. Ānanda, the sentient beings in the realm of beings throughout the limitless, endless world systems are vastly many; they are more, it is said, than the element of earth, the element of water, the element of fire, or the element of wind. Suppose all of them, in a single instant, a single moment, a single second, without one before another, were to become human. Suppose that in a single instant, a single moment, a single second, they all became fully awakened in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Suppose there were also a single householder. Suppose those buddhas, those blessed ones, remained for a long time, for as long as the beginning of saṃsāra cannot be found, and that householder too lived for that many eons. Suppose he venerated, esteemed, served and worshiped those countless buddhas, those blessed ones, with robes, food, bedding, medicines for the sick, requisites, and every comfort. And suppose that for those who had passed into parinirvāṇa he built stūpas made of the seven precious substances, and venerated, esteemed, served and worshiped them with divine parasols, banners and flags, with flowers, garlands, incense, every kind of unguent, and all his possessions. Ānanda, what do you think of that? Would that householder generate much merit on that basis?"

Ānanda replied, "Blessed One, even if that householder pleased, venerated, esteemed, served and worshiped a single tathāgata, he would generate much merit on that basis. He would generate merit that is immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incomparable and unfathomable. What need is there to mention venerating, esteeming, serving and worshiping such a host of tathāgatas for that many eons?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, so it is. It is just as you say: he generates immeasurable merit. Therefore, Ānanda, I instruct you, and you should understand this. The householder generates merit by venerating, esteeming and serving that many tathāgatas for that many eons with every comfort and requisite. But suppose someone makes the Dharma a matter of vital concern, takes it to mind, reflects on it with all their heart, listens to the Dharma with attentive ears and one-pointed mind, and even for the time of a finger-snap brings to mind, 'All formations are impermanent, or suffering, or peaceful, or empty, or selfless.' This generates far more merit than that. Ānanda, one who teaches the Dharma with respect and one who listens to the Dharma with respect generate far more merit. Ānanda, it was with this in mind that I said:

For the sake of a twofold aim,
One should listen to what the Buddha teaches:
The defilements are exhausted,
And awakening, it is held, draws near.
Whoever teaches the Dharma
And whoever holds the banner of the sage,
Both of them come to possess merit.

The Dharma, I said, is the banner of the sage."

Then the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, these two, one who teaches the Dharma with respect and one who listens to the Dharma with respect, are joining battle with Māra. Why is that? Ānanda, being a spiritual friend, being a virtuous companion, and having a spiritual friend: this is what brings the holy life to completion. Why is that? Ānanda, by relying on a spiritual friend, beings subject to birth are completely freed from birth, and so on up to: beings subject to distress are completely freed from distress.

"Ānanda, I told the śrāvakas that there are two causes and two conditions for the arising of right view, namely the voice of another and one's own proper attention. That too is the same point. Ānanda, of these, the voice of another

should be understood to come from the buddhas, the blessed ones. And one's own proper attention should also be understood to come from the buddhas, the blessed ones themselves. Why is that? Ānanda, it is because childish ordinary beings have no proper attention of their own. Why is that? Because if buddhas did not appear, childish ordinary beings would not know what to attend to, and it is the Tathāgata himself who teaches, 'Attend to these dharmas.' Ānanda, seeing this point, I said that one's own proper attention too should be understood to come from the buddhas, the blessed ones."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

It is good to see holy beings;
They cut through and dispel all doubts,
And make even the childish truly learned.
Therefore it is good to see the wise.

To see the noble ones is happiness;
To keep company with the holy is happiness too.
By not seeing the childish,
One is always happy among the holy.

"Ānanda, when I said, 'A spiritual friend, being a virtuous companion, and a spiritual friend free of deceit: this is what brings the holy life to completion,' I spoke those words with this in mind. Why is that? Ānanda, by relying on a spiritual friend, the mind becomes virtuous. Because the mind is virtuous, one's intention becomes virtuous and one's practice becomes virtuous. One's mind becomes clear in faith toward virtuous dharmas, and one comes to abide closely in virtuous dharmas. One gains faith, through understanding, in the buddhas, the blessed ones; one gains faith, through understanding, in the Dharma; one gains faith, through understanding, in the Saṅgha. And one attains the moral disciplines that please the noble ones, that make one free, that are praised by the wise, and that lead to nirvāṇa. Ānanda, it is like this: when heavy rain falls, it fills the hollows to the brim.

Once the ponds are completely full, they make the streams overflow. Once the streams overflow, they make the great rivers overflow. The overflowing great rivers fill the great ocean completely.

In the same way, Ānanda, those who have spiritual friends, who have become virtuous companions, who are fully endowed with virtue, for whom virtue is foremost, and who, relying on the virtuous mind itself, have attained the generation of the power of the roots of virtue, will, by practicing all the way to

the Dharma in accordance with the Dharma, become utterly consummate, utterly stainless, utterly devoted to the pure life, and utterly perfected.

Ānanda, look how even these external things, when their time comes, grow and put forth flowers, branches, and fruit. Ānanda, if even these external things do not prove false, what need is there to say that your good conduct will not prove false? That is impossible. Ānanda, good conduct deceives no one. Practice good conduct! Ānanda, I too have not been deceived by good conduct. Ānanda, formerly, when I practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, I practiced whatever good conduct there was, and that good conduct did not deceive me.

Ānanda, look how, on whatever road the Tathāgata travels, all the uneven ground, ravines, precipices, potholes, hollows, tree stumps, and dense thorns bow down and vanish; low ground becomes high and high ground becomes low; the trees bow deeply; the tree gods pay homage; and whatever people are sitting in the marketplaces and streets follow after the Tathāgata as he goes, and once the Tathāgata has passed, they sit again in their own places.

Ānanda, look at this result that accords with its cause, the good conduct of having always, in the past, shown respect, bowed, and paid homage to the buddhas, the blessed ones, to pratyekabuddhas, to arhats, to bodhisattvas, to pleasing spiritual friends, and to śramaṇas and elder brahmins. Ānanda, look at the distinction of good conduct by which even mindless external things bow and pay homage to the Tathāgata and rise up, and by which whatever things ought to be low or ought to be high become low or high the moment they see the Tathāgata. Yet here some foolish people, overwhelmed by pride, corrupted by pride, their minds tormented by pride, bow to no one.

Ānanda, look how the webbed hands and webbed feet of the Tathāgata have all come from good conduct. Ānanda, look at those good deeds of the past by which I formerly gathered sentient beings through generosity, pleasant speech, beneficial conduct, and consistency of purpose.

Ānanda, formerly, when I practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, I was not like that, thinking, "This is my mother, this is my father, this is a brother, this is a sister, this is a relative, this is a friend, this is an enemy." Rather, Ānanda, toward all sentient beings I had a mind of a single taste, an even mind with no uneven mind, and I regarded them as my own heart.

Ānanda, throughout this long time, a sentient being whom I have not taken in through generosity, pleasant speech, beneficial conduct, and consistency of

purpose is not easy to find, yet childish ordinary people do not know that they were taken in like this. Just as the beginning of saṃsāra is not evident, so childish ordinary people have experienced happiness. Ānanda, far greater than the happiness that all childish ordinary people have experienced through the merit they themselves accumulated is the happiness that I have bestowed and brought about for even a single sentient being. The happiness that I have bestowed on sentient beings, those beings never experienced through merit they themselves accumulated.

Yet, Ānanda, all those bestowals of happiness are impermanent and subject to change. All the bestowals of happiness that I offered to childish ordinary people when I formerly practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva served solely to ripen them in order to establish them on this path. The happiness with which I have now made you happy, the unconditioned happiness, the noble, undefiled happiness, will never later change or be lost.

Therefore, Ānanda, do the work with noble wisdom! Ānanda, do the work through the work of wisdom! I have done mine.

Ānanda, as for other practices too, I have already explained the karmic ripening of the root of virtue that comes from generating even a single thought of faith. Ānanda, there are sentient beings who have made roots of virtue, who have generated roots of virtue, and who have generated the seeds of nirvāṇa. Ānanda, there are also sentient beings who, rightly recollecting the Tathāgata, shed tears from mere joy or mere faith when they hear that I have come to an end and passed away like this. Ānanda, there are also sentient beings who, recollecting the Tathāgata, sigh deeply, and there are those whose hair stands on end. Those sentient beings will not go to the hells, the animal realm, or the world of Yama, and they are certainly bound for perfect and complete awakening.

Likewise, Ānanda, all those sentient beings who, recollecting me, shed tears through the force of the Dharma, whose hair stands on end, or who sigh deeply, Ānanda, will not go to the animal realm or the world of Yama. They will not go to any of the lower realms.

Therefore, Ānanda, strive in heedfulness! Ānanda, the awakening of the buddhas, the blessed ones, is attained through heedfulness, and the other virtuous factors conducive to awakening are likewise attained through heedfulness.

"Ānanda, whatever a teacher should do, whatever one who seeks the good, who seeks others' benefit and happiness, who delights in benefiting them, who is compassionate and loving, should do out of love, all of that I have done. Now you must act so that the path of virtue is by no means cut off, and so that the way of the true Dharma does not decline. Ānanda, act so that this way of the true Dharma lasts for a long time and becomes widespread and vast among gods and humans. Ānanda, I entrust this treasury of the jewel of the Dharma to you, so that it may by no means perish. This is the instruction I give. This is my instruction."

This concludes the twelfth chapter, called "Entrusting the True Dharma."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One (the Buddha), "Blessed One, how should I practice? Blessed One, if I practice in what way will this way of the true Dharma last for a long time and become widespread and vast among gods and humans? Blessed One, how should I compile this Dharma discourse? How should I teach it?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "After my parinirvāṇa, the elder monks will gather and compile the Dharma and the Vinaya. At that time, Ānanda, the elder monks headed by the elder Mahākāśyapa will ask you: 'Ānanda, where did the Tathāgata speak the great teachings? Where did he speak the series of great introductory accounts? Where the great absorption? Where the Fives and the Threes? Where the questions asked by gods? Where the questions asked by Śakra (Indra)? Where the descent from the realm of the gods? Where the questions of Brahmā?' Ānanda, those monks will ask you in these ways.

"'Ānanda, where did the Tathāgata speak the divisions of discourses, the division of teachings in song, the division of expositions, the division of verses, the division of inspired utterances, the division of introductory accounts, the division of legends, the division of accounts beginning "thus it happened," the division of birth stories, the division of extensive teachings, the division of marvelous phenomena, and the division of definitive instructions? Ānanda, where did the Tathāgata speak the Basket of the Śrāvakas? Where did he speak the Basket of the Pratyekabuddhas? Where did he speak the Basket of the Bodhisattvas, the Great Vehicle?'

"Ānanda, when those monks then ask you this, answer them thus:

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One, having first attained perfect and complete awakening, was staying in the land of Magadha at the Seat of

Awakening.'

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying on Mount Gayā.'

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying in the land of Magadha at the foot of the Goatherd's Nyagrodha Tree.'

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying in the land of Vārāṇasī at Ṛṣipatana, in the Deer Park.'

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying at Rājagṛha on Vulture Peak, and on the broad summit of Mount Vaidehaka in Indra's Cave.'

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying at Rājagṛha in the Bamboo Grove, at the Kalandaka Dwelling.'

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying on the slope of Ṛṣigiri, at the Insect Rock.'

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying at Śrāvastī in the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta, the park of Anāthapiṇḍada.'

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying in the land of Vaiśālī in the grove of Āmrapālī, and in the Hall of the Gabled House on the bank of the Monkey Pond.'

"'Likewise, he was staying in the land of Campā on the bank of the pond dug by Gargā. Likewise, he was staying at Gayā on Mount Gayāśīrṣa. Likewise, he was staying in the land of Kauśāmbī at the park of Ghoṣila. He was staying in the land of Abode at the Black Park. He was staying at Pāṭaliputra by the Bahuputraka Shrine. He was staying in the land of Mathurā at the Kukkuṭārāma.'

"'Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying in the city of Kuśinagara, at Upavartana of the Mallas, in the grove of sāla trees.'

"Ānanda, in these ways, wherever the Tathāgata taught the Dharma, to whatever assembly, at whatever time, on the basis of whatever meaning, with reference to whatever person, and in whatever terms he spoke in order to teach whatever wisdom, and whatever terms he spoke by means of whatever meanings, words and letters, all of that you must teach in full, together with its setting, together with its causes, together with its conditions, with good meaning and with good wording. And at the end of each sūtra, write: 'When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the whole assembly rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.' Ānanda, this Dharma discourse should be

compiled in this way. It should be analyzed in this way. It should be taught in this way."

The very moment the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, had spoken the words "Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One," a great earthquake, terrifying and hair-raising, occurred in the world. At that time this great trichiliocosm shook in six ways. It moved, moved strongly, moved strongly everywhere. It rocked, rocked strongly, rocked strongly everywhere. It trembled, trembled strongly, trembled strongly everywhere. It roared, roared strongly, roared strongly everywhere. It was stirred up, stirred up strongly, stirred up strongly everywhere. It crashed, crashed strongly, crashed strongly everywhere. When the east sank, the west rose; when the west sank, the east rose; when the south sank, the north rose; when the north sank, the south rose; when the edges sank, the center rose; and when the center sank, the edges rose.

At that time countless gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras and mahoragas, Śakra, Brahmā and the world guardians, and humans and nonhumans wept bitterly, shedding tears, and spoke these words: "The Blessed One is passing into complete nirvāṇa far too soon! The Sugata is passing into complete nirvāṇa far too soon! The eye of the world is vanishing far too soon! The eye of the world will be gone and the world will become blind far too soon!"

The venerable Ānanda also wept bitterly, shedding tears, and said, "The Blessed One is passing into complete nirvāṇa far too soon! The Sugata is passing into complete nirvāṇa far too soon! The eye of the world is vanishing far too soon! The eye of the world will be gone and the world will become blind far too soon! The world will be left without its guide far too soon!"

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Enough, Ānanda. Do not grieve. Do not lament. Ānanda, whatever has been born and come into being, whatever is made, conditioned, intended, and arisen in dependence, having the nature of perishing, how could it not perish? That is impossible.

"Ānanda, for a long time you have attended upon me with loving action of body, loving action of speech, and loving action of mind, beneficially, pleasantly, without duality, without reservation, without measure, and without harm. Ānanda, you will come to have great power, great splendor, and great vastness; you will become like the deathless, reach the expanse of the deathless, and arrive at the very limit of the deathless.

"Therefore, Ānanda, you should train thus: 'I shall dwell with loving action of body, speech and mind toward my companions in the holy life.' Toward others who practice the holy life, too, you should show the same attentive service. Why is that? Ānanda, after I have passed into complete nirvāṇa, in the later time, in the later age, at the close of the last five hundred years, there will be a time of decline, a time of destruction, a time when monks endowed with moral discipline are wholly exhausted and wholly degenerate, a time when the faction of the undisciplined grows strong, a time when the sacred Dharma wholly degenerates, a time when the side of what is not Dharma prevails, a time when the sacred Dharma is rejected, a time when kings are in turmoil, a time when beings perish, a time of separation from the Dharma, a time of separation from monks, a time of turmoil. When such a time has come, Ānanda, most monks will be undeveloped in body, undeveloped in mind and in moral discipline, and undeveloped in wisdom. Being undeveloped, from body up to wisdom, they will become attached to six things. What are the six? They are these: they will become attached to begging bowls, attached to robes, attached to alms food, attached to bedding and seats, attached to medicines for the sick and to requisites, and attached to fine vessels.

"For the sake of begging bowls they will come to quarrel; becoming contentious, they will dispute and fight with one another with the swords and short spears of their mouths. They will hurl harsh words at one another. They will feel aversion toward one another. Likewise, for the sake of robes, alms food, medicines for the sick and requisites, they will go so far as to feel aversion toward one another. Toward one another they will harbor malice, harbor base thoughts, harbor faithless thoughts, bear resentment, and be filled with thorough malice and faithless thoughts.

"Therefore, Ānanda, whether openly or in private, in subtle matters or in gross ones, in intention or in deed, you should dwell with loving action of body toward your companions in the holy life. You should dwell with loving action of speech and loving action of mind toward your companions in the holy life. Thus, Ānanda, should you train. Why is that? Ānanda, when such a time of great turmoil has come, when there is the degeneration of lifespan, the degeneration of views, the degeneration of afflictions, the degeneration of the age, the degeneration of beings, and the degeneration of the field, then householders too will suffer and fall into suffering. They will be tormented by suffering, tormented by famine, tormented by disease, tormented by death, tormented by bandits and thieves, tormented by drought and by excessive

rain, tormented by the seasons and by sandstorms, and tormented by these and other harms of many kinds.

"Ānanda, those brahmins and householders, suffering in this way and afflicted with suffering, will come to have faith. Having clear faith, and not lacking in discernment, they will have faith in the Buddha out of understanding, and faith in the Dharma and the Saṅgha out of understanding. With minds directed toward the Buddha, minds directed toward the Dharma, and minds directed toward the Saṅgha, some, out of fondness for particular persons, will give gifts; they will make merit; they will keep the poṣadha. Some will take up the bases of training, receive scriptural transmissions, recite them, and also listen to the Dharma. Having listened, they will put it into practice and attain joy, faith, and supreme delight, and they will also produce roots of virtue. Because they possess roots of virtue, when their bodies break up they will be born among the gods in the heavenly world of the happy destinies."

Ānanda, see how perverse that time will have become: even those who have gone forth in faith from home into homelessness will go to the lower realms, while householders living at home, who are suffering and worn down by suffering, will go to good destinies through the root of virtue of a faithful mind.

Ānanda, therefore restrain body, speech, and mind with restraint. Make your mind faithful, grow strong in joy, and have faith, honesty, and an excellent superior intention. Let your bodily action be well considered, your verbal action well considered, and your mental action well considered. And why? Ānanda, a person who does not speak with moderation has five disadvantages. What are the five? He speaks lies, speaks harshly, speaks slander, speaks idle talk, and becomes covetous, and when the body breaks up, after death, he falls into the lower realms, the bad destinies, the abyss, and is reborn among the beings of hell.

Ānanda, a person who speaks with moderation has five benefits. What are the five? He does not speak lies, he has no harsh speech, he has no slander, he has no idle talk, and he becomes free of covetousness, and when the body breaks up he is reborn among the gods in the world of the higher realms, the good destinies. These are the five.

Ānanda, these five disadvantages befall a person who quarrels, finds fault, disputes, wrangles, has a base mind, is full of malice, and has a mind without faith. What are the five? Here, a person who quarrels, and so on up to one whose mind is without faith, speaks lies, slanders, does not give rise to a clear

and faithful mind toward those who possess moral discipline, experiences suffering and unhappiness day and night, and also, when the body breaks up, is reborn among the beings of hell. These are the five.

Ānanda, a person who dwells in loving-kindness has eleven benefits. What are the eleven? Ānanda, here a person who dwells in loving-kindness sleeps happily, wakes happily, does not dream bad dreams, is pleasing to humans and nonhumans, and is protected by the gods. Poison cannot harm him, fire cannot harm him, weapons cannot harm him, and he does not meet his death by water. He obtains robes, food, bedding, medicine for the sick, and other requisites. And even if he has not realized the superhuman qualities, when the body breaks up he is reborn in the world of Brahmā. Ānanda, these are the eleven benefits of a person who dwells in loving-kindness.

Ānanda, therefore, now and after I have passed away, dwell with yourself as your island, yourself as your refuge, the Dharma as your island, the Dharma as your refuge, with no other as your island and no other as your refuge. Ānanda, if one asks how a monk dwells with himself as his island, and so on up to with no other as his island and no other as his refuge: Ānanda, here a monk, ardent, vigilant, and mindful, having dispelled covetousness and dejection toward the world, dwells contemplating the body in the inner body. Ardent, vigilant, and mindful, having dispelled covetousness and dejection toward the world, he dwells contemplating inner feelings, mind, and phenomena. Ānanda, it is in this way that a monk dwells with himself as his island and himself as his refuge, and not with another as his island and another as his refuge.

Ānanda, therefore, whatever a teacher should do for his śrāvakas I have already done; now you must do it. Ānanda, meditate in the wilderness, at the foot of trees, in empty houses, and in the open air. Ānanda, do not be heedless, lest you regret it later. This is my instruction to you.

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The path that, with full knowledge, draws out the dart
I have taught correctly.
The tathāgatas are only teachers;
It is you who must make the effort.

There is no other path
By which the view is purified; this is supreme.
If you practice it, you will cut
The bonds of Māra and be fully liberated.

Those who understand this
Just as the Buddha has explained it,
And who carry out the Teacher's teaching,
Will bring suffering to its end.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda, those monks, that whole assembly, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the thirteenth chapter, on the teaching, from the Dharma discourse of the Great Compassion.

This completes the Great Vehicle sūtra called the White Lotus of Great Compassion.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Śīlendrabodhi and the chief editor and translator, the monk Yeshé Dé.

Translator's Notes

• The phrase rendered "white-lotus waters that flow" is unusual in the list of waters; it may denote lotus pools or be a textual variant, but it is translated as it stands.
• The mountain pair rendered "the Mucilinda and the Great Mucilinda" translates a Tibetan name whose Sanskrit equivalent is not certain; it is identified here by comparison with similar Mahāyāna lists of the world's mountain ranges. A few terms in the list of the beings' calm states are rare and are rendered by sense.
• The phrase rendered "no longer vividly present and no longer manifest" is the Tibetan pair □□□□□□□□□□□□ □□□□□□□□□□□□. It describes the young gods of the sun and moon palaces disappearing, so that the palaces stand empty. The phrase rendered "lowly work" (□□□□□□□□□) literally means "light" work, taken here as petty or menial occupations. The item rendered "yeast" (□□□) is a fermenting agent.
• The term rendered "bonds" is uncertain; the term as written may stand for a related word meaning "fetters" or "bonds." In the list of natural things, the opening term is read as "the elements" rather than the class of spirits called bhūtas, which it denotes in the earlier list of harmful agents.
• The term rendered "conjunctions" may also be read as "fetters" (saṃyojana); in this context it seems to mean the coming together of karma and phenomena. The time units in the list of instants, moments, short spans and brief whiles correspond roughly to kṣaṇa, lava and muhūrta; one of them has no clear standard equivalent and is translated by its meaning. The three words for shining applied to the sun, moon and stars are descriptive words for brilliance.
• The three "forbearances" (kṣānti) attained by bodhisattvas are the standard Mahāyāna stages of acceptance of the Dharma, culminating in acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena. The closing sentence "I am the last person of this" is literal; it likely means the Buddha is the final one of this succession or age in this field, and the sense is not fully certain. "Carakas" and "wandering ascetics" render two classes of non-Buddhist renunciants (Skt. caraka, parivrājaka).
• The sentence "if you rely on this promise and regard it as essential" is grammatically

ambiguous; it may instead mean "since you rely on what is promised and hold it to be essential," that is, the Buddha's general respect for commitments. "I am the last person in this" renders a terse phrase whose precise sense is uncertain. The repeated "buddhafield of the Buddha" reflects a doubled word in the Tibetan.

• The pratyekabuddha's name is given in Tibetan as "the Compassionate One"; a Sanskrit form such as Kāruṇika is plausible but not confirmed, so it is translated by meaning. The phrase rendered "obstructing him wrongfully" is literally "cutting off up to wrongdoing" and is somewhat obscure; the following passage contrasts it with conduct toward the Tathāgata marked by love and free of wrongdoing.

• "Boundless" renders the phrase □□□□□□□□□□, which is difficult as written. It may be a scribal variant of □□□□□□□□ ("immeasurable"); in this reading □□□□ is taken as "pure, solely." The phrase rendered "a great sovereign lord (maheśvara)" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) describes Māra's lordship over the desire realm, not the god Śiva. The pratyekabuddha's name, □□□□□□□□□□□, is translated literally as "the Compassionate One," since its Sanskrit form cannot be confirmed.

• The epithet rendered "holder of the raft" reads □□□□□□□□□□□□□; □□□□□□ ordinarily means "materiality," which does not fit a list of rescuing images (ford, lamp, guide). A vessel or raft sense has been assumed from context; this is uncertain. In Śakra's speech, □□□□□□□ ("remorse") may be a slip for □□□□□□□ ("quarreling"), which appears in the preceding sentence; the text has been translated as written.

• The name of the buddha, rendered in Tibetan as "difficult to approach," is reconstructed as Durāsada; this is a likely but not certain Sanskrit form. The name of his world, "possessing rays," is translated as "Radiant," since its Sanskrit form (perhaps Raśmimatī or similar) could not be confirmed.

• The tathāgata here rendered Durāsada is called in Tibetan "Difficult to Approach"; Durāsada is the usual Sanskrit equivalent of this Tibetan form, but the original name in this sūtra is not attested with certainty. Where the Tibetan reads a form meaning "would not be" in the phrase about sickness, it has been taken as the evident parallel "would not fall ill."

• In the Buddha's words to Rāhula, the Tibetan first says "you have done a father's duty toward me, and I have done a son's duty toward you, my son," and then gives the expected order, "I have done a father's duty, and you have done a son's duty." The first sentence appears inverted, possibly by a copyist, but it has been translated as written. The phrase rendered "through the force of the Dharma" could also mean "through the force of nature," that is, involuntarily.

• In the Buddha's reply to Ānanda, the text reads "become connected" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□), which contradicts the sense of the list. It has been read as "be severed" (□□□□). Similarly, the second fall of Ānanda reads "to the wide" (□□□□□), which has been taken as "to the ground," matching the earlier parallel (□□□). The phrase rendered "offering no comfort" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) reflects the Sanskrit anāśvāsika.

• □□□□□□□□□□ in the list of qualities of Ānanda's service is unusual; rendered "boundless." □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ in the message to the Śākyas is a euphemism for the Buddha's final passing and is rendered accordingly.

• The large numbers are rendered from koṭi counts: ninety-six, ninety-four and ninety-two koṭis, that is 960, 940 and 920 million. The phrase rendered "hundreds of thousands of millions of billions" follows the conventional reading of a Tibetan stock expression for a vast number. Although the Tibetan puts Maitreya's speech and his showing of the body in past-tense or present forms, the frame of the passage is prophetic, so these are rendered in the future.

• The Tibetan names Lofty Peak of Great Slopes, Land Mender, Joyous and the Path park could not be identified with confidence and are translated by meaning. The first may stand for Urumuṇḍa, the mountain near Mathurā associated with Upagupta. "The Reedy" park is

identified as Naṭabhaṭika and "the Excellent" monk as Uttara on the basis of the Mathurā and Pāṭaliputra traditions. Here "Mātṛkā" means the matrices or summaries of the Abhidharma, not the class of goddesses. The figures are read as the Tibetan gives them: ninety-six koṭis of monks, then 44,000, 88,000 and 13,000.

• Several place and personal names could not be identified with confidence and are translated by meaning: the elder "Faithful the Sixth," the city "Golden Measure," the monk "Learned," the city "Abode," the city "Stone Setting," the royal city "Prosperous," and the eon "Excellent Making." Sañjayin and Jaṭila are probable Sanskrit equivalents of standard Tibetan renderings. "Holder of the Mātṛkā" refers here to the doctrinal matrices (the Abhidharma), not to the class of goddesses.

• The householder's name □□□□□□□□ is rendered Dharmavardhana, the usual Sanskrit equivalent; the Sanskrit form in this sūtra is not certain. The tathāgata name □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is given as Vimalaprabha. The world realm "Adorned with All Qualities," the royal capital "Peace," and the city "Where All Trees Grow" are translated from their meanings, since their Sanskrit forms could not be identified with confidence. □□□□□□□ is understood as the quinquennial festival (pañcavārṣika).

• "Filled with those that have passed out of sight" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ literally; the referent is not stated. It most likely means the stūpas, images and relics that have disappeared from the human world and are now enshrined in the realms of gods, nāgas and the rest.

• "Those who receive without restriction" renders the uncertain phrase ma nges par len pa; the intended sense may be "recipients of every kind," that is, of all who receive offerings. In the second list of services the text reads ri mor byed, "make drawings," which makes no sense here; I have followed the evident reading rim gror byed, "serve," which appears in the parallel list just before.

• "Upholder of the Mātṛkā" here refers to the Abhidharma matrices (the third basket beside Sūtra and Vinaya), not to the class of goddesses. The final phrase "with a lot equal to that of humans" most likely means it was reborn as a human being.

• "Even down to a mere quarter of a root" renders the obscure phrase "even merely a fourth root"; the sense seems to be a very small root of virtue, but this is uncertain. The Tathāgata rendered as Roca, last of the thousand buddhas of this eon, is the Tibetan "Möpa"; the identification with the Sanskrit Roca follows the usual Bhadrakalpika list. The term rendered "śramaṇas only in name" is uncertain in the Tibetan.

• In the verse "As I roamed about, again and again," the Tibetan has □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ ("running about, roaming"), which is not the same as the term for wandering ascetics used earlier. It is taken here as the bodhisattva's roaming through births.

• The phrase rendered "split a hundredfold" reads □□□□□□□ ("gone") in the text; the context of the simile requires □□□□□□ ("split"), and it has been translated accordingly. Similarly, □□□□ at the end of chapter nine is read as □□□ ("they say").

• "A hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, the standard Indian large-number formula (koṭi-niyuta-śatasahasra). The "four means of attraction" are generosity, pleasant speech, beneficial conduct, and consistency of conduct.

• The phrase rendered "flawless" describing the field is obscure in the Tibetan and may reflect a scribal variant; the sense of an ideal field is clear from context. In this passage □□□□ is taken as the common noun "teachers" or "superiors," as the context of revering elders and parents requires, rather than as the personal name Uttara used earlier in the text.

• In the opening sentence □□□□ is taken as "teachers" (superiors worthy of offerings) rather than as the proper name Uttara used earlier, since a list of recipients of gifts is meant here.

• "The beating of drums" renders □□□□□□□□□□, whose exact instrument (drum, cymbal or clapping) is uncertain.

• The buddha named in the verses, rendered Prabhākara, is in Tibetan literally "Light-Maker"; it may alternatively be read as an epithet of a buddha rather than a personal name.
• The phrase rendered "for the sake of this very incalculable goal" reads literally "for the sake of this very incalculable [one]"; the implied noun is unstated, presumably awakening. The Sanskrit for □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ ("Gone Very High") is reconstructed as Atyuccagāmin, a past buddha known from the Mahāvastu lists; the identification is likely but not certain. □□□□□□□□□□□□ in the verse ("bull of the Śākyas") refers to the earlier buddha Śākyamuni of this list.
• The clause rendered "what need, then, to speak of putting them into words?" is elliptical in the Tibetan. The sense seems to be that the Buddha's hardships are beyond belief, still more beyond full verbal description. "Compassion for even as long as a single four-line verse" renders the idiom of the four-line verse as a measure of the slightest amount. "The spaces between the worlds" renders the Tibetan for the dark regions between world systems (lokāntarika).
• The deathless nectar renders the Tibetan for amṛta, which here also evokes the "deathless" state of nirvāṇa. "The experience of taste" is a literal rendering; the intended sense in this list of grounds for recollecting the Tathāgata is not fully clear.
• The text reads "dag gi las kyis," which makes little sense here; it is translated as "ngag gi las kyis," "in words" (literally "by verbal action"), the evident reading.
• Here □□□□□□□□ is used generically for a caravan leader in a simile, and as an epithet of the Buddha ("great caravan leader"), so it is translated rather than given as the name Sārthavāha. The large numeral □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (koṭi-niyuta-śatasahasra) is rendered approximately as "hundreds of thousands of ten millions of trillions."
• Here □□□□ is the Mātṛkā, the "matrix" or Abhidharma section of the scriptures listed beside the sūtras and the Vinaya. It is not the class of mother goddesses given in the glossary.
• The phrase rendered "the treasurers" is uncertain; the Tibetan literally suggests "those changed or exchanged by gold," perhaps gold-keepers or financiers who hold the royal wealth alongside the householders.
• "Noble one" renders □□□□□□, literally "one who knows," which is likely the standard rendering of Sanskrit ājāneya ("thoroughbred, of noble breed"), an epithet of awakened beings. The phrase "he makes offerings as gods and humans do" is grammatically ambiguous; it may instead mean that he has gods and humans make offerings.
• The piece opens in mid-sentence; the comparison it begins (all pratyekabuddhas purifying the householder's offering, set against a single Tathāgata) is completed within the piece. "Purifying the offering" renders the technical notion of a worthy recipient making a gift fruitful (dakṣiṇāviśuddhi). The sentence comparing offerings to pratyekabuddhas and to "those such as me" is terse, and I have read its comparative particle as setting the two kinds of offering against each other.
• The large numbers are rendered by their usual values (koṭi as ten million, so "a billion" for a hundred koṭis, etc.); the final term □□□□□□□□ is taken as nayuta. The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is understood as "taking it merely as a supposition," marking the scenario as hypothetical. Here □□□□□ and □□□□ are ordinary words ("conviction," "peaceful"), not the names used elsewhere in the text.
• The phrase rendered "makes the Dharma a matter of vital concern" translates an obscure Tibetan expression, literally "making it like bone-wood." It appears to correspond to the Pāli and Sanskrit idiom of "making it one's very bones," that is, attending with utmost concern. The clause saying that beings are "more than the element of earth, water, fire, or wind" is literally "not the earth element, not the water element," and so on. It is understood here as a comparison of number. The term rendered "distress" ends the standard series from birth

through aging, death, sorrow and so on, which is abridged here with "and so on up to."
• The four ways of gathering disciples (saṃgrahavastu) are rendered here as generosity, pleasant speech, beneficial conduct, and consistency of purpose. "All the way to the Dharma in accordance with the Dharma" interprets the phrase about concordant dharmas as the standard expression dharmānudharma.
• "The Fives and the Threes" renders the Tibetan literally. It probably refers to numerically arranged collections of discourses, but this is uncertain.

The place given as "the broad summit of Mount Vaidehaka" could also be read as "Mount Vaidehaka above Vaiśālī." The Pāli parallel places Indra's Cave on Mount Vediyaka near Rājagṛha, so the Tibetan word is taken here in its ordinary sense of "broad."

"Insect Rock" translates the Tibetan literally. The parallel site on Ṛṣigiri (Pāli Isigili) is usually the Black Rock (Kālaśilā), and I could not securely identify the Sanskrit name behind this rendering.
• The phrase rendered "by the seasons and by sandstorms" is literally "by time and by sand"; its exact sense is uncertain. The text lists six degenerations (adding "the field" to the usual five), and this is kept as written. "Not lacking in discernment" renders a double negative whose precise force is somewhat unclear.
• The phrase rendered "superhuman qualities" is the technical term uttaramanuṣyadharma, the higher spiritual attainments beyond ordinary human states. It is not the proper name Uttara used earlier in the text. The list of five disadvantages of immoderate speech actually names six items as the Tibetan stands; it has been translated as written.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.